OPINION

THIS IS WHAT I ASKED

These are two drafts of a novel of mine. I was tempted to explain my intention. What I was hoping the novel gives the reader. I now realise it should, like any book, speak for itself. I will thus limit my ask to the following - Please look through both carefully and tell me if one holds up more than the other. If it delivers a better experience for the reader. I purposely keep that vague. "Better" can be so many different things. I know which one I want but sometimes the "best" is something one never intended nor imagined. Your feedback is not be an either-or unless it is the case that one outshines the other entirely. Otherwise, explain what parts of which you prefer. Not in a vacuum but if implemented into a third draft with a. which parts from the other and b. things in neither that out to be included or redone. Consider the macroscopic - story arc, plot, pacing, general reader experience, stylistic consistency, clarity, emotional journey, character development, and the like - as well as the microscopic - down to specific parts which could be better or parts where, for example, sentence one and two and five and eight from the second draft work with sentences three and four and six and seven from the first. Go as comprehensive as you can. Don't hold back. If any of this is unclear, let me know prior to your read. Thank you.

REPLY CG I

The verdict

The blunt version is this:

QATAMON occasionally has the better sentence. Polish has the better book.

That is the core judgement. Not because **Polish** wins every page. It does not. Not because **QATAMON** is a failed draft. It is not. But when I step back from the sentence and look at the novel as a novel — story arc, moral pressure, pacing of consequence, emotional accumulation, use of character, and what the ending leaves behind in the reader — **Polish** is stronger.

The first twelve chapters are close enough that I can imagine a third draft being built from either. The decisive divergence comes later, especially in **Chapters XVIII–XIX**. That is where **Polish** proves it understands the novel more completely.

Why Polish holds up better

The main reason is **moral pressure**.

In **Polish**, the note reaches Maryam **too late**, but it does reach her. She reads it. She carries it. She hides it. Then she is moved while carrying it. That is better fiction than the **QATAMON** version where the note comes back unopened and ends up under the mug on the sill. The image in **QATAMON** is good. The plot choice is weaker. It lets circumstance do too much of the tragic work. **Polish** lets history obstruct, but it does not let history absolve. That is the harder and better choice.

That one decision improves several things at once.

It makes **Maryam** better, because she becomes more implicated. She is not merely thwarted by the city; she is also carrying knowledge, concealment, hesitation, and refusal. That makes her morally more difficult, which is exactly what the novel needs.

It makes **Hanna** better, because his competence is no longer just competence. It becomes tragic pressure. He is organising, timing, arranging, carrying, instructing — all while the reader knows there is already something hidden moving through the house with Maryam. When he says, **"I have given you five more minutes,"** the line lands in both drafts, but in **Polish** it lands after concealment has already entered the room. That is far stronger construction.

It also makes the whole object-system work harder. Both drafts understand objects well: papers, spoons, stockings, rugs, cups, cases, keys, maps, bedsteads, shutters. But **Polish** is better at making those things do actual narrative labour. By the late book, even the act of deciding **what gets carried** becomes moral action. That is where the novel becomes itself.

Story arc, pacing, and reader experience

The real plot in both drafts is not event-heavy in the crude sense. The novel is not driven by twists. It is driven by **narrowing**: narrowing room, narrowing choices, narrowing time, narrowing moral space. That means the novel lives or dies by whether the late chapters make earlier tensions feel retroactively inevitable. **Polish** does that better.

The opening is strong in both. The house of condolence chapter works. The domestic order correcting itself for grief is immediately convincing, and the early world is well made. The middle stretch in both drafts is intelligent and atmospherically controlled. The danger there is not incompetence. The danger is **uniform excellence**: too many scenes are written at a similarly polished temperature. Sometimes both drafts could use one more blunt, plain, unadorned move where the prose stops being clever and simply strikes. But when the novel reaches its late turn, **Polish** uses that accumulated control more effectively. It cashes in the pressure. **QATAMON** sometimes preserves atmosphere where the novel really needs consequence.

So in terms of general reader experience:

- **QATAMON** often feels cleaner sentence by sentence.
- **Polish** feels more earned chapter by chapter.
- By the end, **Polish** leaves the stronger after-effect. It asks more of the reader because it has asked more of the characters.

Where QATAMON is better

This is not an either-or judgement in which **QATAMON** has nothing to offer. It has real advantages, and you should steal them.

Its chief virtue is **restraint**.

When **Polish** is worse, it is worse in a specific way: it lands a good sentence, then half-explains it, then nudges the reader towards the interpretation. **QATAMON** sometimes has the discipline to stop earlier. That helps.

Specific places where I prefer **QATAMON**:

In **Chapter IV**, the shorter Nawal phrasing is better:
"Nawal had the irritating gift of hearing arrangement inside arranged sentences."
That is clean. It does the work and gets out.

In **Chapter XIII**, keep the **QATAMON** version of the mug and repetition:
"A mug suggested habit. The first dangerous thing in an affair was not touch. It was repetition."
That is better than the more spread-out handling in **Polish**. It is sharper and more exact.

In **Chapter XVIII**, the **Tariq waiting** material in **QATAMON** is excellent. The flat, the shutter, the waiting, the city's obstruction, the fatigue of trying again — all of that is vivid and persuasive. I would keep the **scene-material**. I would not keep the **final plot function** of the note remaining unopened as the novel's settled version of events.

In **Chapter XX**, the opening is better in **QATAMON**:
"It had. That was the first betrayal."
That lands harder than the **Polish** opening, which is a little more mannered.

And **"Less Room Than Before"** is a better Chapter XIV title than **"After."** The former contains pressure. The latter is too vague.

So yes: **QATAMON** has cleaner steel in places. But it loses the larger structural argument.

Where Polish is clearly better

There are places where I would not hesitate.

In **Chapter I**, the vanity ending is stronger in **Polish**: **"But hating herself had not altered the fall of the skirt. Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners."** That is finished prose. It has edge, rhythm, and exactness without overplaying itself.

The affair material is better in **Polish** overall. Not because every line is better, but because the **scene** is better. It is awkward, materially inconvenient, faintly dusty, faintly humiliating, practical in all the wrong ways. Good. That is what the scene should be. The moment that material turns lush or conventionally romantic, the book becomes more ordinary.

The ending of **Chapter XVIII** in **Polish** — the note on the coverlet and the case on the chair — is one of the strongest pieces in either version. Keep it.

Chapter XIX in **Polish** is simply stronger fiction. The note under the stockings is better than the unopened envelope under the mug. The latter is a good image. The former is a good novelistic choice.

Character work

Maryam

Polish gives her the better shape. She becomes less merely perceptive and more morally implicated. That is crucial. A perceptive heroine is not enough. She needs to be compromised by what she knows and what she withholds. **Polish** does that better.

Hanna

One of the best assets in the whole book. He is not there merely to be the husband-shaped obstacle to a more interesting emotional story. He is interesting in his own right because competence, order, and allocation are his forms of love. In **Polish**, that becomes tragic rather than merely dutiful. He is better used there.

Tariq

He occasionally benefits from **QATAMON**'s restraint. In that draft, some of his waiting and observational material feels less arranged to signify. That is good. The risk with Tariq in both drafts is that he can become a little too curated: exact, pressed, thoughtful, attractive, morally legible. He needs one slightly awkward or mildly selfish edge somewhere to stop feeling too composed by the novel.

Amina and Aunt Widad

Very good in both. They are not side furniture. They are part of the novel's intelligence. Amina grounds everything in labour and bodily fact. Aunt Widad turns love into management. Both are necessary counterweights to Maryam's more reflective register. Keep that balance.

Stylistic consistency and clarity

Both drafts are highly controlled. That is a strength until it starts flattening distinctions.

The largest stylistic problem shared by both drafts is **voice compression**. Too many people can produce very polished, quotable thought. Maryam, Tariq, Amina, Aunt Widad, even Father Elias at times — all can sound like variations of the same refined narrative intelligence. Not all the time, but enough to notice. The third draft should widen those separations. Maryam can keep the most essayistic inward language. Hanna should be driest and most allocative. Amina should remain most rooted in matter and timing. Aunt Widad should be managerial rather than lyrical. Tariq should be most exact when observing or classifying, not when sounding generally wise.

The other style issue is this: **Polish** sometimes says an intelligent thing twice. **QATAMON** sometimes stops too soon. The third draft should split the difference: keep the clarity where the novel genuinely needs causal and emotional legibility, but cut any sentence whose only function is to reassure the reader that the scene has a theme. The book is strongest when the meaning lives in the object, the gesture, the placement, the delay, the bag, the cup, the case, the shutter, the stocking, the bed.

What I would do for a third draft

1. **Use Complete First Draft Polish as the base manuscript.** Do not reverse this. If you start from **QATAMON**, you will spend the revision restoring the better late-book decisions.
2. **Keep the Polish structure for Chapters XVIII–XIX.** This is the decisive point. Maryam should receive the note late, carry it, fail it, hide it, and be moved while carrying it. That is the strongest version of the novel's moral architecture.
3. **Import the Tariq-waiting material from QATAMON into the Polish late structure.** Keep the shutter, the waiting, the obstructed roads, the tired returns, the atmosphere of delay. But do not let that become the final reason the note never matters. Let the city hinder delivery, not erase responsibility.
4. **Keep the Polish affair scene, but steal QATAMON's cleaner lines inside it.** The scene in **Polish** is better built. The line-level compression in **QATAMON** is sometimes better. Combine them.

5. **Use the QATAMON Chapter XX opening, then return to Polish. "It had. That was the first betrayal."** That opening is better. Keep it.
6. **Rename Chapter XIV. "Less Room Than Before"** is better than **"After."**
7. **Trim Polish anywhere it interprets what the scene has already made clear.** Not wholesale. Selectively. The book is intelligent enough already. It does not need to keep proving it.
8. **Do not add more overt historical exposition.** The current seepage method is right: lorries, delays, checked roads, watched streets, altered errands, shifted rooms, bureaucratic frictions. That is how politics should enter this book. More explicit explanation would flatten it.

What neither draft fully solves yet

The biggest unresolved issue in both is **differentiation of voice**, as above.

The second is that **Hanna wants one more exposed line or gesture**. Not a speech. Absolutely not a speech. One moment of visible crack, fatigue, or private hurt that is not fully armoured by competence. He is already strong. One small fracture would make him devastating.

The third is that **Tariq needs a less curated edge**. Not vulgarity. Not stupidity. Just one place where he is not so entirely controlled by his own significance.

The fourth is that both drafts could stand a few more moments of **plainness at impact points**. The prose is often beautiful and exact. Good. But there are places where beauty itself becomes the buffer. Occasionally the book should stop arranging itself and simply hit.

Bottom line

If the aim is the strongest novel, the answer remains the same:

Base draft: Complete First Draft Polish.
Raid draft: QATAMON.

Why? Because **Polish** has the better late-book decisions, the better use of Maryam's complicity, the better use of Hanna, the better moral architecture, and the stronger overall reader after-effect. **QATAMON** should not be discarded; it should be pillaged for restraint, for cleaner cuts, for certain sharper lines, for parts of Tariq's waiting material, for the Chapter XX opening, and for the better Chapter XIV title. But it should not be the foundation.

The simplest true summary is this:

Polish understands the novel more fully. QATAMON sometimes phrases it better. The third draft should keep Polish's architecture and use QATAMON as a knife.

REPLY CG II

Epistemic status: **not guessing**. I re-read the corrected files. This is the corrected version of the comprehensive comparison, not the earlier one that was thrown off by bad pagination. Both drafts already have the same twenty-chapter spine, including **Chapter XX, "The Key"**. That narrows the gap. It does **not** change the winner.

Revised verdict

QATAMON is still the better draft.

But the reason is now narrower and cleaner.

This is **not** a case of one draft having real structure and the other lacking it. The first draft is already a serious, mature novel. Through about Chapter XVII the two versions are very close in architecture, tone, and effect. By my count from the corrected .docx files, *QATAMON* is only about four thousand words shorter overall, and most of that reduction lands exactly where it matters: **Chapters XVIII and XIX**, with **Chapter XX** slightly fuller rather than smaller. So the difference is not that *QATAMON* invented the book. The difference is that it **re-engineered the last movement more intelligently**.

That is the whole thing in one sentence:

The first draft is already strong. QATAMON is stronger where the novel most needs strength.

What I was wrong about before

I was wrong to treat **"The Key"** as if it were a second-draft invention. It is not. The first draft already has it, and it already opens with the excellent line, **"By morning the room no longer looked borrowed. It looked used, which was worse."** That means the first draft was more formally controlled than I first credited.

So the corrected reading is not:

rough first draft / finished second draft

It is:

strong first draft / better-executed second draft

That distinction matters.

Why QATAMON still wins

The decisive gain is still the handling of **The Note** and **Five More Minutes**.

In the first draft, the late emotional image is superb. You have the note on the coverlet, the case on the chair, and the line: **"One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early."** That is a very good line. It is not decorative. It lands. The problem is that it keeps the tragedy primarily within Maryam's room. It is intimate, lyrical, and exact — but still intimate.

In *QATAMON*, the mechanism is harsher and better. The note is returned **unopened**, Tariq puts it **under the mug**, and the book states the real governing fact: **"The city had placed itself between the note and its reader."** That is the stronger tragic design because it shifts the book out of a private missed meeting and into historical severance. The first draft says, in effect, *she missed him*. *QATAMON* says *history missed them for her*. That is the better novel.

The other crucial gain is the opening of Chapter XIX. In the first draft, XIX begins with Maryam waking to the note still on the coverlet and the case still on the chair; the emotional continuity is strong, but the chapter is overloaded because it has to carry the missed note, the packing, the departure, and the first displacement all at once. In *QATAMON*, XIX begins with **"After breakfast Maryam packed her mother's case with the sensation of committing small thefts."** That is cleaner. The chapter begins where it ought to begin: with the practical violence of leaving. The note is no longer clogging the doorway into the next chapter because *QATAMON* has already lodged it elsewhere, with Tariq, the mug, and the city.

That is why the pacing improves. The first draft's ending is not clumsy, but it is **crowded**. *QATAMON* redistributes the weight.

And then there is the final cruelty: in the first draft, Maryam knows about the note and carries it under the stockings; in *QATAMON*, Maryam does **not** know the note was written, delayed, returned unopened, and placed under the mug. The reader knows. She does not. That asymmetry is more brutal than the first draft's lyric sadness. It leaves a colder aftertaste. It is also truer to the novel's historical logic.

So the core verdict stands:

the first draft produces a beautiful missed connection
QATAMON produces a tragedy

Story arc, plot, pacing, reader experience

On the large scale, both versions already have the same good architecture: Yusef's death leads to papers; papers lead to the flat; the flat leads to Tariq; proximity leads to attachment; the quarter narrows; private desire is overtaken by public collapse. That design was already there. What *QATAMON* does is make the final conversion from personal story to historical inevitability more exact.

The chapter retitling in the middle is also a genuine improvement. I prefer **"The Half-Emptied Flat"** and **"Less Room Than Before"** to **"The Price of Seeing"** and **"After."** The newer titles speak the book's true language: less room, diminished space, domestic contraction. They belong to the novel's governing method more deeply than the earlier titles do.

The line **"Qatamon was not emptying, not yet. It was narrowing."** is central, and it exists in the corrected files. That matters because it names the real method of the novel. Catastrophe does not arrive here as speech or manifesto. It arrives as constriction: roads, latches, keys, blankets, rooms, routes, timings. That is one of the book's major strengths in both versions. *QATAMON* simply lets that logic govern the ending more completely.

The one broad weakness that still remains in **both** drafts is middle-book tonal evenness. Not a sag, exactly. More a prolonged steadiness. The prose is good enough that the reader will continue, but the central body of the novel lives for a long time in one controlled frequency: papers, rooms, visits, errands, timing, concealment, practical arrangements. That is the book's method, yes. It still wants one or two more tonal jolts in the middle third.

Character work

Maryam

Maryam remains the book's central achievement. Without her exactness, the novel dies. Both drafts have her. The second draft just interferes with her slightly less.

Hanna

Hanna is one of the best things in the novel. Do **not** sentimentalise him. His decency is administrative. His love takes the form of prevention, sequence, envelopes, routes, certificates, latches, blankets, timings. That is far more interesting than an overtly tender husband would be. He is frighteningly useful, and the novel is right to let usefulness in him read as both care and pressure.

Amina

Amina is indispensable. Every time she appears, the novel gains class intelligence, labour intelligence, and moral intelligence. The pantry scene remains one of the best scenes in either draft. The second draft's version is cleaner overall, but the first draft still contains one of the rawest sentence-level beats in the whole comparison: **"That was what made it dirty. Not romance. Labour."** In *QATAMON*, this becomes the tighter **"What made it dirty was labour."** On balance, the second draft paragraph is better built, but the first draft's last three-beat snap may actually hit harder. That is exactly the sort of sentence-level salvage worth considering for a third draft.

Tariq

Tariq is stronger in *QATAMON* mainly because the late machinery stops reducing him to the object of a missed encounter. The returned note, the mug, the silence, the unknown onward fate — all of that makes him more fully part of the same historical trap as everyone else.

Style and prose

The prose is strong in both. The danger is not weak writing. The danger is **over-finished writing**.

The first draft occasionally explains a beat after it has already landed. *QATAMON* is better at stopping one sentence earlier.

A clean example comes in Chapter I. The first draft gives you: **"But hating herself had not altered the fall of the skirt. Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners."** *QATAMON* gives you: **"The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely learned better manners."** That is a real improvement. It trims the extra preparation and keeps the sting.

But the first draft still wins some isolated sentence fights.

The obvious one is: **“That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no.”** That is better than the second draft’s smoother paraphrase. It is stranger, harsher, and more memorable. Keep it.

I also prefer the first draft’s **“Death, she thought, had not created grandeur. It had created work.”** The *QATAMON* version — **“had created no grandeur, only work”** — is cleaner, but the first draft’s two-step sentence bites harder. Keep that one too.

So the sentence-level truth is this:

QATAMON is usually better at trimming
the first draft still contains a few better blows

What to keep, what to steal, what to redo

Do **not** make a diplomatic 50/50 blend. That would weaken the book.

Build the third draft on **QATAMON**.

Keep from QATAMON

1. The late-book mechanics: returned unopened note, note under the mug, Maryam not knowing, Chapter XIX starting with packing, and the cleaner distribution of late loss.
2. The retitled middle chapters: **“The Half-Emptied Flat”** and **“Less Room Than Before.”**
3. The general policy of sentence-level tightening.
4. The fuller sense that the city, not merely the lovers, is making the last decision.

Steal back from the first draft

1. **“Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no.”**
2. **“Death, she thought, had not created grandeur. It had created work.”**
3. Possibly the Amina beat: **“That was what made it dirty. Not romance. Labour.”** but only if you can insert it without re-importing the first draft’s heavier scaffolding.
4. The force of **“One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early.”** — but **not** by restoring the old scene construction. That line belongs to a weaker late mechanism. If it returns, it should return in altered form or altered placement.

What neither draft fully solves

1. The middle third needs one or two more temperature changes.

2. Maryam and Tariq sometimes speak on too uniformly polished a wavelength. One or two scenes could stand more abrasion or awkwardness.
3. A final pass should reduce the habit of landing the image and then adding one last abstracting sentence after it.

Bottom line

Here is the corrected blunt version.

The first draft is **better than I first said**.
It was already more mature, more structured, and more finished than the bad pagination suggested.
But **QATAMON is still the better book** because the place where it improves is the place that matters most: the final movement, where private feeling, practical action, and historical pressure have to lock together without slack.

So the right third draft is still:

QATAMON as the spine
with
a small, ruthless smuggling operation from the first draft

Not a merger. Not an average. Not a compromise.

The first draft is better at a handful of individual wounds.
QATAMON is better at the design of the wound.

That is why it wins.

REPLY C I

QATAMON: Chapter-by-Chapter Comparison for Third Draft

Both drafts contain twenty chapters. The same architecture. The same arc. The differences are at sentence level, paragraph level, and — crucially — in Chapters XVIII–XX, where the two drafts diverge in a way that alters the emotional meaning of the ending.

Word counts are near-identical in most chapters. Draft A is 76,324 words total; Draft B is 72,076. Draft A is longer in almost every chapter, but the differences are marginal (50–250 words) until Chapters XVIII and XIX, where Draft A is substantially longer.

CHAPTER I — The House of Condolence

Word count: A = 4,881 | B = 4,624

Both are superb. The differences are surgical.

Opening paragraph. Draft A: "had one not known that Uncle Yusef was lying no longer in his flat but in the mortuary room at the church." Draft B: "if Uncle Yusef had not been lying in the mortuary room at the church." Draft A's "lying no longer in his flat" adds a spatial contrast — the absence from one place before naming the presence in another. It earns its extra words. **Use Draft A.**

Maryam in the doorway. Draft A: "not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private." Draft B drops "not because she was overcome." Draft B is right — the negative clause is unnecessary scaffolding. The reader doesn't need to be told what the pause isn't. **Use Draft B.**

Vanity line. Draft A: "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners." Draft B: "The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely learned better manners." Draft A's version is the stronger construction — the paradox is contained in a single sentence, the semicolon doing real work. Draft B splits it and loses the snap. **Use Draft A.**

"The no." Draft A: "That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no." Draft B: "What stayed with her was not the stroke or the doctor, only the fact that no one had been with him." Draft B is better. Draft A's fragmented version tries to be dramatic; Draft B states the plain fact and lets it cut. "The no" as a standalone is a writerly gesture that calls attention to itself. **Use Draft B.**

Death editing. Draft A: "death did not merely close a life; it edited it." Draft B: "death edited a life as much as it ended one." Draft B is more organic, less epigrammatic. It sounds like thought rather than aphorism. **Use Draft B.**

Amina's work ethic. Draft A: "She never wasted an answer when work could be used as an answer instead." Draft B: "She never wasted an answer when work would serve in its place." Draft A's "used as an answer instead" has a slight mechanical quality. Draft B's "serve in its place" is quieter. Marginal. **Either works; slight edge to Draft B.**

The city entering houses. Draft A: "This was how the city entered houses now. Not in speeches. In altered expectations." Draft B: "This was how the city entered houses now: through altered expectations, not speeches." Draft B's colon and reordering is tighter. **Use Draft B.**

Hanna and prevention. Draft A: "That was Hanna entire. Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention." This line does not appear in Draft B in this form. It is one of the best single sentences in the novel. **Ensure this survives into Draft C.**

Chapter ending. Nearly identical. Both end with "tomorrow would belong to papers." Both work.

CHAPTER II — Uncle Yusef's Flat

Word count: A = 3,633 | B = 3,600

Very close throughout. The Tariq entrance scene is identical in both. A few micro-differences:

Leila's question. "Will he know where we put him?" — identical in both drafts and perfect in both.

Tariq's first observation about the biscuit tin. Both versions contain the same deduction about Yusef's filing habits. The dialogue is virtually identical. No meaningful difference.

The patched cuff. Draft A: "The inner wrist of one sleeve had been patched neatly enough that the patch had almost become part of the cloth." Identical in both. No change needed.

CHAPTER III — Claims

Word count: A = 3,008 | B = 2,783

Draft A is ~225 words longer. The chapter deals with Hanna's management of Yusef's estate and the first encounters with municipal bureaucracy.

The extra words in Draft A are largely in transitional passages. Draft B trims connective tissue without losing content. **Use Draft B as base for this chapter** — it is tighter without sacrificing anything essential.

CHAPTER IV — Mrs Farah

Word count: A = 2,902 | B = 2,813

The Mrs Farah observation scene — her remark about Maryam and the schoolmaster — is handled nearly identically. Both capture the quarter's surveillance mechanism well. Draft A has slightly more interior reflection from Maryam; Draft B lets the scene do more of the work. **Use Draft B as base; harvest any particularly strong interior lines from Draft A.**

CHAPTER V — Papers and Pretexts

Word count: A = 3,882 | B = 3,600

The Habib's shop scene and the walk with Tariq. Draft A opens differently ("On Monday morning the house resumed itself with the effort of a body trying to remember posture after illness") while Draft B opens with a sharper first line ("The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast."). **Draft B's opening is better** — it announces the chapter's theme in one stroke.

The stationer's scene plays out similarly in both, but Draft B gives it slightly more texture in the dialogue between Maryam and Tariq over the insurance sheet. The line about "faithfulness to consequences" — Tariq's observation about Hanna — appears in both drafts but is better set up in Draft B because the preceding exchange is tighter.

Use Draft B as base.

CHAPTER VI — The Radio

Word count: A = 4,604 | B = 4,432

The UN partition vote. Both drafts handle this well. The chapter contains Khalil's introduction, the radio scene, the map, and Tariq's staying for lunch. Nearly identical in structure.

Tariq staying. Draft A: "Not only because of the radio." Draft B: same line, same placement. Works identically in both.

Khalil's entrance. Draft A: "He entered as outer weather rather than household disturbance." Strong line, present in both drafts.

Leila and the map. "Why have they left the middle blank?" — identical in both. One of the novel's best child lines.

Amina on pencils. "Because men are ambitious with pencils" — identical. Perfect.

Both drafts are strong here. Draft B trims about 170 words, mostly from transitions. **Use Draft B as base; check Draft A for any lost phrasing.**

CHAPTER VII — The Wrong Reasons

Word count: A = 4,015 | B = 3,903

The Sunday after the vote. Maryam's failure to visit Nawal at the Semiramis. This is where the novel's mechanism of delay — respectable, social, collective — first becomes fully visible.

The Mrs Farah churchyard scene and the mother's "hotels must be impossible" are identical in both drafts.

The long paragraph about how "the whole structure of a house like theirs was designed to make self-directed motion feel slightly theatrical unless justified by unanimity" appears in both. It is essential. Keep it.

Amina's line. "You have not gone. / It became difficult. / In this house everything becomes difficult if left till afternoon." — identical in both. Keep.

Draft A's version is slightly more expansive in the final section about the hotel card remaining beneath the bank draft. Draft B trims without losing the point. **Use Draft B as base.**

CHAPTER VIII — Amina Covers

Word count: A = 3,544 | B = 3,505

The second Beirut letter, the afternoon at Habib's, Amina's cover story. Both drafts handle the stationer's scene and the tram stop with Tariq similarly. The cover story — Amina telling the room that Habib kept Maryam because the machine jammed — is in both drafts.

The pantry scene. Draft A: Amina cleans the ink from Maryam's cuff. Draft B: same scene, same dialogue. "If your mother sees that on the table linen she will speak of it for three days."

"What made it dirty was labour." This sentence appears in Draft B but not Draft A. It is the chapter's thesis in five words. **Ensure it survives into Draft C.**

Both drafts end with Maryam's admission: "She had not wanted the hour to end quickly." **Use Draft B as base** for the "labour" line and the slightly cleaner final section.

CHAPTER IX — Semiramis

Word count: A = 4,979 | B = 4,939

The explosion and Nawal's death. Nearly identical in both drafts, line for line. This is the novel's hinge and it works with devastating force in both versions.

Leila's line. "Then you cannot visit tomorrow." Identical. Devastating in both.

Amina and the hat. "I knew her hat. / The brown one with the pin she wore crooked." Identical. One of the novel's best passages.

"My dear—" Maryam's abandoned letter. The torn notepaper. Both drafts handle this identically.

No meaningful difference between drafts. Use either as base.

CHAPTER X — After Semiramis

Word count: A = 3,600 | B = 3,619

Draft B is actually 19 words longer here — the only chapter where B exceeds A. The aftermath of the explosion, the hall table accumulating papers, the connection between Nawal's death and Nadia's letters from Beirut. Both are very close.

Use Draft B.

CHAPTER XI — Tariq's Mother

Word count: A = 3,048 | B = 3,029

The chapter giving Tariq's domestic world — his mother's health, his teaching, Khalil. Both drafts are near-identical here. This is the chapter I noted earlier as important for giving Tariq dimensionality beyond Maryam's perception.

Note for Draft C: This chapter could bear slight expansion — not of Tariq's feelings toward Maryam, but of the pressure from his own contracting world. His mother's cough, Khalil's concern about the tram routes, the school under strain. A few more sentences showing the cost on his side would prevent the novel from being solely Maryam's story.

CHAPTER XII — Thinning Rooms

Word count: A = 3,445 | B = 3,362

Huda and Ibrahim moving in, the house filling. Both drafts open identically ("The first room to go was the spare room"). The domestic compression is well handled in both.

Draft B's ending is stronger. Draft A ends with the "Amina---" / "No" exchange and the cedar dust. Draft B ends with Maryam trying to say "Hanna" and failing, then the dream of narrowing rooms: "each door opened not onto another chamber but onto a narrower version of the one before." **Use Draft B's ending.**

CHAPTER XIII — The Price of Seeing (A) / The Half-Emptied Flat (B)

Word count: A = 4,319 | B = 4,237

Title. "The Half-Emptied Flat" is better. "The Price of Seeing" announces its theme too loudly; the flat's physical state is the chapter's real subject and its metaphor works without being named. **Use Draft B's title.**

The consummation scene is nearly identical in both drafts. The material details — the hat pin, the iron bed, the cedar blanket, the glove under the bed — are present in both. The key differences:

Draft A: "The first kiss was not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable. It was a mistake recognised as itself while being committed and continued because recognition had arrived too late to save either of them from truth."

Draft B: "The kiss, when it came, was recognised as a mistake even as it continued."

Draft B is leaner. But Draft A's "continued because recognition had arrived too late to save either of them from truth" earns its length — it adds a moral dimension Draft B's brevity loses. **Use Draft A's version of this sentence, but trim "not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable" — the negatives are unnecessary. Start at "It was a mistake recognised..."**

The Amina pantry scene — cedar dust, button, coat — is virtually identical in both. "Cedar dust shows on dark wool if one knows where to look." Identical. Keep.

"He was impossible in many of the ways men become charming only because they are not one's husband." This Hanna line (from Chapter I) echoes here. Both drafts preserve the echo. Good.

Use Draft B as base with Draft A's consummation sentence (trimmed).

CHAPTER XIV — After (A) / Less Room Than Before (B)

Word count: A = 3,918 | B = 3,853

Title. "Less Room Than Before" is better. "After" is vague. The B title carries the chapter's double meaning — physical space and moral space. **Use Draft B's title.**

These chapters are very close. Both contain: the morning after, Amina's coat brush, the street encounter with Tariq and Khalil alongside Huda, Hanna's conversation with Huda through the half-open door, and the bedtime exchange "Less room than before. But room."

Huda's line. "The schoolmaster has less patience in his face than before." / "The whole city has less." / "That is not what I said." — identical in both. Perfect triangulation.

Hanna through the door. "Then we will know more in a month than we know now." — identical.

Amina's line. "In houses, most things are." — present in both drafts. One of the novel's best.

The only notable difference: Draft B has a slightly fuller passage about Maryam hearing Hanna's kindness through the half-open door: "It was perhaps the most practical form of tenderness she had ever known, and because it arrived without heat she had spent years mistaking it for merely method." Draft A has the same thought but phrased as: "mistaking it for method" without "merely." The "merely" matters — it implies she knows it was always more than method and chose not to see it. **Use Draft B's "merely."**

CHAPTER XV — The Demand

Word count: A = 4,800 | B = 4,772

Nearly identical. The bed men, Tariq's "come before one," Hanna's departure. Both drafts contain the same expanded opening with Leila, Ibrahim, breakfast, and the note.

Draft B gives slightly more space to Maryam's interior conflict after Hanna leaves — the paragraph about the note on the dressing table and the choice of whether to go. But the difference is marginal.

Use Draft B as base.

CHAPTER XVI — Narrowing Streets

Word count: A = 3,612 | B = 3,499

The city contracting. Roads watched, routes altered, the quarter's daily life becoming provisional. Both drafts handle this similarly. Draft A is ~113 words longer, mostly in street-scene description.

Use Draft B — slightly tighter.

CHAPTER XVII — The Third Letter

Word count: A = 3,287 | B = 3,275

Almost identical. Nadia's letter, the unsent reply, Amina's uncertain return, the chemist's boy as messenger, Hanna writing on the back of the grocer's circular. The Leila-button-on-the-map scene ("What is it then?" / "A record.") is in both.

No meaningful difference. Use either as base.

CHAPTERS XVIII–XX: THE CRITICAL DIVERGENCE

This is where the two drafts part company in a way that matters to the novel's meaning.

CHAPTER XVIII — The Note

Word count: A = 3,771 | B = 2,021

The fundamental difference: In Draft A, Maryam receives Tariq's note. In Draft B, she does not.

Draft A's version: Maryam goes out to collect Leila from school, runs errands, is delayed by blocked roads and a chemist. She returns home to find the envelope already on the table — the boy delivered it while she was out. Huda tells her it arrived after four. She reads it: "Today. Four o'clock. The flat. If you can come, come. I will be there until dark." It is already

past dark. She knows she has missed him. She knows he waited. The chapter then cuts to Tariq's side — his waiting at the flat, Elias's visits, the empty room. Then returns to the house, where Hanna arrives and tells Maryam to pack the case. The chapter ends with the note on the coverlet and the case on the chair: "One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early."

Draft B's version: Opens with the house shutting itself — back door bolted, map untouched, Amina's blanket still on the chair. Quick domestic sketch. Then cuts entirely to Tariq's side: he writes the note, sends the boy, waits at the flat. But the boy returns with the envelope *unopened*. He couldn't get through to the house — the shutters were drawn, no one answered, the road was watched. Maryam never sees the note. The chapter ends with Tariq leaving the unopened note under the mug on the sill.

Assessment:

Draft B's version is more devastating and more honest to the novel's themes. The note that never arrives is the novel's mechanism of delay taken to its final, structural conclusion. Throughout the book, postponement has been Maryam's defining pattern — visits deferred, letters unanswered, hours allowed to pass. In Draft B, the city itself performs the final postponement. She does not choose not to go. She is not even given the choice. History removes the question before it can be asked. This is consistent with the novel's refusal to let Maryam off the hook through clear moral decisions — she is never permitted the dignity of decisive refusal or decisive commitment.

Draft A's version is more conventionally satisfying. She reads the note, knows she missed him, feels the weight of it. The reader gets the pain of "too late." But this is also more sentimental. It gives Maryam knowledge — she knows he waited, she knows what was asked — and knowledge is a form of closure the novel has spent nineteen chapters denying her. Draft B keeps her in ignorance. She doesn't know whether he came, whether he asked, whether the flat still holds anything of theirs. The uncertainty is crueller and truer.

However: Draft A's domestic material in this chapter — the school pickup, Leila's questions, the blocked road, the chemist — is excellent. The texture of a day made

impossible by errands is exactly what the novel does best. Draft B loses all of this by cutting to Tariq's side too quickly.

Recommendation for Draft C: Use Draft B's central conceit — the note never arrives. But restore Draft A's domestic texture for the first half of the chapter. Show Maryam's day: the school circular, collecting Leila, the roads, the delays. Then cut to Tariq at the flat, waiting. The boy returns with the note unopened. Maryam never knows. The case arrives at the bedroom that evening courtesy of Hanna — as in Draft A — but without the note. The chapter ends with the case on the chair and nothing on the coverlet. The absence is the point.

Additionally: Draft A's Tariq-waiting section contains lines Draft B lacks — particularly "The failure had already happened. Questioning its method would not improve its fact." This is too good to lose. Draft B's version of the same scene has the exchange with Elias ("You need not wait if the roads are bad" / "I know" / "Do you?") which is also in Draft A. Keep both.

CHAPTER XIX — Five More Minutes

Word count: A = 4,461 | B = 3,174

Draft A opens with Maryam waking beside the note and the case — the morning after Chapter XVIII. The day then unfolds: packing, the bed men, the "five more minutes" scene, departure, arrival at the school rooms, and the first night there. It is a long chapter containing both the dismantling of the house and the arrival elsewhere.

Draft B opens with packing the mother's case — "with the sensation of committing small thefts." It skips the morning-with-the-note opening (since the note never arrived). It then covers the same material: mother's objections, bed men, "five more minutes," departure, truck, school rooms. It ends with Maryam lying in the schoolroom not knowing the note exists, and the passage: "Somewhere across the quarter, in a room she could not reach and did not know was waiting for her, the back shutter was still rattling and a mug stood on a sill beside a folded newspaper."

Assessment: Draft B's ending of this chapter — where Maryam does not know the note exists — is the stronger choice, consistent with the recommendation above. But Draft A has better material in the packing/departure sequence. Draft B's mother-and-shawl dialogue ("Not that shawl. The grey. The brown makes me look as if I have already become somebody's aunt." / "You are somebody's aunt." / "Not in cloth.") is superb and exclusive to Draft B. **Keep this exchange.**

Draft A's bed-men scene is longer and more textured — the rusted screw, the porter's narrow shoulders, the mattress leaning in the hall "like arguments no longer able to lie down." Draft B has the same scene but compressed. **Use Draft A's fuller version of the bed-men scene.**

The "five more minutes" scene itself is in both drafts and is nearly identical. Hanna in the doorway: "I have given you five more minutes." Maryam's interior response: "As if time were not hers in that room any longer and never had been; as if what he could offer was not understanding but measure; as if mercy itself, in him, could only arrive through allocation." This is one of the novel's defining moments. Both drafts handle it well. No change needed.

Recommendation for Draft C: Use Draft B's structure (no note in hand), but restore Draft A's fuller domestic material — particularly the bed-men scene and the departure sequence. End the chapter as Draft B does, with Maryam not knowing the note exists.

CHAPTER XX — The Key

Word count: A = 2,615 | B = 3,032

Both open with the schoolroom morning: the chalk, the stockings, the blankets shaped by bad sleep. Both contain the Aunt Widad key exchange ("Keep it" / "Why?" / "Because if you give it to your husband now he will put it with the others and it will become one more instrument"). Both end with the key on the desk.

Draft B is longer and better. It has several passages Draft A lacks or compresses:

1. "That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether one had the right to keep them." — After the key warms in her hand. Present only in Draft B.

2. The passage about Maryam grieving Tariq "not as an image — she had too much exactness left for that — but as a set of unfinished weights: the flat, the question, the demand that had never received an answer because history had removed answer from the list of actions still available." — Draft B only.

3. "And beneath both griefs, because truth was meaner than dignity, ran the low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her." — Both drafts have this, but Draft B develops it more fully: "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all. Yet the necessity others had begun carrying for her left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded." This is Draft B only and it is essential.

4. The final image: "cold despite her hand" — Draft B adds this to the key. Draft A ends more quickly.

Use Draft B for this chapter.

SUMMARY: BASE TEXT AND INTERVENTIONS

Use Draft B as the base text for Draft C. It is consistently tighter, its chapter titles are better (XIII, XIV), and its handling of the note (XVIII) is structurally superior.

From Draft A, harvest:

- Chapter I: the "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised" construction; the "Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention" line; the "lying no longer in his flat" opening clause

- Chapter XIII: the fuller consummation sentence ("a mistake recognised as itself while being committed...")

- Chapter XVIII: the domestic texture of Maryam's day (school pickup, Leila, the blocked roads, the chemist) — graft this onto Draft B's structure where the note never arrives

- Chapter XIX: the fuller bed-men scene, the departure details

In neither draft but needed in Draft C:

1. Tariq's own cost. Chapter XI gives some of this but it needs two or three more sentences — via Khalil, via the school ledger, via the mother — showing what the affair and the city's contraction cost him on his own terms, not filtered through Maryam.

2. A slightly stronger thematic link between Nawal and Tariq. Nawal was the person who could name what Maryam was feeling without destroying it. Her death removes that possibility. The affair then proceeds without any external intelligence capable of seeing it clearly. This is implicit in both drafts. One or two sentences making it structural — not explicit, just structural — would strengthen the novel's second half.

3. Reduce the Mrs Farah surveillance motif by one or two instances. Both drafts rely on it perhaps five times. Three strong instances would carry the point. After that it becomes a mechanism the reader can see too clearly.

4. Standardise chapter formatting. Both drafts have inconsistent headers (some bold, some italic, some plain). Fix for Draft C.

REPLY C II

QATAMON — Comparative Commentary on Drafts A and B

Preliminary Note

Both drafts contain twenty chapters, numbered I through XX, with the same structural spine. Roughly 85–90% of the prose is identical or near-identical. The drafts diverge in sentence-level choices scattered throughout, in the titles and internal handling of Chapters XIII and XIV, and most significantly in the architecture of the final two chapters (XIX and XX). Neither draft outshines the other entirely. A third draft should draw from both.

THE MACRO PICTURE

Structure

Both drafts follow the same arc: Chapter I (The House of Condolence) through XX (The Key in Draft B; material folded into XIX in Draft A). Both contain The Radio, Semiramis, the consummation scene, The Third Letter, and The Key. The differences are within chapters rather than between them.

The chapter titles diverge in two places:

- **Chapter XIII** — Draft A: "The Price of Seeing" / Draft B: "The Half-Emptied Flat"
- **Chapter XIV** — Draft A: "After" / Draft B: "Less Room Than Before"

The most significant structural difference lies in the ending. Draft A's Chapter XIX ("Five More Minutes") opens with Maryam waking to find Tariq's note still on the coverlet and Hanna's case still on the chair, then runs through the entire departure and displacement sequence before flowing into Chapter XX ("The Key") at the schoolroom. Draft B's Chapter XIX opens later — with packing the mother's case — and gives Chapter XX substantially more material, including passages not present in Draft A.

What Draft A Has That Draft B Doesn't

The note-on-the-coverlet opening of Chapter XIX. This is the single most significant passage unique to either draft. Maryam wakes. The note is on the coverlet. The case is on the chair. She rereads the note in daylight: "Today. Four o'clock. The flat. If you can come, come. I will be there until dark." The words have not improved by night. She opens the case. Packing in daylight is uglier than in lamplight. Then the crucial gesture: she slips the note inside the case beneath the first rolled pair of stockings. "The note had arrived too late to be answered and too exactly to be discarded. Hidden among stockings, it looked no less guilty than it had looked on the coverlet."

This passage makes the note a physical object that travels with Maryam into displacement. Without it — as in Draft B — the note disappears from the narrative after Chapter XVIII and the ending has less material weight. Tariq's demand ceases to be something carried in luggage alongside the child's cardigan and the mother's icon. That matters. The novel is about objects that survive their occasions and acquire new meaning through transport. The note in the stockings is one of its finest instances of this.

Sentence-level choices in the Semiramis chapter (IX). Draft A has the fuller version of the grief scene: "Maryam bent forward and pressed the cloth against her eyes, not because she had become theatrical enough to need a prop but because grief, when it finally arrived, often did so through tiny exactnesses one had not arranged for." Draft B compresses this. The clause about theatricality is essential — it distinguishes Maryam's grief from performance, which is the novel's central concern throughout.

Sentence-level choices in the consummation chapter (XIII). Draft A contains: "Behind her she heard him fold the blanket, not because order still mattered morally but because order was the only form of mercy available to men like him after they had crossed the line between desire and damage." Draft B replaces this with: "set the pillow straight, as if order might still be of use to someone." Draft A's version is more precise about Tariq's character — the distinction between order as morality and order as mercy — and stronger.

The Amina pantry scene (XIII) — one line. Draft A: "It contained neither insolence nor mercy. She had repaired the evidence in the night and was now giving it back in the form of clothing." Draft B drops the first sentence. Keep it. It earns the second.

What Draft B Has That Draft A Doesn't

The final movement of Chapter XX. Draft B has several passages not present in Draft A:

First: "She did not know that a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened, and placed under the mug by a hand that had then left the room without closing the shutter or the door." This introduces Tariq's side of the failed meeting without breaking into his perspective at length. It is devastating precisely because Maryam doesn't know it. The reader is given knowledge the protagonist is denied, and the sentence's calm factual progression — written, sent, carried, returned, placed — makes the futility unbearable.

Second: "She grieved him in uncertainty. She grieved also the house, the quarter, the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still survive them. And beneath

both griefs, because truth was meaner than dignity, ran the low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her." This articulates the novel's final emotional position more explicitly and forcefully than Draft A manages.

Third: "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all. Yet the necessity others had begun carrying for her left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded. It was a relief as ugly as the wash water in the basin. She knew it. It remained." The ugly-relief motif — the knowledge that history has removed the necessity of choosing, and the shame of being grateful for it — is the novel's real final note. Draft B states it with greater precision.

Fourth: "That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether one had the right to keep them." This sentence, about the key warming in her hand, is in Draft B only. It works.

Chapter Titles

"The Half-Emptied Flat" is the better title for Chapter XIII. "The Price of Seeing" is too literary, too conscious of itself as a chapter heading. It tells the reader what to feel. "The Half-Emptied Flat" is the location, the fact, the thing — and the novel's method throughout is to let facts do the work of feeling.

"Less Room Than Before" is the better title for Chapter XIV. "After" is vague and could head any chapter. "Less Room Than Before" is spatial, exact, and carries a double meaning: the house has less physical room because of Huda and Ibrahim, and the moral room available to Maryam has contracted.

SENTENCE-LEVEL PREFERENCES IN SHARED PASSAGES

Chapter I

Draft A: "not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private." Draft B: "Maryam stood in the doorway a moment before going in. The house had already ceased to be private." **Prefer Draft A.** The "not because... but because" construction immediately establishes the novel's central method: interiority defined by negation, feeling located by what it is not. It tells the reader how to read Maryam.

Draft A: "had one not known that Uncle Yusef was lying no longer in his flat." Draft B: "if Uncle Yusef had not been lying in the mortuary room." **Prefer Draft A.** The conditional "had one not known" is more precise — it's about knowledge, not about Yusef — and the generalising "one" opens the register beyond Maryam to the community voice.

Draft A: "constituted affection." Draft B: "amounted to affection." **Prefer Draft A.** "Constituted" is juridical, formal, self-interrogating. It fits the novel's register.

Draft A: "begun ordering themselves behind his eyes." Draft B: "begun arranging themselves behind his eyes." **Prefer Draft A.** "Ordering" suggests command, hierarchy — Hanna's particular intelligence.

Draft B: "She never wasted an answer when work would serve in its place." Draft A: "She never wasted an answer when work could be used as an answer instead." **Prefer Draft B.** More concise. The A version over-explains.

Draft A: "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners." Draft B: "The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely learned better manners." **Prefer Draft A's closing line** but **Draft B's lead-up sentences.** Draft B's preceding sentences — "For one wretched instant she had thought people would say she wore sorrow with dignity, and then despised herself for caring how she might be seen" — are tighter than Draft A's version. The ideal hybrid: Draft B's lead-up, Draft A's semicolon pivot.

Chapter IX (Semiramis)

Draft A: "food was one of the few forms by which alarm could be kept from becoming theatre." Draft B: "food was one of the few ways alarm could be kept from becoming theatre." **Prefer Draft A.** "Forms" is better than "ways" — it suggests formality, ritual, the novel's concern with how households give shape to the shapeless.

Draft A: "he had not yet given the world authority to cancel sequence altogether." Draft B: "he had not yet granted the world authority to cancel sequence altogether." **Prefer Draft B.** "Granted" is slightly more Hanna — deliberate, controlled, as if the decision were his to make.

Chapter XIII

Draft A: "The page looked like a debate carried on by decent men in a language papers respected more than households did." Draft B: "On the page the two hands looked like decent men disagreeing in a language paper respected more than households did." **Prefer Draft A.** The abstraction of "a debate" is better than "the two hands looked like decent men," which makes hands look like men — a slight category error.

Draft A: "At no point did either of them say this is absurd, though absurdity stood in the room like a fourth presence." Draft B: "Neither of them said anything about the absurdity of it." **Prefer Draft A.** The personification of absurdity as a fourth presence is precise and earned.

Chapter XIV

Draft A: "No one answered that. It was too near a true sentence for breakfast." Draft B: "No one answered." **Prefer Draft A.** The second sentence — "too near a true sentence for breakfast" — is one of the novel's signature moves: making the social mechanics of silence visible.

Chapter XIX

Draft A: "On the coverlet lay the note. On the chair sat the case. One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early. Between them the room held exactly the width of one night." This passage exists only in Draft A's version. **It should be in the third draft.** It is among the most structurally elegant passages in either manuscript.

Chapter XX

Draft A: "A key begged for a door; without one it became only a shaped insistence on what was elsewhere." Draft B: "A key begged for a door; without one it became only a shaped insistence on what was no longer accessible." **Prefer Draft B.** "No longer accessible" is more precise than "elsewhere" — it registers not just distance but impossibility.

CHARACTER

Both drafts handle the ensemble superbly. Aunt Widad, the mother, Father Elias, Leila — all fully alive in both. Two observations:

Hanna is fractionally better served by Draft B's Chapter XIII title and XIV title because the consummation and the morning-after are given names that locate them in the physical world ("The Half-Emptied Flat," "Less Room Than Before") rather than in editorial commentary ("The Price of Seeing," "After"). Hanna's line "Empty rooms become foolish if one leaves them half respectable" lands with more force when the chapter title has already established the flat as the scene's governing fact.

Tariq benefits from Draft A's order-as-mercy line in Chapter XIII and from Draft A's Chapter XIX opening. In Draft A, Tariq's note travels physically into the luggage of displacement; in Draft B, it disappears after Chapter XVIII. Draft B compensates with the returned-unopened passage in Chapter XX, which gives Tariq's waiting its own weight. The third draft should have both: the note in the stockings (from Draft A's XIX) and the note returned unopened (from Draft B's XX). These are not redundant — one is about Maryam carrying what she cannot answer; the other is about what happened to the answer she never gave.

Amina is consistent across both drafts. She carries the novel's moral intelligence. Neither draft gives Amina a scene in which her own displacement is acknowledged as itself rather than as a symptom of the household's decline. The knotted pillowcase, the lower road becoming impassable, the side room — these are all seen through the household's need for her. One moment — even five sentences — in which her own geography of loss becomes visible rather than inferred would strengthen the novel without requiring a subplot. Not a revelation. A crack in the surface through which her life appears. Consider adding this to the third draft.

PACING AND ARC

The pacing is controlled in both drafts because the architecture is the same. The progression from condolence house to displacement schoolroom moves with tidal inevitability. Each chapter tightens the available space — domestic, geographical, moral — until the schoolroom behind the school is the only room left.

The Radio chapter (VI) and Semiramis chapter (IX) give the political turning points their full weight in both drafts. Both drafts handle the map scene — the newspaper spread on the dining table, the salt cellar and paperknife as weights — with the same domestic materiality.

The one pacing concern is in the transition between XVIII and XIX. Draft A handles this better by making XIX open with the physical residue of XVIII: the note on the bed, the case on the chair. Draft B's XIX opens with packing the mother's case, which is effective but severs the direct link between Tariq's demand and the family's departure. The reader should feel both pressures operating simultaneously in the same room, on the same morning. Draft A achieves this. Draft B does not.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THE THIRD DRAFT

Use Draft B as the base for chapter titles (XIII and XIV) and for the Chapter XX ending.

Restore Draft A's Chapter XIX opening — the note on the coverlet, the case on the chair, the rereading in daylight, the note slipped beneath the stockings. This should precede the packing-of-the-mother's-case scene that Draft B opens with.

Keep Draft A's sentence-level choices where noted above: the "not because... but because" construction in Chapter I; "constituted" over "amounted"; "ordering" over "arranging"; the full grief-and-cloth passage in Chapter IX; the order-as-mercy line and the absurdity-as-fourth-presence line in Chapter XIII; "too near a true sentence for breakfast" in Chapter XIV; the "one had arrived too late / the other too early" passage in Chapter XIX.

Keep Draft B's sentence-level choices where noted: "work would serve in its place" over "work could be used as an answer instead"; "granted" over "given"; "no longer accessible" over "elsewhere"; the key-warming sentence in Chapter XX.

Keep Draft B's unique passages in Chapter XX: the note returned unopened, the ugly-relief meditation, "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all."

Consider adding one brief moment — a crack, not a scene — in which Amina's own displacement becomes visible as itself. Her knotted pillowcase and the side room are there. What's missing is one sentence in which the household recognises, even fleetingly, that Amina's lower road is also Amina's life, not merely a staffing problem.

Clean the chapter numbering. Number sequentially I through XX with no gaps and consistent formatting.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The novel is accomplished work. The prose is controlled, intelligent, and entirely its own. The emotional register — refusing melodrama while achieving real devastation through domestic precision — is sustained with remarkable consistency. The political is made domestic without being diminished. The domestic is made political without being inflated. That is very difficult to do, and both drafts do it.

The differences between the drafts are not of kind but of degree: which sentence is tighter, which passage earns its place, which title tells the truth more exactly. The combination described above — Draft B's titles and ending, Draft A's XIX opening and scattered sentence-level preferences — produces the strongest possible version of material that is already working at a high level.

Please note – When relevant, Draft A is Complete First Draft Polish and Draft B is QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash

THIS IS WHAT V1 II ASKED

I am giving you two drafts of the same novel and deliberately not explaining my intentions, because I want the book to speak for itself. Please read both closely and tell me which draft works better as a novel, or whether the strongest version would be a third draft built from the best parts of each. Do not force this into an either-or unless one draft clearly outclasses the other. Instead, compare them as complete reading experiences and explain, as comprehensively and specifically as possible, what each draft does better or worse at the macroscopic level — structure, plot, pacing, clarity, consistency, emotional force, character work, thematic coherence, and overall movement — and at the microscopic level — scenes, transitions, paragraphs, sentences, and line-by-line choices where one draft is stronger than the other. Where a hybrid would be best, specify exactly what should be kept from Draft A, what should be kept from Draft B, and what neither draft has yet solved and should be rewritten. Be exact, constructive, and unreserved.

REPLY V1 II CG I

I reread the paginated versions of Draft A, *Complete First Draft Polish*, and Draft B, *QATAMON*. My verdict did **not** change in substance, but it did sharpen in one important place: I am now more confident that **A's Chapters XVIII–XIX contain the better late-book mechanism**, while **B remains the stronger manuscript overall**.

Final judgement

Bluntly: **Draft B is the better novel as it currently reads.** It is tighter, more self-trusting, and more consistent from page to page. But **the best final book is not B untouched**. The strongest version is a **third draft built on B, then corrected by A in the late movement**, chiefly in Chapters XVIII and XIX, and recombined again in Chapter XX.

Approximate counts from the uploaded text support that reading. By my count, A is about **76.3k** words and B about **72.1k**, so A is roughly **4.2k** words longer overall. Nearly all of that extra weight sits where the real structural change sits: **A is about 1.8k words longer in XVIII and about 1.3k longer in XIX, while B is actually about 400 words longer in XX**. In other words, A's major revision is not spread evenly through the book; it is concentrated in the late-book machinery, which is exactly where it helps most. Those counts are approximate, because DOCX extraction is never perfectly canonical, but the pattern is clear.

What both drafts already do well

Both drafts understand the right scale of history. The city does not enter the novel through speeches or lectures. It enters through watched roads, delayed servants, altered routes, borrowed rooms, shutters left partly closed, papers needing stamps, and households learning new habits before they admit they are learning them. That is one of the book's real strengths, and it is strong in both versions. The novel is not pretending politics and domestic life are separate; it shows politics turning domestic life into logistics. That is right.

The basic architecture is also good in both: death becomes paperwork; paperwork becomes proximity; proximity becomes moral risk; then the quarter narrows until private hesitation is overtaken by public collapse. That architecture already exists. The question is not whether the book has a shape. It does. The question is which draft earns that shape better. On that question, B wins most of the book, and A improves the last act.

Why B is the stronger manuscript overall

B is better from roughly **Chapters I–XVII** because it **starts later, stops sooner, and explains less**. A keeps adding one more sentence before or after the live thing. Sometimes that extra sentence is good. Often it is not needed.

The cleanest example is **Chapter V**. A opens with an added domestic preface — "On Monday morning the house resumed itself..." — before arriving at the real chapter strike: **"The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast."** B begins there. B is right. A's added lead-in is not bad prose; it is simply weaker chapter management.

The same thing happens in **Chapter VI**. A begins abstractly: Yusef's papers have "ceased to behave like grief and begun behaving like work". True, but too essayed. B begins with the day that "resembled a doctor". That is more alive, more strange, more novelistic, and it gets the chapter moving at once. B's middle chapters are full of those small gains.

B is also better at concrete pressure. When A writes, in Chapter VIII, that "tragic silver remains merely decorative", it is intelligent but slightly writerly. B's version is harder and better: **"silver does not stay tragic for long. It becomes something to sell."** That is not just a better line. It is a better novelistic instinct. It turns theme back into object and need. The same is true of the **birdcage wired shut with no bird in it** in B's Chapter XII: it is one of the best single historical-domestic images in either draft, and A's substitute is weaker.

B's restraint also helps the love story. In **Chapter XIII**, A adds lines like "That, perhaps, was the beginning of the chapter's true price..." and "The first dangerous thing in an affair was not touch. It was repetition." Those lines are intelligent, but they are also self-aware in a way

the scene does not need. B is wiser there. It lets the room, the tea, the mug, and the repeated work imply what A says aloud. And B's kiss sentence is cleaner: it trusts the moment instead of glossing it.

The same pattern holds in **Chapter XIV**. A gives you "which was perhaps the exact cruelty of it", then "It was not a wound or a triumph. It was only an alteration." B pares that back to "Altered, that was all." B is not always better sentence by sentence, but it is more often better **chapter by chapter**, because it refuses to turn every strong beat into a little essay about itself.

So at the macroscopic level B wins on **pacing, rhythm, and consistency**. It carries the reader more confidently through the middle of the novel. The book feels less as though it is pausing to interpret itself.

Why A matters, and where it is genuinely better

A matters because it fixes the late-book tragedy in a way B does not.

In B, **Chapter XVIII** is excellent on its own terms: Tariq waits in the flat; the schoolboy returns; the note ends up under the mug on the sill; the back shutter rattles; the room holds the failure. That is beautifully controlled. But it puts the decisive late pain mostly on **his** side. Maryam's Chapter XIX then proceeds through packing, the move, and displacement without that same physical collision between her and the message.

A changes that. In A, **the note reaches Maryam**. That single change alters the book's moral geometry. The separation is no longer merely a matter of mistiming, watched roads, and tragic logistics. It becomes something she must **receive, hold, hide, and lie beside**. The note on the coverlet and the case on the chair are not decorative improvements. They are structural ones. A turns the ending from "history prevented an answer" into "history narrowed the world so brutally that the answer arrived and still could not be lived". That is the stronger tragedy.

The page-break reread made me more confident of that than I was before. In the current paginated A, **Chapter XVIII now ends where it should**: with the note on the coverlet and the case on the chair. My earlier hesitation that this material might be spilling too far into XIX is much smaller now. The chapter border basically works. The only remaining issue is that XIX deliberately reopens on the same note/case tableau, which is emotionally right but still slightly duplicative.

A's **Chapter XIX** is therefore more valuable than B's, because it lets the note become private burden rather than pure dramatic irony. The act of hiding it under the stockings is exactly the right kind of indignity: practical, furtive, morally ugly, and small enough to feel true. And A's

Chapter XIX final sentence — **“The house was shut. The flat was bare. The note lay under the stockings, answered by nothing. She was here.”** — is one of the strongest endings in either draft. B’s ending is good, but it is still partly arranged around what Maryam does **not** know. A’s is harsher because it is arranged around what she **does** know and still cannot answer.

A is also better in a few earlier line-level places. Two obvious ones are in **Chapter I**. A’s **“That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no.”** is plainly better than B’s fuller sentence about what stayed with her. And A’s **“Death, she thought, had not created grandeur. It had created work.”** hits harder than B’s compressed “created no grandeur, only work.” In both cases A wins by being blunter, not by being longer.

A also has the better **Chapter XIII title**: **The Price of Seeing** is superior to **The Half-Emptied Flat**. The latter is accurate but merely descriptive. The former names the chapter’s real action. By contrast, **neither Chapter XIV title works**. A’s **After** is too vague to do any work. B’s **Less Room Than Before** is competent but prosy and over-explicit. That chapter needs a new title.

Where my assessment changed after the paginated reread

Two material adjustments.

First: I am now firmer that **A XVIII–XIX are not just interesting alternatives; they are the right late-book correction**. The page-break versions make that impossible to dismiss as formatting noise.

Second: I am **less** inclined than before to hand **Chapter XX** to A. B’s Chapter XX has the stronger underlying psychological logic — the broken sleep, the key in the hand, the shameful relief that history has collapsed choice ahead of her — but B sometimes leans too visibly into its own phrasing. The sentence about objects adapting to the body, for instance, is writer-visible, and the “wash water in the basin” simile is good but right on the edge of over-insistence. A trims some of that, sometimes usefully, but also loses some of B’s stronger internal sequence. So XX is now, to my mind, a **recombination chapter**, not a win for either draft.

Character work

Hanna is superb in both drafts. He is not furniture. He is one of the novel’s major engines. His form of love — arranging, preventing, sequencing, anticipating, allocating — is dramatically powerful because it is both generous and oppressive. The “five more minutes” moment is one of the best things in the book, and it works in both drafts.

Maryam is good in both, but A improves her where it matters most by letting the late note pass through her hands. That change gives her a truer burden. B protects her from some over-explanation; A gives her the better final moral weight. The best version keeps both advantages.

Tariq is good, but still slightly too exact in both. He is often intelligent, tactful, burdened, and controlled in ways the book understands, but he is not yet quite unpredictable enough or singular enough early enough. Chapter XI helps. So do the flat scenes. But Hanna still sometimes lands harder than Tariq, and that is a structural warning. It does not mean Hanna should be weakened. It means the affair needs to become indispensable a little sooner and with slightly more irregularity.

Amina, Aunt Widad, Leila, and the mother are all strong. Amina in particular is excellent. Very little needs changing there.

Exact hybrid plan

If you are building the strongest book from these two files, this is the cleanest route.

Use B as the base text for Chapters I–XVII. That is where the manuscript is more reliable as a reading experience. Then make targeted imports from A.

From A, import these exact things:

1. In **Chapter I**, keep **"The no."** and keep the split cadence of **"had not created grandeur. It had created work."**
2. In **Chapter XIII**, keep the title **The Price of Seeing**.
3. In **Chapters XVIII–XIX**, keep the **fact** that Maryam receives the note; keep the **coverlet/chair tableau**; keep the note hidden under the stockings; keep the Chapter XIX ending **"answered by nothing. She was here."**
4. In **Chapter XX**, keep A's pruning where B turns slightly self-conscious.

From B, keep these exact things:

1. **Chapter V opening**. Cut A's preface.
2. **Chapter VI opening**. Cut A's abstract preamble.
3. **Chapter VIII** line: **"silver does not stay tragic for long. It becomes something to sell."**
4. **Chapter XII** birdcage image.

5. **Chapter XIII** kiss sentence and the general restraint around the affair's first consummation.
6. Much of **Chapter XX**'s underlying emotional logic: the key in the hand, the broken sleep, the shameful relief that choice has collapsed ahead of her.

Rebuild these from scratch or by true recombination, not by simple paste:

1. **Chapter XIV title**.
2. **Chapter XVIII**: keep A's note-delivery architecture, but borrow B's waiting-room tension — the mug on the sill, the back shutter, Elias moving through the building, the sense of time thinning — without reintroducing B's note-return logic.
3. **Chapter XIX opening**: keep A's waking tableau for the note/case, but cut more quickly into the packing sequence so the chapter does not linger twice on the same fact.
4. **Chapter XX**: take B's psychological sequence, then edit it with A's scalpel. Keep the inner logic; cut the showier phrasing.

What neither draft has solved yet

The biggest unsolved issue is this: **the novel's world, house, and administrative pressures are more consistently compelling than the affair**. That is not a disaster, because the world-building is very good. But if the book wants to be not just a strong historical-domestic tragedy but a devastating tragic love story, then Maryam and Tariq need to become a little more singular to each other a little earlier. At present, the book's best pressure is often the pressure of rooms, papers, routes, and Hanna's competence.

The second unsolved issue is **middle-book rhythm**. Too many middle chapters move in the same elegant cadence: household task, exact exchange, inward classification, quiet close. The chapters are good individually. Their cumulative tempo flattens slightly. B mitigates this better than A, but neither wholly solves it.

The third is **prose temperature**. Both drafts like polished antithesis and the explanatory afterbeat. A does it more. B does it less, but still enough that it needs watching. The rule for the next draft should be ruthless: whenever the scene already landed, cut the sentence that names what it just did.

Bottom line

So, stripped down to the useful answer:

Best current manuscript: Draft B.
Most valuable revision A contains: the late-book note/case/note-under-stockings machinery.
Best final novel: a third draft built on B, corrected by A in XVIII–XIX, and recomposed again in XX.

That is the honest answer. B is the better book now. A contains the correction that stops the ending from being merely sad and makes it tragic.

REPLY V1 II CG II

First, both final drafts have the **same 20-chapter skeleton**. So B's advantage is **not** architectural in the crude sense of "more chapters" or "a cleaner existence of Chapter XX". It is an advantage of **execution inside the same architecture**. Second, A has a slightly stronger claim on a few late-book sentences than I gave it before, especially in Chapter XX.

The blunt answer is still this:

Draft B is the better novel as a complete reading experience. The strongest final book would be a third draft built on B as the base text, with selected restorations from A.

Not a diplomatic merge. Not a 50/50 splice. **B as spine. A as donor.**

What changed in my view after re-reading these final versions

These are not two wholly different books. They are the **same novel at two levels of self-knowledge**. Large stretches are already very close. A lot of chapter endings are near-identical. The real decisions lie in:

- chapter entrances;
- Hanna's characterisation in Chapter III;
- the consummation and its morning after in XIII–XIV;
- and, decisively, the entire **XVIII–XX sequence**.

By my count from the files after normalising formatting, B is roughly **4,000 words shorter overall**. More important than the total is where those cuts and additions happen: B cuts heavily in **XVIII** and **XIX**, then gives **XX** more room. That redistribution is one of the main reasons B reads better as a novel. It cuts set-up and expands consequence. That is the correct instinct.

The core judgement

A often has the better isolated sentence.
B more often has the better chapter.
And **B very clearly has the better final act**.

That is why B wins the book.

Macroscopic analysis

Structure

B wins, but narrowly until the final act, then clearly.

Across most of the book, the drafts share the same underlying structure. The stronger difference is that B tends to **start later and stop earlier**. It enters scenes closer to pressure and exits without the extra explanatory beat A sometimes adds.

That matters most in Chapters V and VI. In A, Chapter V opens with the house "resuming itself" after condolence. In B, it opens with the harder, cleaner line about the first violence done to a house by death being public and the second domestic. That is better chapter judgement. Chapter VI shows the same pattern: A opens by explaining that Yusef's papers have stopped behaving like grief and started behaving like work; B opens in weather, atmosphere, and unease, then lets the chapter discover its argument inside scene. B is more novelistic there.

Plot

B wins clearly.

The decisive reason is the note mechanism.

In A, Maryam receives Tariq's note, reads it, cannot answer, then hides it under the stockings. That version gives you secrecy, private guilt, and a morally dirtier Maryam. It is interesting. It is also more conventional. The tragedy stays largely interpersonal.

In B, the note is sent, delayed by watched roads and altered routes, and **returned unopened**. Tariq does not know whether she could not answer or would not. Maryam does not know the note existed. That is the right tragic form for this book, because it makes the catastrophe not merely a backdrop to desire but the thing that **rewires causality itself**. The city does not decorate the tragedy; it performs it.

That one revision changes the whole book's moral geometry.

Pacing

B wins.

A is not baggy in the obvious sense. It is worse than baggy: it is sometimes **over-complete**. It shows the thing, then supplies the secondary sentence explaining the thing, then occasionally supplies a third sentence securing the interpretation.

B usually cuts that extra step. Not always correctly, but usually.

The late redistribution is especially effective. A spends more time staging the note as an object in Maryam's possession. B spends less time on that because it has removed that logic altogether, and uses the saved space to strengthen Tariq's waiting, the practical mechanics of departure, and the altered life of the schoolroom. That is better pacing because it is better causality.

Clarity

B wins.

Not because A is confusing. A is not. But B is clearer about what kind of tragedy it is building. It clarifies the note, clarifies the role of roads and watched spaces, clarifies the late-book narrowing, and clarifies Tariq's independent existence without overexposing him.

Emotional force

Split verdict.

A often lands the sharper single stab.
B lands the stronger cumulative wound.

A's best local advantage is that it trusts the fragment. "Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no." is better than B's smoother paraphrase of the same beat. A is more dangerous there. It cuts directly into the nerve.

But B's final cumulative force is greater because the late-book loss is no longer merely that Maryam failed to answer. It is that history made answer and non-answer look the same from the wrong room.

That is worse. Therefore it is better.

Character

Maryam: slight edge to B overall, but with a caveat. B is stronger structurally because her tragedy is no longer reduced to hiding a note. But A sometimes gives her more inner contamination. Draft C must restore some of that dirt.

Hanna: edge to A. This is one of the most important findings.

A gives Hanna several formulations B should not have cut. The key one is that he “did not rank claims by sentiment” and moved among competing obligations as though order were the only justice available in a disordered world. That is the deepest statement of his character in either draft. A also has the line about some men making themselves indispensable so they do not have to say who they are when they sit still. That is excellent and should not have been lost.

B still handles Hanna well. It even adds one useful Maryam-side correction in Chapter III: that she has grown too used to reading his practical loyalty as climate rather than a series of acts. That is good. But A still owns the best Hanna sentences.

Tariq: B wins. Not because he changes completely, but because B gives him late-book existence outside Maryam’s interpretation. The waiting scene in the flat matters a great deal. It gives him solitude, time, an object world, and failure.

Amina / Aunt Widad / Leila / Huda: essentially a draw. Both drafts know exactly how to use them. They are never decorative.

Thematic coherence

B wins.

Both drafts understand that the book’s deepest subject is narrowing life through rooms, routes, paper, labour, and time. But B holds to that more consistently. A sometimes leans back towards adultery-novel psychology. B keeps returning the book to its true grammar: house, flat, road, map, key, mug, child, bread, schoolroom.

Overall movement

B wins.

A moves well. B narrows better.

That is the best single description of the difference.

Microscopic analysis

Where A is stronger

1. Chapter I.
A’s fragment after Yusef’s death is plainly better: “Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no.” B tidies it and weakens it. Keep A here.

2. Chapter III.
A owns the best Hanna material. Keep the “did not rank claims by sentiment” paragraph.

Keep the “order as justice” line. Keep the “made themselves indispensable” line if you can find the right place for it.

3. Chapter XIII, the first kiss.
A’s sentence is better: the kiss is a mistake recognised as itself while being committed. B’s version is cleaner and weaker. Keep A’s entry into the kiss.

4. Chapter XIV, the morning after.
A is again better at bodily truth: “not a wound or a triumph … only an alteration.” B’s “Altered, that was all” is too neat. It sounds revised rather than lived. Keep A here.

5. Parts of Chapter XX.
A is subtler in some of the final inward movement. B’s added lines about betrayal and relief are not wrong, but they are closer to visible authorship. A’s formulation about the choice being lifted out of reach and feeling, for a moment, like rest is stronger because it is less announced. This is one of the relevant changes in my view: A deserves more credit in the final chapter than I first gave it.

Where B is stronger

1. Chapter V opening.
B’s opener is simply better chaptercraft. It starts the chapter on the right pressure point.

2. Chapter VI opening.
Same verdict. B gets into weather, unease, and the altered register of domestic life faster and more vividly.

3. Chapter XIV title.
“Less Room Than Before” is miles better than “After”. No contest.

4. Chapters XVIII–XIX as a unit.
This is the heart of it. B’s late act is not better because it is fancier. It is better because it has the right logic. The note returns unopened. Tariq waits. Maryam does not know. The city has done the damage. That is the novel’s true tragic mechanism.

5. Tariq’s independence.
B’s late Tariq material stops him being merely the site of Maryam’s deferral. He becomes his own room, his own time, his own unanswered question.

Where neither draft is fully solved

1. The novel is still too uniformly quotable.
Too many paragraphs arrive already carrying their own underlining. B improves this. It does not cure it.

2. Some Maryam/Tariq exchanges remain slightly over-authored. They are strongest when they speak through objects, work, routes, and timing. They are weaker when they sound equally capable of writing the book.

3. The middle still repeats its governing ideas a little too often. Especially in III–VI, and to a lesser extent X–XII, both drafts occasionally restate what the novel has already proved: that papers create cover, that houses lose privacy, that delay is now dangerous, that history arrives domestically. B reduces this repetition. It does not remove it.

4. B has a few visibly authored late lines that should be watched.
"The city had placed itself between the note and its reader."
"That was the first betrayal."
"It was a relief as ugly as the wash water in the basin."
None is fatal. All sit close to self-announcement. The book can carry a few such lines. It should not acquire many more.

Exact prescription for Draft C

Do **not** merge generously. That would weaken the book.

Keep from B

- the overall manuscript base;
- the tighter chapter entrances, especially **V** and **VI**;
- **Chapter XIV title**: *Less Room Than Before*;
- the **returned-unopened note** mechanism;
- Tariq waiting in the flat in **XVIII**;
- the structural logic of **XIX** and **XX**;
- B's added Tariq autonomy;
- B's line in Chapter III that Maryam reads Hanna's practical loyalty as climate rather than as acts;
- B's line in Chapter XIII that Tariq's care makes the thing harder, not easier.

Restore from A

- Chapter I: "Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no."
- Chapter III: the Hanna paragraph about not ranking claims by sentiment;

- Chapter III: the line about order being the only justice available;
- Chapter III: the “indispensable” line;
- Chapter XIII: A’s entry into the first kiss;
- Chapter XIV: A’s morning-after body logic;
- Chapter XX: A’s more restrained inward phrasing about the choice being lifted out of reach and feeling like rest.

Rewrite, do not paste

- any A material that depends on Maryam physically receiving the note;
- the brilliant A sentence “One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early.” It is excellent, but it is now logically unusable if B’s superior note mechanism is kept;
- B’s “first betrayal” line if you want the end less visibly authored;
- B’s wash-water relief paragraph, or at least reduce it by a third;
- one or two middle-book thesis paragraphs in III–VI;
- a few Maryam/Tariq exchanges that are too polished.

Bottom line

So, with the final versions in hand:

Draft B is the better novel.
Draft A remains indispensable.
The best final book is B, sharpened with A’s best wounds and then re-stitched without sentimentality.

The shortest honest formulation is this:

B wins the book. A wins some of the blood.
Use B as the body. Put A’s sharpest blades back in.

REPLY V1 II C I

QATAMON: Comparative Analysis of Two Drafts

Draft A: *Complete First Draft Polish*

Draft B: *QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash*

Both manuscripts are the same novel in twenty chapters, running from Uncle Yusef's condolence day through the family's displacement to a parish schoolroom. Both follow the same chapter sequence, the same plot, and the same cast. Draft A runs approximately 76,300 words; Draft B approximately 72,100. The differences are not structural but textural — and one of them is a fundamental narrative decision about the novel's climax.

I. THE CENTRAL DIVERGENCE: CHAPTERS XVIII–XIX

This is the single most important difference between the drafts. It determines what kind of novel this is at its close.

What happens in Draft A

Draft A's Chapter XVIII ("The Note," 3,771 words) contains the following sequence. Maryam collects Leila from school, navigating streets that have begun to refuse their old purposes — a butcher's assistant running with parcels against his chest, two mattresses roped badly against a wall, a woman arguing a receipt with the intensity of someone defending the old order. She arrives home to find an envelope with her name on it, set apart from the other papers on the table. Huda tells her a boy brought it. Maryam opens it:

Today. Four o'clock. The flat. If you can come, come. I will be there until dark. T.

It is already past dark.

The chapter then shifts to Tariq's perspective — the only sustained departure from Maryam's close-third point of view in either draft. We see him in the stripped flat, the chipped mug on the sill, the newspaper he will not read because reading would make the waiting a performance. Father Elias visits three times. The boy returns on foot, cap gone, one trouser knee dark with mud. The envelope is unopened. Tariq puts it under the mug and leaves without closing the shutter.

Then Hanna arrives with the small case and tells Maryam to pack. The chapter ends: "On the coverlet lay the note. On the chair sat the case. One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early. Between them the room held exactly the width of one night."

In Draft A's Chapter XIX, the note travels with Maryam into the schoolroom. "In the case at the foot of the mattress, beneath the stockings, the note still lay where she had put it." The ending: "The house was shut. The flat was bare. The note lay under the stockings, answered by nothing. She was here."

Maryam possesses the note. She knows it was sent. She could not act on it. The ending is about the impossibility of response.

What happens in Draft B

Draft B's Chapter XVIII ("The Note," 2,022 words) compresses the household morning — no school run, no streets. Hanna announces the schoolrooms are open. They pack. Then, within the same chapter, the perspective shifts to Tariq: writing the note at a quarter past eleven, sending the boy, waiting in the flat, the same Elias visits, the same boy returning with the envelope unopened. The scene is told with the same detail and patience as Draft A's version. The chapter ends: "The note was under the mug. The mug was on the sill. The room held the rest."

But in Draft B's Chapter XIX, Maryam has no note. She has never received it. The chapter ends with an omniscient passage — the only moment in either draft where the narration reveals something the protagonist cannot know:

"She did not know that a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened, and placed under the mug by a hand that had then left the room without closing the shutter or the door. She knew only that the ceiling above her was not hers, that the child beside her breathed as if breath were the last ordinary thing still functioning, and that somewhere in the city a man she could not answer had asked a question the day itself had made unanswerable."

Assessment

Draft B's version is the braver and more complete choice.

The novel's entire architecture is built on delay. Maryam delays answering Nadia. She delays visiting Nawal, who then dies in the Semiramis. She delays naming what has happened at the flat. She delays answering the demand Tariq has not quite made. The note that never arrives is the final expression of this principle: history itself has become the last delay, and it does not distinguish between circumstance and decision. The city placed itself between the note and its reader.

In Draft A, Maryam receives the note and is prevented from acting on it by timing. That is painful but relatively simple — external constraint. In Draft B, she never knows the offer was made. She ends the novel in ignorance of the final gesture, which means she cannot even grieve the missed chance cleanly. She is denied not only the meeting but the knowledge that the meeting was sought. This is crueller and truer to the novel's logic.

The omniscient break in Draft B's XIX works precisely because the novel has never done it before. One departure from close-third, in the final pages, to show the reader what the protagonist cannot see — this is a structural move, not a lapse. It must remain the only such moment. If it were done twice, it would become a technique. Done once, at this exact point, it becomes an event.

Draft A's version has one substantial advantage: the school-run and street material cut from Draft B's XVIII is strong. The teacher asking each woman twice for the family name, the brass finial on a bedstead carried past, the butcher's assistant running with meat held against his chest as if it had become a document requiring haste — these details earn the departure scene. They should be recovered, not as part of the note sequence (Maryam should not receive the note) but as material placed earlier in XVIII or redistributed into XVII's street-level texture.

Draft A's closing line for XVIII — "One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early. Between them the room held exactly the width of one night" — is a fine sentence, but it belongs to a different novel: the one where she receives the note. It cannot survive the move to Draft B's architecture.

II. CHAPTER TITLES

Two chapters carry different titles across the drafts. Both matter.

Chapter XIII. Draft A: "The Price of Seeing." Draft B: "The Half-Emptied Flat." Draft B is better. "The Price of Seeing" tells the reader what to feel before the chapter has begun — it interprets the action in advance. "The Half-Emptied Flat" is concrete, spatial, and lets the metaphor of emptying accumulate without announcement. The flat is half-emptied of furniture; Maryam is half-emptied of her former composure; the quarter is half-emptied of its residents. The title trusts each of these meanings to arrive without being named.

Chapter XIV. Draft A: "After." Draft B: "Less Room Than Before." Draft A is better. "After" is exact and stark and refuses to specify what it follows. The reader knows. It earns its reticence from the previous chapter. "Less Room Than Before" is accurate but explanatory — it tells the reader the chapter's theme is spatial and domestic compression, which the prose will demonstrate within its first paragraphs anyway.

III. LINE-LEVEL DIFFERENCES IN SHARED CHAPTERS

The two drafts share approximately 95% of their prose. Where they diverge at the sentence level, neither draft is uniformly stronger. What follows is an accounting of the significant differences, chapter by chapter, with a verdict on each.

Chapter I

The opening paragraph. Draft A: "a pale Jerusalem morning that might have belonged to any other day in Qatamon had one not known that Uncle Yusef was lying no longer in his flat but in the mortuary room at the church." Draft B: "a pale Jerusalem morning that might have belonged to any other day in Qatamon, if Uncle Yusef had not been lying in the mortuary room at the church."

Draft A's version is better. "Lying no longer in his flat but in the mortuary room" makes the displacement concrete — Yusef has been moved from a place of life to a place of administration. Draft B's version ("had not been lying in the mortuary room") omits the flat, losing that specific sense of a body removed from where it belonged. The phrase "no longer" does essential work.

The doorway. Draft A: "Maryam stood in the doorway for a moment before going in, not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private." Draft B: "Maryam stood in the doorway a moment before going in. The house had already ceased to be private."

Draft A is better. The negation — "not because she was overcome" — establishes the novel's entire method of characterising Maryam. She is defined throughout by what she is not feeling, not doing, not admitting. To cut the negation here is to weaken the reader's first understanding of how this consciousness works. It also pre-empts a sentimental reading:

the reader is told at once that this woman is not overcome, and that the reason she pauses is architectural rather than emotional.

Disgust. Draft A: "she had noticed, with disgust and accuracy, that even the unflattering dress made her look composed." Draft B: "she had seen with disgust that even the unbecoming dress made her look composed."

Draft A is better. "Accuracy" is the devastating word. It means Maryam's self-assessment is not melodrama but forensic — she sees clearly and is disgusted by what she sees clearly. Without it, the sentence is merely self-reproach. With it, it becomes the portrait of a mind that cannot stop being precise even when precision is the source of suffering. This is one of the best two-word combinations in either manuscript.

Vanity. Draft A: "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners." Draft B: "The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely learned better manners."

Draft A is better. The full aphoristic form — vanity did not vanish because it was despised — has more authority and more bite. Draft B's "The disgust changed nothing" is flat by comparison; it states the point without sharpening it.

Chapter V

The opening. Draft A begins: "On Monday morning the house resumed itself with an indecency that would have offended Maryam less if it had not been so necessary." This is followed by a paragraph about the condolence mats gone, the chairs returned, the spectacles still on the sideboard "because no one could decide whether removing them would count as tidiness or betrayal." Only then does the aphorism arrive: "The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast."

Draft B cuts the preamble and opens with the aphorism.

Draft B's instinct is right — the aphorism is stronger as a chapter opener. But Draft A's spectacles detail ("tidiness or betrayal") is too good to lose. It should be recovered elsewhere in the chapter.

Chapter XIII

The metafictional line. Draft A contains: "That, perhaps, was the beginning of the chapter's true price: not desire itself, but the fact that delay had already shown what it cost in one direction and still had not cured her in the other."

Draft B has: "Delay had already shown what it cost in one direction and still had not cured her in the other."

Draft B is right to cut "the chapter's true price." The phrase breaks the novel's register — it addresses the reader as a reader, acknowledging the artefact of the chapter, which nothing else in either manuscript does. The observation about delay is strong and should stay. The frame around it should not.

The mug. Draft A: "A mug suggested habit, and habit was bad enough." Draft B: "A mug suggested habit. The first dangerous thing in an affair was not touch. It was repetition."

Draft A is better. "Habit was bad enough" is dry, exact, and trusts the reader to understand the implication. Draft B's version spells it out — "the first dangerous thing in an affair" — in a way that makes the narrator sound like an advice columnist rather than a consciousness moving through its own discomfort. The novel earns its power by never using the word "affair." It should continue not using it.

Chapter XIV

The opening. Draft A: "When Maryam woke the next morning the room looked ordinary first and wrong only a second later, which was perhaps the exact cruelty of it." Draft B: "When Maryam woke the next morning the room looked ordinary first and wrong only a second later."

Draft A is better. "Which was perhaps the exact cruelty of it" earns its place because it names a specific quality of the morning-after that the novel cannot afford to leave unstated: the cruelty is in the delay between ordinary and wrong. That micro-delay recapitulates the novel's master theme.

The alteration. Draft A: "It was not a wound or a triumph. It was only an alteration." Draft B: "Altered, that was all."

Draft A is better. The longer form — wound, triumph, alteration — sets up a triad that dismisses the dramatic options before arriving at the accurate one. "Altered, that was all" compresses this into a shrug. The morning after what has happened in the flat deserves more weight than a shrug, even a composed one.

Chapter XVIII

The opening sentence. Draft A: "By breakfast the house had begun measuring itself in shorter units." Draft B: "The house had begun shutting itself without anyone quite admitting that this was what it was doing."

Draft A is better. "Measuring itself in shorter units" is original and concrete — it translates the abstract feeling of contraction into the domestic language of measurement that the novel has used throughout (lists, inventories, ledgers, accounts). "Shutting itself" is a more generic metaphor. "Shorter units" also connects to the novel's recurring preoccupation with time narrowing.

Chapter XX

The final key image. Draft A: "Then she took the key out at last and laid it on the desk beside her folded gloves." Draft B: "Then she opened her other hand, looked at the key in the dark as if darkness could tell brass from shadow, and laid it on the desk beside her folded gloves."

Draft B is better. "As if darkness could tell brass from shadow" adds exactly one image — the failure of sight to distinguish the key from the dark around it — and that image does structural work: it makes the key disappear into the room even as it is laid down. The object that has been carried and held and traced through leather all night becomes, at the moment of release, indistinguishable from its surroundings. This is not ornamentation. It is the novel's final statement about what happens to private objects when the world that gave them meaning has contracted beyond use.

"Ordinary indignities persisted. So did ordinary mercies." Draft B adds this sentence near the end. It does not appear in Draft A. It should stay. It is the novel's most compressed ethical statement, and it arrives at the right moment — after the passage sounds and before the final image. It names the two forces that have governed the entire novel without announcing themselves as themes.

The expanded ending. Draft B's Chapter XX contains several passages not in Draft A's shorter version:

"She grieved him in uncertainty. She grieved also the house, the quarter, the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still survive them."

"And beneath both griefs, because truth was meaner than dignity, ran the low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her. The room behind the school, the files, the children, the priests, the keys, the blankets, Hanna's sequence, the routes and shutters and lists — all of it had made the world so narrow that there was no longer enough width in it to stage the old indecision. She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all."

This is more explicit than Draft A's handling. Draft A reaches the same insight more austerely: "The choice had been lifted out of reach and the knowledge of that felt, for a moment, like rest. She knew what sort of feeling it was. It remained."

For this particular novel — which has spent 72,000 words working by implication — Draft A's compression is more in keeping with the method. But Draft B's sentence "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all" is the novel's clearest articulation of its protagonist's moral condition. It should survive, even if the surrounding material is trimmed back toward Draft A's brevity.

IV. THE TARIQ SUBPLOT

Both drafts handle Tariq with extraordinary restraint. He is never described in terms of attraction. The relationship is conveyed entirely through objects, timing, spatial awareness, and the testimony of coats. Both drafts share the same key details: the chipped mug suggesting habit, the cedar dust on dark wool, Amina's forensic brush of the coat, Hanna's competent silences.

The one difference worth noting, beyond the XVIII–XIX divergence already discussed, is in the Amina coat scene. Both drafts contain it and place it at the end of Chapter XIII. The prose is virtually identical. Draft A has: "the republic of matter, where ash, flour, chalk, and cedar all preserved their separate citizenship." Draft B: "the republic of matter, where ash, flour, chalk, and cedar all kept their separate citizenship." "Preserved" is marginally better — it implies active effort, which is what Amina is doing: preserving distinctions that the household around her is collapsing.

V. WHAT NEITHER DRAFT HAS FULLY SOLVED

1. Draft B's Chapter XVIII is too thin. At 2,022 words it is the shortest chapter in either manuscript, and it carries the novel's climax — the final Tariq sequence. The Tariq material itself is patient and fully developed. What is missing is the Maryam side: the streets, the school run, the texture of the day's contraction. In Draft A this material gives the reader the physical experience of the quarter closing down before the departure. In Draft B the household goes from "Hanna said the rooms are open" to the Tariq scene without the reader having felt the roads. This material should be recovered — not with the note (Maryam must not receive it), but as the first half of the chapter, before the perspective shifts to Tariq.

2. The Nawal thread. Both drafts handle Nawal's death through aftermath, which is correct for the novel's method. Draft B's Chapter XIII recovers the two unanswered notes in the handbag — one written before Semiramis, one the day before the explosion — and the line "even the dead still wrote in the grammar of next week" is one of the strongest in either manuscript. But after Chapter XIII, Nawal drops out of the novel's active consciousness. A single moment of recall in XVI or XVII — even a glance at the drawer where the card was placed, even the physical act of not opening the drawer — would maintain the thread without overplaying it.

3. Chapter numbering and formatting. Both manuscripts have inconsistent chapter header formatting. Some chapters are marked CHAPTER IX, some **CHAPTER IX**, some just with a bare Roman numeral. This needs to be standardised in the final version.

VI. VERDICT

Neither draft outclasses the other. Both are the same novel, and both are very good. The strongest version is a third draft built from the best of each, using Draft B as the base text and restoring specific material from Draft A.

Use Draft B for:

- The XVIII–XIX architecture. Maryam does not receive the note. The omniscient break stays.

- The Chapter V opening (aphorism first).

- Chapter XIII title: "The Half-Emptied Flat."

- The cut of the "chapter's true price" metafictional line.

- The Chapter XX key image ("as if darkness could tell brass from shadow").

- "Ordinary indignities persisted. So did ordinary mercies."

- "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all."

Restore from Draft A:

- The Chapter I opening paragraph: "lying no longer in his flat but in the mortuary room."

- The doorway negation: "not because she was overcome but because."

- "With disgust and accuracy."

- "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners."

- The spectacles on the sideboard from Chapter V ("tidiness or betrayal").

- "A mug suggested habit, and habit was bad enough" — cut Draft B's "affair" gloss.

- Chapter XIV opening: "which was perhaps the exact cruelty of it."

- "It was not a wound or a triumph. It was only an alteration."

- Chapter XIV title: "After."

- Chapter XVIII opening: "By breakfast the house had begun measuring itself in shorter units."

- The school-run and street material from Draft A's XVIII, repositioned so Maryam does not receive the note.

- "Preserved their separate citizenship" over "kept."

- Draft A's more compressed ending paragraphs in XX, with Draft B's "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all" grafted in.

Rewrite or develop:

- Bulk up Draft B's Chapter XVIII with recovered street-level material from Draft A (approximately 800–1,200 additional words on the Maryam side before the Tariq shift).
- Add one brief moment of Nawal recall in Chapter XVI or XVII.
- Standardise chapter headers throughout.

VII. A NOTE ON THE NOVEL ITSELF

It would be dishonest to write this analysis without saying that both drafts are operating at a level of sustained prose intelligence that is rare. The sentence-by-sentence quality is high and consistent across 70,000+ words. The novel's method — treating domestic objects and bureaucratic paper as the medium through which historical catastrophe is experienced — is wholly achieved. The character work, particularly Maryam, Hanna, Aunt Widad, Leila, and Amina, is precise and alive. The restraint with which the Tariq subplot is handled is the most technically accomplished element of either draft; the Amina coat scene alone is worth the read.

The differences between the drafts are real but they are the differences between a strong novel and a marginally stronger version of the same novel. The task now is assembly, not rescue.

REPLY V1 II C II

QATAMON: A Comparative Analysis of Two Drafts

PRELIMINARY ORIENTATION

Both drafts are complete twenty-chapter novels. Draft A (*Complete First Draft Polish*) runs to approximately 76,300 words. Draft B (*QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash*) runs to

approximately 72,100 words. The difference is not missing content on Draft B's side but reflects Draft B being the tighter editorial pass throughout. They share the same essential architecture, the same cast, the same sequence of events, and the same thematic logic. They are not radically different conceptions of the same story; they are two stages of the same draft, with Draft B the more advanced version of the first half and, in several chapters, the far more fully realised version of the second.

A hybrid is required. One draft does not clearly outclass the other across its full length. Draft A preserves sentence-level precision that Draft B has occasionally smoothed flat. Draft B resolves the second half with a moral and structural exactness that Draft A does not match, and in two chapters — XVIII and XIX — Draft A is plainly incomplete. The task is therefore specific: establish which draft governs the working text by chapter, restore what has been lost from each, and address what neither has yet solved.

WHAT THE NOVEL IS DOING

Before comparing the drafts it is worth being clear about what the novel is, because several of its apparent risks are in fact its strongest commitments.

The subject is not the Nakba. It is what the Nakba does to domestic time — specifically to the time of a woman who is simultaneously managing a condolence house, sorting a dead uncle's papers, conducting an affair with the man helping sort them, failing to visit a friend who will die in a hotel bombing, and watching her city narrow street by street. The catastrophe enters not through announcement but through routes avoided, bread prices, a wireless left on too late, the hour at which a servant can no longer get home. Nothing is named loudly. The form — close third-person domestic realism, obsessive attention to objects and protocols, political pressure arriving through the side door of social behaviour — is not timidity. It is formal precision. The scale is correct. The subject of the novel is not what Jerusalem was losing but what the people inside it were doing with the last hours of their ordinary life, and how those hours were already morally compromised before history arrived to make the question moot.

The use of paper as the novel's central metaphor — Yusef's estate, Hanna's files, the copying machine at Habib's, the notes sent by schoolboys on bicycles, the certificates that must be kept in the inner pocket — is not a conceit. Paper in this novel is what stands between people and the confrontation of what they are doing, and it is also what outlasts people when the confrontation arrives too late. That the affair begins in a dead man's flat under cover of estate management, and ends when the roads make a note undeliverable, is structurally exact.

The choice not to render the political catastrophe through its own drama is also correct. Both drafts earn this choice. Deir Yassin enters through bread. The UN vote arrives in the wireless register of a smooth announcer voice nobody trusts. The first sign that Hanna understands the situation is that he leaves his hat unbrushed. The novel knows what it is doing here, and it should be trusted.

MACROSCOPIC ANALYSIS: STRUCTURE, PLOT, AND PACING

The novel's structure is clean and well-proportioned. The condolence house of Chapter I establishes the domestic world, the class protocols, the central characters, and introduces Tariq through the practical pretext of the dead man's papers. The affair builds across the flat-sorting chapters through the middle section. The Semiramis explosion (Chapter IX) is the structural hinge — it delivers the lethal consequence of delay as literal event, converts Maryam's postponements from character trait into moral history, and introduces Amina's active role in managing what the household now requires. The second half tracks the contraction: the city narrowing, the house filling with displaced relatives, the flat emptying, and the departure, which is not an ending but the correct absence of one.

The arc is sound in both drafts. There are, however, three pacing problems that both carry and neither has resolved.

The Huda/landlord scene in Chapter III runs longer than the novel needs. The landlord exchange is necessary — it shows Hanna operating in his specific mode of protection-without-warmth, and it gives Maryam the occasion to see the school fees receipt and understand that Hanna's practical loyalty is continuous even where it excludes her. But the walk-home dialogue after the landlord leaves runs approximately a third too long, and the scene of moving the bed and cabinet, while not without merit, overstays. Trim by roughly a third in this section without cutting the scene's function.

The chapter-opening problem. Both drafts use some variant of "the house had altered/resumed" to open Chapter I, Chapter II, Chapter IV, and Chapter XII. Chapter V in Draft A repeats almost verbatim the opening paragraph of Chapter IV — the same furniture-of-grief description used to announce that the house has returned to normal. This is the most significant structural error in Draft A. Draft B solves it for Chapter V with a better opening line. The device of announcing the house's changed state is used too many times regardless. The chapters beginning with Chapter XII onward should vary their entry points — some should begin in action, or mid-conversation, or on a street.

The middle section's digression rate. Chapters V through VII carry more Amina-and-Aunt-Widad-at-table material than the novel can sustain at that point. The ensemble comedy of

the household is one of the novel's genuine pleasures and serves a real function — it externalises Maryam's interiority through other people's exactness — but by Chapter VI several of the set-piece exchanges have begun to feel mechanical. One of the Leila-at-table sequences and one of Aunt Widad's accounting scenes could be trimmed without loss.

CHARACTER WORK

Maryam is rendered with real intelligence. The novel refuses to make her sympathetic in the comfortable sense — she understands the machinery of her own self-deception precisely, can name what she is doing while still doing it, and the clarity does not redeem her. That is a difficult thing to sustain across twenty chapters and both drafts sustain it. The moment in Chapter IX where Nawal's confirmation arrives and Maryam feels "not merely pain but exposure" — the whole mechanism of defensible postponement reduced by a child to arithmetic — is one of the novel's best. Neither draft handles this badly.

Hanna is one of the novel's genuine achievements and the place where the drafts diverge most productively. He is rendered entirely through behaviour — the receipt under the sugar bowl, the spectacles picked up and set down untouched, the envelope marked "if needed," the hat unbrushed on the day Deir Yassin enters through bread. His affection is never stated, which is correct. He is not cold; he is structural. His love arrives in the form of prevention and allocation. The line that best captures him — "I have given you five more minutes," and Maryam's recognition that mercy in him could only arrive through measure — is in Draft B's Chapter XIX and not in Draft A's. It is the single most important line in the novel about this character and it must be in the final text.

Tariq functions well through most of both drafts but is almost entirely seen through Maryam's observation, which creates a risk of his becoming instrumental rather than inhabited. Chapter XI ("Tariq's Mother") is the corrective, and both drafts have it. His own domestic world — the old mug, his mother's dispersed property copies, the medicine sorted into the case, the equation between himself and Hanna that his mother's sentence makes visible — gives him one chapter of genuine interiority. It is enough, but only barely. The chapter works, and the image of the chipped mug and the duplicate key on the washstand as a two-object portrait of his situation is precise. The problem is that after this chapter he reverts to being read by Maryam. The demand scene in Chapter XV gives him one moment of losing composure — "you become honest for half a second and then retreat into furniture" — and that is the right kind of edge on him. The novel is close to having solved Tariq but has not fully crossed the line.

Amina is the novel's moral fulcrum and both drafts treat her well, though Draft B treats her better in the later chapters. She is never explained, never sentimentalised, and never reduced to a device. Her labour is what the novel's conscience runs on precisely because she would reject the description. The pantry scene in Chapter VIII — building an explanation for Maryam's late return entirely from materials already available to the house, then in private rubbing the ink from Maryam's thumb — and the later line "In houses, most things are [matters of cleaning]" establish her as someone whose knowledge is practical, complete, and without judgment in the dramatic sense. She does not forgive. She manages. The distinction is important and both drafts maintain it. Her final line in Chapter XIX — "Until there is a table again" — is the right note.

Leila is used brilliantly throughout as both comic instrument and moral pressure. Her literalness cuts at exactly the moments when adult self-deception has become most elaborate. "Then you cannot visit tomorrow" after Nawal's death is the most damaging sentence in the novel precisely because it is spoken without knowledge of what it damages. "There is too much marriage in [your] room" is funny and also the first crack in the novel's surface composure. The child is never cute and never precocious in the grating sense. She is simply younger than the self-knowledge the adults are deploying, and therefore more accurate.

Nawal Khoury deserves mention because the novel does something unusual with her. She is present for only two scenes, yet her death changes the moral weight of everything that preceded it. The key to this is that she is rendered as a specific person — the hat adjusted after the gate rather than before — rather than a narrative function. Amina's "I knew her hat" is the sentence that achieves this most economically. Both drafts have it.

CHAPTER-BY-CHAPTER DIVERGENCES

The following are the chapters where the drafts differ significantly. Where the content is essentially identical, nothing is said.

Chapter V opening. Draft A opens Chapter V with the same description of the house returned from grief that opened Chapter IV — "The condolence mats were gone. The borrowed chairs had been carried back..." This is not repetition for effect. It is an oversight. Draft B opens Chapter V with: *"The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast."* This is a substantially better opening and the correct solution to the problem. Use Draft B's Chapter V opening.

Chapter XIII: the affair. Draft A titles this "The Price of Seeing." Draft B titles it "The Half-Emptied Flat." The content is largely the same. Draft B adds one detail the affair scene

needs: *"He paused twice, once to say her name and once for nothing at all except to see whether she had changed her mind while there was still time to possess one. The shock of his care made the thing harder, not easier."* This is the superior version of that moment — it gives the encounter a second's worth of male hesitation that changes its moral texture. Take Draft B's addition.

For the framing of the kiss itself, however, Draft A is better: *"It was a mistake recognised as itself while being committed and continued because recognition had arrived too late to save either of them from truth."* Draft B compresses this to *"The kiss, when it came, was recognised as a mistake even as it continued,"* which loses the crucial clause about recognition arriving too late. The error in both this sentence and this chapter was to see timing and knowledge as the same thing. Draft A's version understands the distinction. Restore it.

The material awkwardness of the scene — the hat pin, the spring's complaint, the laugh that becomes tears, *"Not no to this. No to stopping and pretending that improves anything"* — is handled comparably in both drafts. The restoration of the room afterwards (the dark window as mirror, the mug rinsed as though tea had simply concluded) is correct in both. Neither over-dignifies what has happened or punishes it theatrically.

Chapter XIV: the morning after. This is the most significant structural divergence in the first fifteen chapters.

Draft A titles this chapter "After" and gives it one scene — brief, technically competent, and insufficient for what the novel needs at this moment.

Draft B titles it "Less Room Than Before" and adds substantial material. Maryam and Huda walking to Habib's to collect the corrected bank draft; a street encounter with Tariq and Khalil, neither contrived nor romantic, observed by Huda with the intelligence of someone who knows exactly what she is choosing not to say: *"The schoolmaster has less patience in his face than before." / "That is not what I said." / "No. It may still be what I meant."* This exchange does something important: it gives Maryam a witness who neither accuses nor excuses her. Huda, as the novel's other displaced woman, understands something about the arithmetic of dependence and desire that she does not put into words, which is the correct register for her. The chapter closes with Hanna, in the dark: *"Less room than before. But room."* He means the house. He may mean more than the house. The sentence's ambiguity is the right ending for this chapter.

Take Draft B's Chapter XIV in full.

Chapter XVIII: the note. This is the most consequential structural difference between the two drafts, and it changes the moral argument of the ending.

In Draft A: Tariq sends the note — "Today. Four o'clock. The flat." — via a schoolboy. It arrives at the house. Maryam reads it. The family is already in motion toward displacement; she cannot go. He waits until dark and leaves. She possesses the note.

In Draft B: Tariq sends the note. The boy cannot get through the roads — watched streets, men who have decided the afternoon belongs to them. The note is returned to Tariq unopened. He sits in the flat until dark watching the light change. He leaves without closing the shutter, placing the envelope under the mug. Maryam never receives it. She lies that night in the schoolroom knowing only that somewhere in the city a man she could not answer had asked a question the day itself had made unanswerable. She does not know he asked it in writing. She does not know he waited.

Draft B's version is structurally and morally superior. The novel's whole argument has been that the city and its catastrophe collaborate with personal cowardice in ways indistinguishable to the person performing the cowardice. In Draft A, Maryam receives the note and circumstance prevents action — she is still, technically, a victim of timing. In Draft B, the city prevents even the question from reaching her, and she is left in genuine ignorance about whether he tried — which is both more historically accurate to what displacement does to communication, and more honest about the nature of the relief she feels when Hanna tells her the building was shut before dark. In Draft B, she feels relief at not having to decide. She does not know there was something to decide. That gap is the correct moral shape for the ending.

Draft B also gives Chapter XVIII Tariq's point of view for his waiting in the flat — the chair avoided all afternoon, the mug becoming too intimate as an object, Elias's question "Do you?" received without answer — and this is the right use of that perspective at that moment. It is the only extended scene from outside Maryam's point of view in the whole novel, and it earns its place precisely because it shows the reader what Maryam cannot know.

Take Draft B's Chapter XVIII in full.

Chapter XIX: the departure. Draft A's version of this chapter is competent in parts and incomplete in development.

Draft B's version is the novel's best chapter in the second half. It earns its title and contains several of the novel's finest passages. The packing of the mother's case with all its petty resistances — the shawl, the shoes, the hat — and the moment of genuine unexpected love: *"For one instant Maryam loved her, or loved what the sentence preserved of ordinary pettiness in a room where ordinary pettiness ought already to have been extinguished. Then the moment passed."* Amina brushing the coat on the back steps: *"There. Now it looks as if you still belong to your own coat."* The bed men dismantling the guest room, the screw that

won't yield, Leila watching as though the bed were a person undergoing treatment. Father Elias's truck arriving late carrying a widow with grandchildren. Loading. Huda: *"The smaller one. That one says one night. This one says your husband is right."* Amina's goodbye: *"Until there is a table again."* Hanna turning the key in the lock — *"The sound was not large. Metal, wood, a resistance overcome"* — and not lingering. The drive through Jerusalem exhibiting itself in sections.

And the chapter's centre:

Hanna in the bedroom doorway, where Maryam stands holding Yusef's key: *"I have given you five more minutes."*

"It took her a second to understand the grammar of it. Not take what you need. Not make it quick. Not we have no time. I have given you five more minutes. As if time were not hers in that room any longer and never had been; as if what he could offer was not understanding but measure; as if mercy itself, in him, could only arrive through allocation."

This is the novel's definitive statement about Hanna, and it arrives at exactly the right moment. It is not in Draft A in this form. It must be in the final text.

Take Draft B's Chapter XIX in full.

Chapter XX: the ending. Draft A's final chapter ends mid-sentence. It is unfinished. Draft B's Chapter XX is complete.

The schoolroom material in the first half of the chapter is essentially identical in both drafts and is strong: Amina's "You were meant to," Aunt Widad's hat as evidence from a better room, Leila's laugh as something Maryam receives with a small pain of gratitude, Father Elias with his bread and no capacity for sainthood, Leila's "Home is a somewhere" answered with "Yes. It is."

Draft B's ending goes further and is correct:

Maryam holding the key and understanding that objects adapt to a body without asking whether the body has the right to keep them. Then, lying in the dark with Leila's breathing beside her, the chapter's moral accounting:

"She grieved him in uncertainty. She grieved also the house, the quarter, the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still survive them. And beneath both griefs, because truth was meaner than dignity, ran the low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her."

Not hope — the chapter explicitly refuses that word. What had been withdrawn from the neighbourhood was *"the assumption that delay was still a harmless form of good breeding."*

And beneath the grief, the relief that the world had narrowed so far that the old indecision no longer had room to be staged. She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all. The necessity imposed by the city had done the work that cowardice preferred not to do explicitly. She knows this. The knowledge does not exonerate her. It is, in Draft B's phrasing, "a relief as ugly as the wash water in the basin."

The key is laid on the desk. *"In the morning it would still be there, small and displaced, opening nothing in the room where it had come to rest."*

This is the right ending for this novel — not resolution, but the correct weight of what has been lost and what cannot be honestly mourned because departure has not yet declared itself. Take Draft B's Chapter XX in full.

MICROSCOPIC ANALYSIS: SENTENCE AND PARAGRAPH LEVEL

The following are the specific sentence-level choices where one draft is demonstrably better than the other and the correct choice should be made explicitly in the working text.

Where Draft A is better:

"That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no." Draft B smooths this to: *"What stayed with her was not the stroke or the doctor, only the fact that no one had been with him."* The fragmented version enacts the thought precisely — the mind returning to the simplest word, not the medical fact. Restore Draft A's version.

Tariq's voice, first described. Draft A: *"His voice was lower than she had expected. Not rich. Simply controlled."* Draft B collapses this to *"controlled rather than rich."* The split sentence mimics the precision of the observation — the mind making a distinction, not offering a synonym. Restore Draft A's version.

Tariq's courtesy. Draft A: *"His courtesy was exact but lacked the faint softening men often brought into rooms like this."* Draft B: *"His courtesy was exact, without the faint softening."* "Lacked" is stronger than "without" because it implies a characteristic that has been removed rather than one that was never present. The word carries an active absence. Restore Draft A's version.

The observation after Huda's landlord leaves. Draft A adds, after describing Hanna's protection of Huda in the room: *"It was a form of protection too dry to look like one unless one watched closely."* Draft B ends the scene a sentence earlier. Draft A's addition is the better reading of the moment. Restore it.

Hanna characterised in his first unguarded moment. Draft A: *"He was simply, for one unguarded moment, telling the truth as he saw it."* Draft B: *"For once he was saying what he thought."* This is subtly inaccurate — Hanna always says what he thinks. His candour is not occasional; what is occasional is the unguardedness of its presentation. "For one unguarded moment" is right. Restore Draft A's version.

The affair's framing sentence, as noted above. Draft A's version must be restored.

The Nadia letter interiority in Chapter V. Draft A develops Maryam's reading of Nadia's first letter with more steps than Draft B, including the observation about the "yet" that has entered *"there is no need yet"* without permission. This additional interior passage is worth keeping.

Where Draft B is better:

"The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast." Use as Chapter V's opening sentence.

"Death, she thought, had created no grandeur, only work." Draft A renders this in two sentences that lose compression. Draft B's single sentence is better.

"He paused twice, once to say her name and once for nothing at all except to see whether she had changed her mind while there was still time to possess one. The shock of his care made the thing harder, not easier." Chapter XIII addition. Take it.

"Less room than before. But room." Chapter XIV's closing line. Take it.

"I have given you five more minutes." Chapter XIX. Take it.

"Until there is a table again." Chapter XIX, Amina's goodbye. Take it.

"In the morning it would still be there, small and displaced, opening nothing in the room where it had come to rest." Chapter XX's final sentence. Take it.

Various smaller tightenings throughout Chapters I–XII where Draft B has correctly cut a qualifying clause or simplified a sentence that was performing its precision at the cost of rhythm. These should be assessed line by line in the editing pass, with Draft B taken as the default and Draft A's versions restored where the sharpness is lost.

WHAT NEITHER DRAFT HAS FULLY SOLVED

Tariq's second half. Chapter XI gives him one chapter of genuine interiority and it works. After that, he is largely returned to being observed by Maryam. The demand scene in Chapter

XV is his best moment in the second half — *"you become honest for half a second and then retreat into furniture"* is the most damaging sentence he delivers in the novel, and it arrives from a real anger that both drafts render correctly. But his own situation under the city's pressure — his school, his quarter, his mother's redistributed property copies, the attendance ledger with its marginal notes about children sent ahead — is gestured at rather than inhabited once Chapter XI has passed. The novel would benefit from one additional scene, not long, in the middle section, in which Tariq's specific position in the city is made to press against his silence in the flat. This needn't break the novel's insistence on staying inside Maryam's perspective — it could be achieved through what she observes of him, or through the evidence of what he has been doing when she is not there. What it should not do is explain him.

Khalil Darwish is used as a walk-on for good lines and serves his function in Chapter XV as the person who forces the question Maryam has been avoiding. But he has been onstage in a dozen scenes before that and in none of them is he quite real. He is a function until Chapter XV, at which point he is briefly a person. One earlier scene — the school under pressure, Khalil managing fathers with the patience that almost qualifies as contempt — would make his Chapter XV role feel earned rather than conveniently deployed.

The chapter-opening frame. As noted, the "the house had resumed/altered" device is used too many times. In the final text, at least three of the chapter openings that use this frame should begin differently — in action, in dialogue, or on the street — without losing the novel's awareness of the house as a barometer of the situation.

Hanna's own weight. The novel handles Hanna with great intelligence, but he is consistently seen through Maryam's reading of his behaviour. There are moments — the phone call to his sister in Chapter X, the "I know" exchange after Nawal's death — where his own particular burden almost surfaces. The novel could allow this to happen once, briefly, without requiring sentiment or explanation. The "I have given you five more minutes" moment in Chapter XIX comes closest and is enough if handled carefully. But there is a version of the novel in which Hanna gets one moment — not of confession, not of breakdown, but of the kind of illegibility that Maryam has been trying to read for twenty chapters suddenly resolving into something too clear to deny — that would make the final chapter's silence between them more exact. This is not a requirement; it is the direction in which the novel is already pointing.

VERDICT AND HYBRID PRESCRIPTION

The novel is accomplished, fully formed in its conception, and earns its ambitions. The subject is handled with the correct restraint. The form serves the material. The ensemble of characters is managed with intelligence and without false note. The ending — what both drafts are reaching for in Chapter XX, and what Draft B achieves — is the right ending: not resolution, not comfort, not the dramatisation of loss, but the exact weight of what has been irreversibly begun.

The working text should be built as follows:

Start with Draft B as the base text throughout. Draft B is the more fully revised version of the first half and the more fully realised version of the second.

Restore from Draft A the following specific choices: the fragmented "Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no."; the split sentence for Tariq's voice ("Not rich. Simply controlled."); "but lacked" in the courtesy description; "for one unguarded moment"; the protection observation at Huda's; the affair's framing sentence in Chapter XIII; and the Nadia letter interiority in Chapter V. Assess the first half line by line in an editing pass with this principle: where Draft B has smoothed a sentence that was better fragmented, restore Draft A's version; where Draft A is more elaborate without being more precise, keep Draft B's cut.

Use Draft B's Chapter V opening sentence, discarding Draft A's repeated paragraph.

Use Draft B's Chapter XIII addition of the "paused twice" detail, retaining Draft A's affair framing sentence.

Use Draft B's Chapter XIV ("Less Room Than Before") in full.

Use Draft B's Chapter XVIII in full.

Use Draft B's Chapter XIX in full.

Use Draft B's Chapter XX in full.

Then address in rewriting what neither draft has yet solved: the chapter-opening repetition (at minimum three chapters need different entry points); the Huda/landlord scene in Chapter III trimmed by a third; one earlier scene establishing Khalil as a person rather than a function; and the possibility — not the obligation — of one moment in which Hanna's own weight briefly exceeds Maryam's capacity to read it.

THIS IS WHAT V2 II ASKED

These are two drafts of the same novel. Read them as two competing manuscripts and judge only what is on the page. Do not assume the newer draft is better, do not assume my preferred draft is the stronger one, and do not infer intention where the text itself does not earn it. I want a comprehensive comparative editorial judgement: which draft gives the stronger overall reading experience, where one clearly surpasses the other, where one gains by losing something the other had, and whether the best final version is Draft A, Draft B, or a third draft built from a precise synthesis of both. Please evaluate both macroscopically and microscopically: story architecture, plot, pacing, chapter-to-chapter movement, emotional force, character depth and consistency, thematic clarity, stylistic control, sentence and paragraph quality, and any places where one draft is materially sharper, truer, riskier, or more powerful than the other. If one draft is decisively better, say so plainly and explain why. If neither is fully superior, then propose the strongest possible Draft C: what to keep from each, what to cut from each, what has been lost in revision, what remains unsolved in both, and what would need to be newly written or reworked to produce the best version of the novel. Wherever possible, ground your judgement in concrete scenes, chapters, paragraphs, or lines rather than abstract preference. Treat this not as a workshop reaction but as an editorial adjudication between two serious versions of the same book. The aim is not diplomacy. It is to discover which version, or which synthesis, makes the best novel.

REPLY V2 II CG I

Verdict

Draft A is the stronger existing novel. Draft B is the better line-edit in patches. Those are not the same thing.

If I had to choose one manuscript as it stands, I would choose **Draft A**.

If the aim is the **best possible final book**, I would not publish either unchanged. I would build **Draft C on Draft A**, using Draft B as a surgical tool rather than as the governing version.

The blunt reason is simple: **B improves the book whenever it cuts explanation; it hurts the book whenever it cuts consequence.** In the final movement, it cuts consequence.

The macro judgement

For roughly the first twelve chapters, these are largely the same novel with different levels of compression. The real fork begins in the **affair / aftermath / demand / note / departure / key** sequence. That is where the adjudication lives.

The book's real engine is not plot in the conventional sense. It is **accretion**: grief becoming paperwork, paperwork becoming pretext, pretext becoming intimacy, intimacy becoming impossible once rooms, roads, schools, and departures begin tightening. That is the book's originality. Desire does not erupt in spite of administration; it grows **through** administration.

Both drafts understand that in the first half. **Draft A keeps understanding it in the last act. Draft B partially stops.**

Where Draft B is better

B is not cosmetic. It contains real improvements.

First, **sentence discipline**. B often removes the extra sentence that tells the reader what the image has already done. In early chapters especially, that helps. The opening is marginally cleaner. Some chapter endings stop a beat sooner. In Chapter III, for instance, B is right to end earlier rather than adding one more interpretive turn on Hanna.

Second, B is often **better when it replaces abstraction with concrete pressure**. The clearest example is the intimacy scene in Chapter XIII. A has some excellent material there, but it occasionally explains itself. B is stronger when it makes the scene physical again: the pause, the crack in the plaster, the unchanged room, the fact that care makes the act harder rather than softer. That is a genuine gain.

Third, **B's Tariq-waiting material is excellent**. The chapter built around his waiting in the flat, the boy returning on foot, the envelope unopened, the mug on the sill: that is first-rate. It gives Tariq humiliation, duration, and a life outside Maryam's field of feeling. That should not be lost.

Fourth, a few of B's later additions around the **key** and the "ugly relief" of choice being removed are strong. Not all of them. But some are worth stealing.

So B is not inferior across the board. It is often sharper, cleaner, and more mistrustful of its own eloquence. That is good editorial instinct.

Where Draft A is better

Here the answer is more important.

1. A is better about Maryam

This is the biggest difference.

The novel works because Maryam is not innocent. She is not a villain either. She is a woman whose delays, evasions, decencies, and failures of timing are the novel's real tragedy. The Nawal line is built on that. The hotel line is built on that. Tariq is built on that.

A keeps Maryam morally active. B too often lets circumstance do the dirtiest work for her.

The note sequence is the decisive example. In B, the undelivered note is clean tragedy. The city intervenes. The boy cannot get through. The envelope returns. It is elegant, and it is weaker.

In A, the note reaches Maryam too late, and she must **carry it**. Then the case appears. Then the note is hidden away. Then it goes with her. That is far better. It is dirtier, more compromising, and more truthful to the book already written. This novel should not let history take all the blame. It needs Maryam's evasiveness to remain live.

2. A is better in Chapters XVIII–XIX by a clear margin

This is where I stop being balanced.

A's "The Note" and "Five More Minutes" are materially stronger than B's versions.

In A, the emotional architecture locks into place:

- the note arrives too late,
- Tariq waits,
- Hanna sees enough without forcing speech,
- the case is packed,
- the note remains physically present,
- the departure happens under that pressure,
- the key becomes the surviving object.

That is devastating because the book has trained us, chapter after chapter, to understand the moral meaning of objects: cards, cups, files, receipts, stockings, keys, mugs, maps, cases. A cashes that out properly.

B, by contrast, becomes too efficient. It separates Tariq's waiting into a strong scene, then compresses Maryam's side and removes the filth of her carrying the unanswered note. That is false economy. **The late act should feel overfull, not elegantly streamlined.**

3. A is better about consequence after the affair

The affair itself is strong in both. The difference is what comes after.

A understands that the act is not the climax. The real climax is what the act does to timing, speech, movement, and silence afterwards. B knows this, but it shortens the bruise time. A lets the bruise spread.

That matters because the book's moral centre is not sex; it is **postponement collapsing into body, and then body having to re-enter duty**. A makes that re-entry hurt more.

4. A is riskier about Hanna, and that helps

Hanna is one of the best things in the book. In both drafts he is never simplified into husband-as-obstacle. Good. That would have killed the novel.

But A keeps a few harder Maryam-thoughts about him that B trims away. Those thoughts are often cruel, and sometimes perhaps one sentence too many, but they keep Hanna difficult. He is not just competence and decency. He is a man whose care arrives as allocation, measure, sequence. The line **"I have given you five more minutes"** is one of the best in either draft because it contains both mercy and domination without reducing him to either.

B's pruning around Hanna is sometimes wise, but sometimes it also removes friction the book needs.

Chapter-to-chapter movement

The strongest continuous run in both drafts is roughly **VI to X**: the radio, the neighbourhood listening to itself receive history, the failure to get to the Semiramis, the blast, and the aftermath. That is where the novel proves it can turn public event into domestic consequence without speeches.

The strongest single confrontation is in **Chapter XV**: **"I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another."** That lands in both drafts. It is the right line, and the bed-men interruption cuts it correctly.

The structural difference is what happens after that confrontation. **A honours it. B partially evades it.**

Character judgement

Maryam: stronger in A, because she is less protected.

Hanna: excellent in both. B tidies him; A leaves him more dangerous.

Tariq: slightly stronger in B in isolation because the waiting scene gives him more autonomous life. But A gives the relationship better novelistic consequence.

Amina: excellent in both. Do not soften her. Do not make her more "sympathetic". She is already human and indispensable.

Aunt Widad: likewise excellent. She is not mere comic relief; she is one of the book's structural braces.

Nawal: still slightly under-furnished in both. She is vivid enough to matter, but I would still want one more page of her earlier. Not a lot. One more page.

Leila: good and necessary, but the book could use one less witty-child line and one more genuinely intimate mother-daughter beat.

Thematic clarity

The book's themes are clear in both versions:

- grief becomes administration;
- respectability polices movement more effectively than direct prohibition;
- history narrows space before anyone manages a clean choice;
- the private and political are fused through routes, rooms, and objects.

A generally lets those themes emerge through **object-work**. B more often **states** them. That is the pattern.

When this book is strongest, it does not tell you the theme; it lets the **mug, the note, the key, the bed, the map, the stockings, the case** do the work.

Draft C: the strongest possible version

This is the precise synthesis I would build.

1. **Use Draft A as the base text.** Not negotiable.
2. **Line-edit Chapters I–XII against Draft B.** Take B's cleaner compressions where it has cut a redundant after-sentence, tightened a chapter ending, or replaced abstraction with physical detail.

3. **Keep A's architecture from Chapter XIII onward.**
   Keep **"The Price of Seeing"** as the Chapter XIII title. B's **"The Half-Emptied Flat"** is serviceable and weaker.
   For Chapter XIV, I would actually consider B's **"Less Room Than Before"** over A's **"After"**.

4. **For the intimacy scene, use A's structure with selected B substitutions.**
   Keep A's fuller moral and psychological build. Import B's concrete physical revisions where A becomes essayistic.

5. **For the note/departure sequence, keep A's structure and consequences, but steal B's Tariq-waiting texture.**
   This is the core of Draft C.
   Keep A's late-arriving note, Maryam's knowledge, the note on the bed, the note under the stockings, and the continuity into displacement.
   Import from B the stronger external detail of Tariq's waiting and the boy's return.
   What you should **not** keep is B's underlying decision to leave Maryam ignorant. That lets her off.

6. **For the ending, use A's restraint with a few of B's best additions.**
   B has some useful lines about the ugly relief of choice collapsing. Use those sparingly.
   Do not let the final chapter become a closing argument about its own meaning. The key on the desk is enough.

What remains unsolved in both

Three things.

First, the book is a little too fond of its own recurring lexicon: **exact, practical, sequence, ordinary, arrangement, rooms, manage/manageable**. Those words are part of the book's system, so I would not purge them, but I would cut where the echo becomes habit rather than design.

Second, some chapter endings still take one explanatory step too far. This is mostly an A problem, and B often helps. The rule for revision should be: **cut commentary, not consequence.**

Third, Nawal and Leila each need one more notch of life. Not much. Just enough that Nawal's absence and Leila's presence bear even more weight without the novel needing to explain either.

Final call

Existing manuscript: Draft A.
Best possible novel: Draft C, built on Draft A.
Plain reason: A is the stronger book because it is harsher about timing, consequence, and Maryam's responsibility. B is often the sharper prose, but it weakens the novel when it tries to make the late act cleaner than the novel's moral logic will support.

That is the judgement.

REPLY V2 II CG II

I compared Draft A and Draft B as submitted manuscripts, not as intentions. The blunt verdict is this: **Draft A is the stronger reading experience on the page.** If I had to choose one file to send out tomorrow, it would be A. If I were choosing the best possible version of the novel from the material in both, it would **not** be either draft intact. It would be a **Draft C built mainly from B's revision logic, but with several important restorations from A.**

The first reason A wins is not subtle. **Draft B, as a submitted object, is badly hobbled by its formatting.** Its contents page runs Chapter II to page 33 and Chapter XX to page 404, while A runs to page 270; yet on a rough extraction from the files, B is actually shorter, not longer. Reading B on the page, many prose lines are broken into separate paragraph units, which destroys paragraph pressure, rhythm, and stamina. Because you explicitly asked me to judge what is on the page, I cannot excuse that as an implementation detail. It is part of the manuscript the reader receives, and it materially weakens it.

If I strip that away and judge the underlying prose only, the contest gets much closer. Then the real answer is: **B has the better editorial instincts in a number of important places, but A keeps several human truths that B trims away.** So A is the better submitted manuscript; B is the more promising revision; C is the better novel.

The macro judgement

Both drafts know what book they are. This is not a panoramic historical novel pretending to be about "Jerusalem"; it is a pressure novel about rooms, errands, propriety, grief, administration, desire, and the way public catastrophe enters a household first as inconvenience, then as rearrangement, then as moral injury. That architecture is sound in both drafts. The basic movement — Yusef's death, the papers, Tariq's entry, the neighbourhood's surveillance, the tightening city, Semiramis, the affair, the narrowing of domestic and public space, the failed note, the displaced key — is strong and properly cumulative.

Where both drafts are vulnerable is the middle. The novel's machinery is excellent, but it is sometimes **over-proved**: papers, claims, copying, visits, rumours, neighbourhood observation, practical rearrangements. The material is good; the issue is repetition of function. A is more exposed here. B is better at cutting the extra beat before the beat. That is one reason B often feels more authoritative as revision, even when it is not ultimately the truer text.

Where B clearly surpasses A

B is usually better at **chapter attack**. The cleanest example is Chapter V. A opens with a preparatory sentence — "On Monday morning the house resumed itself..." — before reaching the real line. B cuts the run-up and starts where it should: **"The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast."** That is simply stronger. It arrives faster, lands harder, and trusts the line. A earns it; B places it correctly.

B is also better in Chapter VI. A begins abstractly with the papers no longer behaving like grief and beginning to behave like work. That is intelligent but second-order. B opens in weather and body: cold Jerusalem air, Leila saying the day resembles a doctor. That is better fiction. It lets the abstraction emerge from scene instead of announcing it first. B repeatedly does this in the middle third: it restores physical entry before reflective intelligence. That improves pace and chapter-to-chapter movement.

B is slightly better in the **affair chapter as enacted scene**, even though I think it gives that chapter the worse title. A calls Chapter XIII **"The Price of Seeing"**; B renames it **"The Half-Emptied Flat."** That title change is a loss. It trades moral voltage for accurate furniture. But inside the scene, B adds one of the best revisions in either manuscript: Tariq pauses "to see whether she had changed her mind while there was still time to possess one." That is excellent. It makes the scene more exact, more adult, and more dangerous by being more careful. A's scene is already strong, but B gives it a better human brake.

B is also better in **late structural reweighting**, especially across Chapters XVIII–XIX. A's Chapter XVIII ends beautifully with the note and the case sharing one room: "One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early." That is strong writing. But B's redistribution of material around the failed note is better novel architecture. Its Chapter XIX ending — where Maryam does not know that the note has been written, carried, returned unopened, and placed under the mug — tightens the emotional trap. It binds Tariq's failed reach, Maryam's ignorance, and the city's intervention into one structure rather than three parallel feelings. That is a real gain.

B also improves thematic coherence through its **spatial lexicon**. The retitling from A's Chapter XIV **"After"** to B's **"Less Room Than Before"** is a clear improvement. "After" is a placeholder. "Less Room Than Before" belongs to this novel's governing method. B understands more consistently than A that the book's deepest metaphor is not abstract guilt or passion but the literal reduction of available room — social, moral, domestic, political.

Where A clearly surpasses B

A is better whenever the novel needs to preserve a **psychological after-image** rather than a clean line. The single most obvious loss in B is Hanna. In A, after the Huda/claims material, Maryam thinks that **"some men made themselves indispensable in order not to have to say who they were when they sat still."** B cuts that. It should not have been cut. It is one of the sharpest Hanna lines in the book. Without it, he risks becoming too purely functional — an instrument of competence rather than a man whose competence is itself a form of emotional defence. That cut weakens character depth, marital tension, and the novel's moral intelligence all at once.

A is stronger in its **moral naming**. Again, Chapter XIII is the best example. **"The Price of Seeing"** is a better title than **"The Half-Emptied Flat."** B's title is serviceable, but it undersells the hinge. The chapter is not chiefly about a room being partly cleared. It is about the cost of recognising something and proceeding anyway. A names the moral event. B names the furniture. A wins.

A is also stronger in the **household-contracting material** that surrounds the late crisis. B's Chapter XVIII is structurally cleaner, but it is probably too compressed. A gives more of the house measuring itself in shorter units, more of the degraded ordinary, more of the morning domesticity under pressure. That matters, because the novel's greatness lies precisely in making catastrophe arrive through habit. B knows what to sacrifice; sometimes it sacrifices the wrong thing. In late chapters, A lets you feel the cost before it cashes it in. B sometimes cashes it in too quickly.

A is also, at its best, **truer in uglier ways**. B is usually sharper. A is sometimes truer. By that I mean: A occasionally keeps the slightly awkward, over-specific, self-accusing thought that a polished revision wants to sand down. In this book, those thoughts often belong to the character, not to authorial slackness. B improves a great deal by trimming exposition, but it sometimes trims the very residue that makes the feeling stick.

Character by character

Maryam is excellent in both drafts. No issue there. The intelligence, vanity, resentment, hunger, classed self-consciousness, and moral evasiveness all hold. But A lets her keep a little more of the embarrassing second thought. That helps.

Hanna is better in A. Not because A sentimentalises him — it does not — but because it preserves more of the interpretation around him. B risks reducing him to competence. A better shows why that competence is both admirable and suffocating.

Tariq is slightly better in B. Not wholesale, but in key moments. B trims away some of the aura and leaves more exact human conduct. The added pause in the affair scene is the best example.

Amina and **Aunt Widad** are first-rate in both. They are among the book's strongest assets. The novel would lose half its authority without them.

Nawal works in both because the book makes her exact before it makes her absent. That is why Semiramis hurts.

Style, sentence control, paragraph control

At sentence level, both drafts are strong. Too strong, sometimes. The recurring risk in both is **composed exactness** becoming a house style. When every important feeling arrives in a sentence that already knows it is quotable, the prose starts admiring its own calibration. B edges closer to that danger in the late chapters. A sometimes drifts into the opposite problem: one sentence too many after the point has landed.

At paragraph level, though, **A wins by a mile as submitted**, because B's page-level paragraphing is broken. Even if B contains better surgery beneath the surface, the submitted document destroys the reader's ability to feel paragraph accumulation properly. On your terms — what is on the page — that is fatal.

The strongest Draft C

This is the book I would build:

1. **Take B as the base text for content and structure.** Its revision intelligence is real.
2. **Re-paragraph the entire manuscript properly.** Non-negotiable.
3. **Restore A's Chapter XIII title: "The Price of Seeing."** Keep B's Chapter XIV title: "Less Room Than Before." B wins one title fight; A wins the other.
4. **Restore A's deleted Hanna material, especially the "indispensable / sat still" thought.** Without that, Hanna thins out too much.
5. **Keep B's Chapter V and VI improvements.** The harder opening to Chapter V and the colder, more embodied opening to Chapter VI are better.

6. **Keep B's added pause/consent beat in the affair scene**, but do not automatically prefer all of B's tightening there. A's moral pressure should remain audible.
7. **Use B's late structure for Chapters XVIII–XIX**, but splice back a little more of A's household contraction before the note sequence.
8. **Watch B's late polished lines.** Some are excellent. A few sit just on the edge of sounding written rather than lived.

Bottom line

Here is the clean answer.

Which draft is the stronger manuscript on the page? Draft A.

Which draft contains the better revision intelligence in places? Draft B.

Which version makes the best novel? Draft C: B's cleaner spine, A's richer nerve endings.

One sentence version: **Draft A is the better submitted manuscript; Draft B is the better partial surgery; the best book is neither, but a very precise synthesis.**

REPLY V2 II C I

QATAMON — Editorial Adjudication Between Two Drafts

Draft A: *Complete First Draft Polish*

Draft B: *QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash*

Verdict

Draft B is the stronger novel. It is not close.

Draft B is tighter, structurally sounder, and makes one decision — the Tariq point-of-view chapter — that transforms the ending from very good to genuinely great. Its sentence-level edits are almost uniformly improvements. Its compressions lose nothing essential except four specific phrases that should be restored.

A Draft C is not required. Draft B is Draft C. It needs only targeted restorations, minor trims, and two small additions. The details follow.

I. Scale and Structure

Both drafts share the same 20-chapter skeleton, the same chapter titles (with two exceptions at XIII and XIV), and roughly 85–90% of their actual prose at the sentence level. The differences are surgical, not wholesale.

- **Draft A:** ~76,500 words across 20 chapters (XIX and XX combined into one massive final chapter of ~7,077 words).
- **Draft B:** ~72,200 words across 20 chapters, with the endgame reorganised into three chapters.

Chapters I–XVII are within 2–5% of each other in word count. The real structural divergence is concentrated in the final quarter:

- **Draft A endgame:** Ch XVIII (3,770w) + Ch XIX (7,077w) = 10,847 words across two chapters, no Tariq POV scene, no chapter break before the schoolroom.
- **Draft B endgame:** Ch XVIII (2,020w) + Ch XIX (3,173w) + Ch XX (3,031w) = 8,224 words across three chapters, with the Tariq waiting scene and a chapter break before the final morning.

Draft B's endgame is about 2,600 words leaner yet contains material (Tariq's chapter) that Draft A lacks entirely. Draft B cut roughly 3,500 words of Maryam-side material from the departure sequence while adding 2,000 words of Tariq. The result is tighter and emotionally richer.

II. The Three Most Significant Structural Decisions

1. Chapter XVIII — Tariq's Perspective

This is the single most important editorial decision between the two manuscripts.

Draft A's Chapter XVIII ("The Note") is told entirely from Maryam's side of the household on the day of departure. Draft B replaces approximately half of this material with a scene written from Tariq's point of view: he writes the note, sends the boy on the bicycle, waits in the flat, watches the light thin, and receives the unopened envelope back.

In Draft A, Tariq remains a figure seen only through Maryam's consciousness. That works through the affair and the consummation. It does not work at the end. By the time the novel reaches its final movement, Maryam's interiority alone cannot carry the weight of what the affair costs. The reader needs to see Tariq waiting in the stripped flat, receiving the unopened letter, placing it under the mug. Without that scene, the closing paragraphs — "She did not know that a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened..." — arrive as authorial information rather than earned dramatic irony. In Draft B, the reader has lived through both sides. The convergence of the two unknowings is devastating. Draft A tells you about it. Draft B makes you feel both halves.

2. Chapter XIX — Compression

Draft A's Chapter XIX runs to over 7,000 words. It is by far the longest chapter in either manuscript. It contains the packing, the mother's case, the bed men, the truck, the arrival at the schoolroom, the passage goodbye with Hanna, and the final nocturnal meditation. Draft B splits this material: the packing and bed-removal go into Chapter XIX (now much shorter), and the overnight scene at the schoolroom becomes Chapter XX.

This is structurally correct. Draft A's XIX dilutes its own climax. By the time you reach "I have given you five more minutes" — one of the finest moments in the entire novel — you have been reading at high pitch for too long. Draft B's division gives the departure its own chapter and the schoolroom its own chapter. The reader breathes. The final chapter lands harder for having space around it.

3. Chapter XV — Draft A's Excess

Draft A's Chapter XV ("The Demand") runs to nearly 4,800 words and contains material Draft B distributes more wisely. The breakfast scene is superb, but the chapter accumulates too many errands and too many conversations before its emotional centre arrives. Draft B trims this by approximately one page's worth of domestic business, which is still substantial and tighter for it.

III. Chapter Title Changes

Draft B renames two chapters:

- Ch XIII: "The Price of Seeing" → "The Half-Emptied Flat"
- Ch XIV: "After" → "Less Room Than Before"

Both changes are improvements. "The Price of Seeing" is abstract and slightly sententious. "The Half-Emptied Flat" keeps the room metaphor operational. "After" is so generic it could title any chapter in any novel. "Less Room Than Before" is specific and echoes the narrowing arc. The novel's governing metaphor — rooms emptied, rooms narrowed, rooms lost — runs through every chapter title, and these revised titles participate more honestly in that pattern.

IV. Prose Quality — Sentence-Level Comparison

Where the two drafts share identical passages, the prose is excellent in both. This is a genuinely distinguished novel at the sentence level. Where the drafts diverge, Draft B is almost always sharper.

Draft B's Improvements

Chapter I opening. Draft A: "not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private." Draft B cuts "not because she was overcome but" and goes straight to the observation. The parenthetical self-explanation weakened the moment.

Chapter I, Yusef's death. Draft A: "That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no." This is fine but slightly mannered with the isolated "The no." Draft B: "What stayed with her was not the stroke or the doctor, only the fact that no one had been with him." Plainer, sadder, better.

Chapter I, Amina. Draft A: "She never wasted an answer when work could be used as an answer instead." Draft B: "She never wasted an answer when work would serve in its place." Slightly more natural rhythm.

Chapter XIII, the kiss. Draft A: "The first kiss was not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable. It was a mistake recognised as itself while being committed and continued because recognition had arrived too late to save either of them from truth." Draft B: "The kiss, when it came, was recognised as a mistake even as it continued." One sentence. Ruthless. More efficient — though see Section V below for what this compression loses.

Chapter XIII, Hanna's knowledge. Draft A: "...and it was not a gift she could use." Draft B: "...and one she could do nothing with." Marginally sharper.

Chapter XII ending. Draft A: "Not emptier. Worse than empty. Precisely occupied." Draft B cuts the first two fragments and keeps "The wrong people in the right rooms..." This is a gain in momentum, though the loss of the "removing alibis" line (see below) weakens the passage overall.

Final chapter, closing meditation. Draft A: "Relief came with the knowledge and at once made itself ugly." Draft B: "She felt, alongside grief, the shameful ease of having been spared the last movement of will. She hated it at once and could not prevent it existing." More specific, more honest, more painful. Draft B also adds: "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all. Yet the necessity others had begun carrying for her left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded." This is excellent new material that sharpens the novel's argument about agency and history.

Final chapter, the key. Draft A: "It warmed almost immediately." (Full stop, end of paragraph.) Draft B adds: "That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether one had the right to keep them." The addition earns itself.

Draft B's Notable Addition in the Semiramis Chapter (IX)

After the mother says "It was the Semiramis," Draft B inserts Hanna hanging his coat and saying: "It was placed. Not thrown. Placed." This is an excellent addition. It sharpens

Hanna's character — he processes catastrophe through its mechanics, not its emotion — and introduces the political dimension (a placed bomb, not an accident) without editorialising.

V. What Draft B Cut That It Shouldn't Have

Draft B's trimming is almost uniformly an improvement. But there are four cuts that weaken the novel:

1. "The city was not removing rooms. It was removing alibis."

End of Chapter XII. One of the novel's best single-line thematic statements. It crystallises the double meaning of "thinning rooms" — the political narrowing and the exposure of the affair. Draft B cuts it. **It should be restored**, in its original position after the shawl-and-mug paragraph.

2. "...because order was the only form of mercy available to men like him after they had crossed the line between desire and damage."

Chapter XIII, after the consummation, Tariq folding the blanket. Draft B replaces this with "as if order might still be of use to someone." The Draft A version is the stronger sentence by a wide margin. "Desire and damage" is the novel's moral vocabulary made precise. "Of use to someone" is vague. **Restore the Draft A version.**

3. "The sentence was not beautiful. It was probably unwise. It was also the truest thing she had said in months."

Chapter XIII, after Maryam's "No to stopping and pretending that improves anything." Draft B cuts "the truest thing she had said in months" and replaces it with simply "true." The original is better because "in months" locates the truth in accumulated dishonesty — the whole arc of deferred feeling. The single word "true" does less work. **Restore "the truest thing she had said in months."**

4. "The first kiss was not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable."

Chapter XIII. I initially thought "theatrically solvable" was trying too hard. On re-reading, I was wrong. The phrase earns itself precisely because it refuses the usual vocabulary of passionate fiction. Draft B's compression of the kiss into one sentence is ruthlessly efficient, but it loses the defiance of the original's insistence on what the kiss was *not*. This is a closer call. **Consider restoring the phrase, even integrated into Draft B's compressed version** — something like: "The kiss, when it came, was not an eruption or anything so theatrically solvable; it was recognised as a mistake even as it continued."

VI. Pacing — Chapter by Chapter

The novel's pacing follows the same essential rhythm in both drafts: slow domestic accumulation (I–IV), the introduction of Tariq and the political backdrop thickening (V–VIII), the Semiramis explosion as the novel's hinge (IX), the emotional and political tightening (X–XIV), the affair's exposure through furniture and departure (XV–XVII), and the endgame of displacement and separation (XVIII–XX).

This rhythm is sound. The novel is deliberately, honourably slow. It earns its slowness because every domestic detail — the coffee tin, the stockings, the rug turned for grief, the hat that won't pin — is doing double or triple duty: characterising, building period texture, and tracking the political compression of the quarter. Almost nothing in the first eight chapters is fat. Even scenes that appear to be pure household business (Huda's arrival, the

mother's intransigence about linen, Leila's constitutional objections to stockings) lay the ground for the final chapters, where linen and stockings and cases become the literal instruments of departure.

Where pacing falters slightly in both drafts

Chapter V ("Papers and Pretexts") has a long middle passage of bureaucratic detail — property claims, Nabil's office, the bank — that threatens to become a catalogue rather than a scene. It works because Hanna's administrative competence is a key theme, but the chapter could lose one bureaucratic visit without damage.

Chapter XV ("The Demand") remains, even in Draft B, the novel's most crowded chapter. The breakfast scene is superb. The bed-removal is essential. But between them sits a passage where Maryam is upstairs choosing what to wear, then Amina comes in with the mending, then there's a long exchange about the coat and the hem — material that echoes the Chapter XIII Amina-coat scene (cedar dust, the loose button, "your clothes are participating in politics") perhaps too closely. One of these two scenes should carry the full weight; the other should be leaner. Since the Chapter XIII version is the novel's best Amina scene, the Chapter XV echo should be trimmed by roughly half.

Draft A's Chapter XIX is simply too long. At 7,077 words it is nearly double the average chapter length. Draft B's decision to split this into two chapters and cut roughly 900 words is correct. What Draft B cuts — some packing detail, some truck-loading, some of the mother's complaints — are things the reader has already seen versions of. By this point the household's style of resistance-through-complaint has been so thoroughly established that each new instance earns diminishing returns.

VII. Emotional Force

The novel's emotional power sits in three places:

1. The Consummation (Chapter XIII)

Both drafts handle this superbly. The scene is among the finest depictions of adultery I've read in English — it refuses glamour, refuses melodrama, and locates the erotic charge in furniture, dust, weather, and the precise domestic detritus of other lives (the lentils list, the pharmacy packet, the exercise book). The Amina scene afterwards — the cedar dust on the coat, the tea in the cloth — is devastating because it operates entirely through material evidence. Amina never accuses, never judges. She simply reads matter as a professional reader of matter, and her reading is total.

Both drafts achieve this equally. Draft B's small trims in the consummation scene itself slightly reduce the moment's reflective depth without damaging the scene's physical and emotional force. Restoring the four phrases identified in Section V would make it complete.

2. The Semiramis Chapter (IX)

This is the novel's structural hinge and it is flawless in both drafts. The explosion entering as an interruption of sleep; the household's graduated response (the mother's lesser explanation, Hanna shaving, Amina putting bread near the stove); the slow arrival of information about Nawal; Tariq's note reaching the house — all of this is handled with the kind of controlled precision that only very good novelists achieve. Draft B's addition of Hanna's "It was placed. Not thrown. Placed." sharpens it further.

3. The Ending

Draft B's ending is stronger because it does something Draft A cannot: it places the reader simultaneously inside Maryam's not-knowing and inside Tariq's waiting. The paragraph beginning "She did not know this. She did not know that a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened..." works in both drafts, but in Draft A it

arrives as narratorial summary — the author telling you about Tariq's afternoon. In Draft B, you have already lived through that afternoon in Chapter XVIII. You have watched Tariq sit in the chair, seen the boy return with the envelope, watched him place it under the mug. When the novel then shifts to Maryam lying on the camp mattress and tells you "she did not know," the irony is earned by experience, not reported by narration. This is the difference between a very good ending and a great one.

The final line — "In the morning it would still be there, small and displaced, opening nothing in the room where it had come to rest" — is identical in both drafts and exactly right. "Displaced" carries the novel's entire political and personal argument in five syllables. The ending does not close but simply stops, because the history it describes did not close either.

VIII. Character

Both drafts handle the ensemble well.

Amina is a masterpiece of characterisation in both — the pantry scene after the affair is faultless. She is the novel's moral compass precisely because she refuses to be one: she reads evidence, repairs it, and declines to carry the burden of knowledge. "I am only telling you that cedar dust shows on dark wool if one knows where to look. Also the tea in the flat is stronger than ours. It stays in the cloth." That is characterisation of the highest order.

Leila is consistently the novel's best comic instrument. Her logic is impeccable in its childish rigour ("sacrifice is easier for boys because they owned fewer ribbons"; "I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep the pencils"). She provides tonal relief without ever becoming comic relief — she is always listening, always assimilating, and her final gesture of sitting on the pencils is both funny and heartbreaking.

Hanna is rendered with extraordinary discipline: a man whose competence is both his virtue and his cruelty, never caricatured, never sentimentalised. "I have given you five more minutes" is one of the great husband-sentences in English fiction.

Maryam's mother and **Aunt Widad** form a remarkable double act — the mother operating through dignified complaint, Widad through witty pragmatism. Widad's "Not yours. That is sometimes the most exact category available" is the novel's last word on possession, spoken by a woman who understands dispossession without ever having been required to be sentimental about it.

Where Draft B gains materially is in Tariq. In Draft A he exists only through Maryam's perception. That works for most of the novel. It fails at the end. The Tariq-waiting scene in Draft B's Chapter XVIII gives him independent existence at the precise moment the novel requires it. Without it, the affair risks feeling like Maryam's story alone, and the political allegory — two people separated not by choice but by the narrowing of the city — loses its symmetry. The scene itself is beautifully executed: Tariq waiting, the shutter rattling, the boy returning with the envelope, the mug placed over the note. It is writing of the same quality as the best of the Maryam chapters.

IX. Thematic Clarity

The novel's governing metaphor — rooms emptied, rooms narrowed, rooms lost — is tracked with almost obsessive precision in both drafts. Every chapter title either names a room or names the condition of rooms. The affair and the Nakba are mapped onto the same spatial grammar: both are stories of rooms becoming uninhabitable, of domestic space ceasing to protect, of keys that open doors one can no longer reach.

This is the novel's deepest strength and it needs no revision. The metaphor never becomes schematic because it is always grounded in physical objects — the wardrobe leaving its pale square, the mug on the sill, the bed frame protesting, the curtains half-drawn. When the

metaphor does surface as statement, it earns itself: "When rooms grow empty people begin to behave as though emptiness were permission" (Hanna, Chapter XII) is the novel's thesis spoken by the character least likely to know how true it is.

X. What Remains Unsolved in Both Drafts

1. Khalil

He is introduced, given witty lines, deployed as a foil and a public-facing counterweight to Tariq's interiority — but he never quite becomes necessary to the plot. He functions as a witness and a social lubricant. The novel would not collapse without him, but it would lose some of its texture. The question is whether he earns his page-time or whether some of his scenes (particularly in Chapters XIV and XVI) could be compressed. He is not a problem, but he is the one character who exists more for the world-building than for the story.

2. Nadia's Letters

The correspondence from Cairo is a thread that runs through the novel without ever quite resolving. This may be intentional — the novel is full of letters unanswered, promises unkept, communications overtaken by events — but Nadia herself remains so distant that her letters become more motif than character. One more concrete detail about Nadia (a single line giving her a physical trait, a verbal habit, a specific demand) would ground the thread without requiring a scene.

3. Hanna's Knowledge

The novel holds in exquisite suspension the question of whether Hanna knows about the affair. "When rooms grow empty people begin to behave as though emptiness were

permission" could be direct accusation or general philosophy. "Do not go tomorrow if I cannot be there" could be prudence or surveillance. "I have given you five more minutes" could be mercy toward a wife who loves a house or mercy toward a wife who loves a man. This ambiguity is one of the novel's greatest achievements. But it needs to remain genuinely ambiguous rather than merely unresolved. In both drafts it holds — but only just. The danger is that Hanna's unknowing begins to look, by the final chapters, like authorial convenience rather than character. One small moment — a sentence in which Hanna's face registers something he immediately suppresses, or a question he starts and does not finish — somewhere between Chapters XIV and XVI would strengthen the ambiguity by proving it is alive rather than simply maintained.

XI. Final Recommendation — Complete Action List

Draft B is the novel to publish. The following actions produce the final manuscript:

Restore from Draft A

1. **"The city was not removing rooms. It was removing alibis."** — Restore at end of Chapter XII, after the shawl-and-mug paragraph.

2. **"...because order was the only form of mercy available to men like him after they had crossed the line between desire and damage."** — Restore in Chapter XIII, Tariq folding the blanket. Replace "as if order might still be of use to someone."

3. **"It was also the truest thing she had said in months."** — Restore in Chapter XIII, after "It was probably unwise." Replace the standalone "true."

4. **Consider restoring "nor anything so theatrically solvable"** to the kiss paragraph, integrated into Draft B's compressed version.

Trim in Draft B

5. **Chapter XV:** The Amina-mending-basket scene echoes the Chapter XIII pantry scene too closely. Reduce by approximately half — keep the coat inspection, cut the extended dialogue about hems.

6. **Chapter V:** One bureaucratic visit to Nabil's office could be compressed by a third.

Add (Newly Written)

7. **One moment of Hanna's near-awareness** — a half-sentence, a suppressed question, a look that does not complete itself — somewhere between Chapters XIV and XVI. Not revelation. Just proof that the ambiguity is active rather than dormant.

8. **One concrete detail about Nadia** — a single line in one of her letters that gives her a voice rather than a function.

Everything Else Stands

The architecture is sound. The prose is exceptional. The ending is earned. The Tariq chapter transforms the final movement from report into drama. The room metaphor holds without becoming schematic. The ensemble characterisation is assured. This is a serious, accomplished, and at times extraordinary novel.

REPLY V2 II C II

Draft B is the stronger novel. Not decisively in every chapter, but consistently and cumulatively, and where it is weaker it is weaker in ways that are easy to fix. Draft A is the richer deposit. Draft B is the better book. The best version is a Draft C that restores a small number of things Draft B cut too eagerly, but is built on Draft B's chassis.

Here is the case.

ARCHITECTURE AND PACING

Draft A's chapter lengths are wildly uneven. Chapters 1–12 are relatively compact (180–340 lines), then the novel suddenly lurches into enormous chapters: Ch15 at 944 lines, Ch18 at 628, Ch19 at 1037. The effect on the reader is front-loading thinness and back-loading exhaustion. The first half moves with admirable restraint; the second half loses structural discipline. It reads as though the writer trusted the material more once the affair and the collapse arrived and began writing at greater length because the emotional stakes were higher — but that instinct, while understandable, damages the proportional architecture.

Draft B redistributes this. The first twelve chapters are expanded (more breath, more scene, more furnished interiors), while the final cluster — especially 18 and 19 — is significantly condensed. The result is a novel that feels structurally continuous rather than back-loaded. The proportions are not yet perfect (Ch18 at 124 lines feels slightly underweight, and I'll come back to this), but the overall rhythm is markedly better.

The chapter titles in Draft B are also improvements. "The Half-Emptied Flat" (B) is concrete, material, and does the work the chapter does; "The Price of Seeing" (A) is thematic and slightly announcing. "Less Room Than Before" (B) vs "After" (A) — the former carries the novel's spatial logic (rooms contracting, quarter narrowing, domestic space shrinking), while "After" is generic, tells the reader nothing, and belongs to a lesser book.

SENTENCE-LEVEL CONTROL

Draft B is consistently tighter at the sentence level, and the tightening is almost always an improvement. A few examples:

Draft A: "That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no." Draft B: "What stayed with her was not the stroke or the doctor, only the fact that no one had been with him."

Draft A's version is more dramatic — the three-fragment construction, the isolated "The no." It has a certain theatrical punch. Draft B's version is quieter and more honest. It tells you what stayed and why in a single measured sentence. In the context of this novel — which earns its power through restraint and the suppression of theatrical gesture — Draft B's version is truer to the voice.

Draft A: "She never wasted an answer when work could be used as an answer instead." Draft B: "She never wasted an answer when work would serve in its place."

The revision is fractionally shorter, more idiomatic, and cleaner.

Draft A: "vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners." Draft B: "Vanity merely learned better manners."

Draft B cuts the first clause. The observation is stronger for losing the setup. The reader doesn't need the philosophical preamble; the aphorism lands harder alone.

Draft A (end of Ch9): "Hope was too theatrical and too available to later writers." Draft B cuts this entirely, leaving just: "Not hope."

This is the single best editorial cut in the revision. The parenthetical about "later writers" breaks the fourth wall, introduces a self-conscious literary-critical register that belongs to an essay, not to a novel narrated from close-third inside Maryam's consciousness. Draft B rightly kills it.

These are representative, not exhaustive. Across the manuscript, Draft B trims 10–15% of the prose, and in roughly 85% of cases the trim is correct.

THE CONSUMMATION SCENE (Ch13)

This is the novel's pivot, and both drafts handle it with extraordinary care. The material is nearly identical. Both versions achieve the remarkable feat of writing a sex scene in which the objects (hat pin, glove, iron bedframe, cedar blanket, chipped mug) carry the emotional and moral weight, and the act itself is rendered through material awkwardness rather than sensation. The line "A thing deferred through papers, errands, weather, child, church, death, road, and ordinary cowardice had become body" is the finest sentence in the novel and appears in both.

Draft B is marginally sharper here. It adds: "He paused twice, once to say her name and once for nothing at all except to see whether she had changed her mind while there was still time to possess one." And: "A crack in the plaster above the wardrobe. Someone shouting for a cart in the street below." These additions are excellent — they keep the world material and intrusive during the scene itself, refusing romantic enclosure.

Draft A has: "The intensity lay not in revelation but in the complete collapse of postponement." Draft B cuts this. I think Draft B is right. The sentence explains what the scene has already shown. It is intelligent commentary, but the novel is better without the commentary.

The Amina pantry scene that closes the chapter — the cedar dust on the coat, the loose button, "I said both. It seemed efficient" — is identical in both drafts and is among the best things in the book.

THE DEMAND (Ch15) AND THE NOTE (Ch18)

Here is where Draft B both gains and loses.

Draft A's Ch15 is massive but contains the novel's most important confrontation: Tariq saying "I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another." Both drafts include this scene. But Draft A gives it significantly more room to breathe — Khalil's entrance, the exchange about delay ("You have not been an acceleration"), and the extended argument in which Maryam lists her obligations and Tariq answers that there is no clean sentence, only the absence of one. Draft B retains the confrontation but compresses the surrounding context. The compression mostly works, but some of the air around the scene is valuable. Khalil's line — "You are not short of walls. You are short of time" — is excellent and deserves its space.

Draft B's Ch18 ("The Note") is the most significant structural departure. It is only 124 lines. It cuts the extended domestic morning that Draft A gives and instead moves more quickly to Tariq writing the note and then waiting in the empty flat. The Tariq waiting scene is powerful in both drafts — the shutter rattling, the boy returning with the unopened envelope, the mug on the sill. But Draft B's Ch18 feels thin. The domestic morning — Amina arriving with mud on her hem, the school circular, Leila's stocking — is important connective tissue in Draft A. It shows the household still functioning under increasing pressure, and its removal in Draft B makes the transition to the note feel slightly abrupt.

Draft B's Ch19 is also much shorter (228 lines vs 1037). Draft A's Ch19 is the most bloated chapter in the book, but it contains irreplaceable material: the packing scene with Maryam's mother arguing about shawls, the icon exchange ("Then let Leila cough piously"), the bed men dismantling the frame ("It sounds resisted"), Amina saying "Everything matters once it is visible," and the truck ride through the quarter. Draft B moves much of this material into Ch19 effectively, but some of the texture around the truck ride and the arrival at the schoolrooms is reduced.

CHARACTER

Both drafts handle the central cast with the same intelligence. Maryam is the novel's great achievement — a woman whose interiority is rendered through domestic precision rather than psychological exposition. Hanna is a masterpiece of restraint: a man whose competence is both his strength and his limitation, whose silence is never emptiness. Amina is the novel's moral centre, and she earns it through labour and observation, not through wisdom delivered as aphorism.

Leila is consistently excellent. Her lines are never cute. They are the observations of a child who thinks literally and therefore accidentally exposes what adults have agreed to conceal. "How much coffee does a soul need?" "Why is everyone saying he loved children when he was rude to Uncle Fawzi?" "I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where

to keep the pencils." These are among the novel's best lines and they survive intact in both drafts.

Tariq is slightly more present in Draft A, which gives him more time in the confrontation scene and more texture in the waiting scene. Draft B's Tariq is marginally thinner. This is the one character loss in revision.

THEMATIC CLARITY

Both drafts handle the same themes: the privatisation of political catastrophe through domestic routine; the way a household absorbs historical violence by translating it into errands; the collapse of postponement as both a personal and a political fact. The novel's great insight is that the affair and the Nakba operate on the same mechanism — the withdrawal of the assumption that delay is safe. Draft B makes this clearer by tightening the language around it. The spatial metaphor (rooms emptying, streets narrowing, the quarter contracting) is more consistently maintained in Draft B because the chapter titles reinforce it and the prose trims the moments where Draft A over-explains the parallel.

THE ENDING

Draft B's ending is better. The final paragraphs are nearly identical, but Draft B adds: "She grieved him in uncertainty. She grieved also the house, the quarter, the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still survive them." This is a fine addition — it names the grief without sentimentalising it. And the revision of the relief passage is sharper: "the necessity others had begun carrying for her left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded. It was a relief as ugly as the wash water in the basin." Draft A's version is good but slightly more diffuse.

The final image — the key on the desk, opening nothing — is the same in both and is exactly right.

THE VERDICT

Draft B is the stronger novel. It is structurally better proportioned, more disciplined in its prose, more consistent in its tonal register, and more trusting of the reader. It removes nearly all of the moments where Draft A explains what it has already shown, and it tightens the aphoristic tendency that occasionally makes Draft A sound like it is admiring its own sentences.

But Draft B is not yet the final draft. It has over-cut in three places:

1. **Ch18 needs 30–40% more domestic tissue.** The morning scene from Draft A — Amina arriving with mud, the school circular, Leila's stocking — should be restored in compressed form. Without it, the transition to Tariq's note feels too sudden, and the household's increasing precariousness is under-demonstrated at exactly the moment it needs to be felt.
2. **Ch15 should restore Khalil's entrance and the "You have not been an acceleration" exchange.** These are too good to lose, and they give Tariq's world (the school, the male networks of obligation) a texture his character needs. Cut some of Draft A's surrounding material if necessary, but keep those two beats.
3. **Ch19's packing scene with Maryam's mother** — the shawl argument, the icon, "Then let Leila cough piously" — is fully present in Draft B and should remain. But the bed men sequence and the truck ride could stand to recover 15–20% of the material Draft A gives them, particularly the moment when the quarter is described through the truck window ("a rolled carpet against a railing, a stack of chairs in a yard, women carrying not baskets but bundles tied in pillowcases"). Draft B has this, but the surrounding rhythm is slightly rushed.

Draft C, then, is Draft B with three targeted restorations from Draft A, totalling perhaps 2,000–3,000 words of returned material, and no new writing required except transitions to accommodate the restored passages. Everything else should remain as Draft B has it.

One last thing. This is a very good novel. The sentence-level quality is remarkably sustained across 400+ pages. The domestic register never falters. The political is never announced, only inhabited. The affair is rendered without a single false note. The ending refuses resolution without refusing feeling. These are rare achievements.

THIS IS WHAT VF ASKED

I am giving you two drafts of the same novel. Read both in full before commenting on either. Then tell me what you find — what each draft does that the other does not, where one is stronger, where the other is, and where neither has yet found the best version of a passage, a scene, a sentence, or a structural choice. I am not asking you to pick a winner. I am asking you to read as an editor who has been given two serious attempts at the same book and must advise the author on how to produce the strongest possible third. Work at every level — the architecture of the whole, the shape of individual chapters, the weight of scenes, the rhythm of paragraphs, the precision of sentences, the truth of characters, and the earned or unearned quality of any line that asks the reader to feel something. If a passage in one draft is doing something the other draft should learn from, say so. If both drafts share a weakness neither has solved, say so. If one draft has cut something the other kept and the cut was wrong, say so. If the cut was right, say so. Be specific. Use the text. Do not summarise when you can point. Do not praise when you can improve. The only thing I do not want is vagueness. Thank you.

REPLY VF CG I

I have read Complete First Draft Polish and QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash in full.

Bluntly: these are not two different novels. They are two states of the same novel. Draft B is the shorter, cleaner pass. Draft A is the riskier, more morally exposing pass. Up to about Chapter XII, most changes are local: clause pressure, chapter openings, a few trims, a few expansions. From the affair onwards, the revisions stop being local and become decisive.

The strongest third draft will not come from splitting the difference. It will come from taking Draft B's sentence discipline and keeping Draft A's moral cruelty.

The deepest difference is this: Draft A is more willing to keep Maryam implicated. Draft B is more willing to let history do the work for her. For this particular book, that is not a small matter. It is the matter.

The book's architecture is already right. Beginning with the condolence house instead of the love story is right. Building desire through papers, errands, copying, church business, rent, roofs, routes, watched roads, and room shortage is right. Letting politics enter through domestic procedure rather than speeches is right. Do not rebuild that. But do not tell yourself the remaining choices are cosmetic. They are moral.

Where Draft A is stronger

Draft A is stronger whenever the novel needs to keep guilt in the room.

The largest example is the late note. In Draft A, Maryam receives Tariq's note too late. Huda says, "A boy brought it." It arrived "After four. Closer to five." Maryam then reads: "Today. Four o'clock. The flat. / If you can come, come. I will be there until dark." That is brutal in the correct way. The note exists. It reaches her. It is too late. She carries it. She sleeps with it nearby. She packs around it. That is the novel's law: not grand fate, but lateness, sequence, domestic contamination, the cost of one postponement too many.

Draft B changes that law. The note is returned unopened. The boy says, "I went first to the house," and later the prose tells us, "The city had placed itself between the note and its reader." Elegant sentence. Wrong sentence. It is the wrong kind of elegance. It shifts the burden from Maryam's failure of timing to historical obstruction. History absolutely should narrow the roads. It should not absolve the woman. This book is harsher and better when the city tightens around a choice Maryam has already failed to make in time.

Related to that, Draft A's opening to Chapter XIX is plainly better: "When Maryam woke the note was still on the coverlet and the case still on the chair." That is exactly the kind of contamination this novel does best. The note is now a domestic object among travel objects. Draft B opens Chapter XIX with packing the mother's case. Useful, but weaker. It loses the moral stain.

Draft A is also stronger in Chapter XIII's title. **The Price of Seeing** is better than **The Half-Emptied Flat**. The chapter is not only about a room being emptied. It is about recognition becoming expensive. The furniture matters, but the title in Draft B reduces the scene to logistics when the chapter is paying off a moral and erotic cost.

Draft A is stronger whenever it keeps Maryam's shame from becoming abstract. Her "low shameful relief" when choice is taken out of reach is good because it is ugly and exact. The novel must keep that. Maryam is not tragic because she loves too much. She is tragic because she delays, partitions, rationalises, and then feels relief when circumstance does what she would not do herself.

Where Draft B is stronger

Draft B is stronger whenever Draft A starts captioning its own scenes.

The clearest case is the consummation scene. Draft A too often explains after the room has already done the work. In A, you get sentences like: "The first kiss was not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable." Then later: "The intensity lay not in revelation but in the complete collapse of postponement." Then: "That was all. That was everything." None of these sentences are false. They are simply too aware of themselves. The room already knows it. The reader already knows it. The prose is stepping between the scene and the feeling.

Draft B is much better here. Where A gives you a paragraph of interpretive management, B pares it back to, “The kiss, when it came, was recognised as a mistake even as it continued.” That is enough. It is harder, cleaner, and far less pleased with itself. B then trusts the crack in the plaster, the shouted cart below, the iron frame, the cold room, the tied journals, the pale wall-square. That is the right instinct. The affair should be made of matter, not commentary.

This is the right cut. Keep it.

Draft B is also often right at chapter openings. In Chapter V, B starts immediately with one of the best lines in the book: “The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic.” Draft A takes a step longer to get there. That step is not bad, but it is not needed. B is right to arrive sooner.

In Chapter XIV, B is again cleaner. Draft A opens: “the room looked ordinary first and wrong only a second later, which was perhaps the exact cruelty of it,” and then adds, “It was not a wound or a triumph. It was only an alteration.” Draft B cuts this to something much firmer: the room looked ordinary first and wrong only a second later; “Altered, that was all.” That is the better version. Same meaning. Less varnish.

Chapter XIV’s title is also better in B. **Less Room Than Before** is superior to **After**. “After” tells you nothing. “Less Room Than Before” continues one of the novel’s governing structural metaphors: shrinking space, shrinking options, shrinking moral room. That title belongs to this book. Keep it.

Chapter XX opens better in Draft B as well. A says sleep came “in torn shallow pockets.” Fine. B says: “Maryam had not expected sleep to come. It had. That was the first betrayal.” Better. Harder. More exact. Less decorative.

So the pattern is clear. Draft B is usually right when it cuts the sentence that explains the sentence before it.

Where the cut was right, and where it was wrong

Right cuts in Draft B:

- Cutting the self-explanatory material around the consummation.
- Cutting certain chapter-opening throat-clearings.
- Tightening Chapter XIV’s aftermath prose.
- Arriving faster at strong lines rather than preparing them.

Wrong cuts in Draft B:

- Removing Maryam's too-late receipt of the note and replacing it with failed delivery.
- Losing the note-on-coverlet contamination at the start of Chapter XIX.
- Cleaning the late moral structure so far that history begins carrying blame that belongs to character.

That last one matters most. Do not let the final movement become lovers-kept-apart-by-roadblock. That is a smaller and easier book than the one you actually have.

Where neither draft is yet right

First: the prose still overuses a favourite hinge. The book loves the "Not X. Not Y. Z." turn. It loves the corrective sentence. It loves the balanced negation. It loves the elegant reversal in the tail. It works often. It does not work this often. After a while the ear starts waiting for it. Once the ear starts waiting, the rhythm loses force.

You can hear the habit everywhere:

- "Not publicly. Not yet."
- "Not comfort. Not escape. Not memory."
- "Not Choose me. Not even I love you..."
- "Not no to this. No to stopping..."
- "It was not a wound or a triumph..."

These are good tools. They have become manner.

Second: too many speakers can deliver finished, quotable, perfectly weighted sentences. Maryam should. Hanna often should. Aunt Widad sometimes should. Tariq sometimes should. Amina almost never should in that mode, because her authority comes from matter, not aphorism. Yet the general level of exactness is so high that the author's pressure sometimes overrides speaker distinction. Tariq, in particular, still occasionally sounds less like a man under pressure and more like a second house-style instrument.

Third: the middle chapters are still slightly too even in temperature. The chapter count is not the problem. Twenty chapters is fine for this book because it is a book of rooms, compartments, routes, documents, errands, and closures. The problem is that some early-middle chapters are more "pressure continues" than "this chapter has a singular chamber-pressure of its own". V, VI, and perhaps X are the places I would examine. Not for cutting. For stronger individuality.

Fourth: Mother and Aunt Widad are not yet separated enough at the level of dialogue rhythm. Their functions are distinct, but their speech texture still overlaps more than it should when both are active in the same scene. The mother is rank, category, verdict, self-dignifying fragility. Aunt Widad is management, counting, order, dry competence. When they blur, the household loses one of its chief pleasures: pressure arriving from different women in different grammars.

Fifth: Nawal is still just slightly under-lived before Semiramis. Not badly. Not enough to justify a whole new subplot. But her death lands a fraction more as judgement on Maryam than as the loss of an irreplaceable living person. One more small, unforced notch of Nawal's singularity earlier would help. One. Not three.

Sixth: some of the chapter endings are too knowingly "correct". The mug. The key. The glove. The chalk. The stockings. The map. These objects are good. They are often doing real work. But the book is now so adept at object-endings that a few begin to feel not false, but pre-approved. Keep the object endings that sting. Cut the ones that merely look like the right sort of ending.

On character truth

Maryam is right in both drafts. Keep her morally porous. Keep her vain. Keep her perceptive. Keep her governed by delay. Do not redeem her by explanation.

Hanna is one of the best things in the novel. Protect him. Do not warm him to make the affair easier to justify. Do not darken him to make the affair easier to pardon. The marriage works because it is real and insufficient. The "five more minutes" scene proves the book understands him exactly. He can allocate mercy; he cannot become the kind of man who dissolves it into feeling.

Tariq is good in both drafts and necessary in ways he was perhaps not in earlier stages. His mother, school, satchel, notices, tea, copied leases, and Khalil give him real life outside Maryam. Keep all that. But do not let him become too finished. He is best when he says something plain and irreversible, like "I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another." He is less good when his speech begins sounding like an elegantly distressed précis of the novel's themes.

Amina is exact. Leave her alone. Do not enlarge her. She is strongest when she reads dust on wool, tea in cloth, lateness in roads, labour in kitchens. She does not need more pages. She needs protection from improvement.

Leila is mostly right. Watch only that her lines stay child-true rather than miniature-adult devastating.

What the strongest third draft should do

1. Base the late architecture on Draft A, not Draft B. Maryam must receive the note too late. The note must contaminate the move. She must sleep beside failure, not be spared it by a watched road.
2. Base the sentence-level handling of the affair on Draft B. Keep B's cuts. Remove A's self-captioning lines around the kiss, the revelation, the postponement, the "That was all. That was everything" material. The room, the bed, the dust, the glove, the rain, the hat pin, the cracked plaster, the cart below: those are enough.
3. Keep **The Price of Seeing** for Chapter XIII. Keep **Less Room Than Before** for Chapter XIV.
4. Use Draft B's instinct for harder chapter openings where it is plainly right. Chapter V should open on "The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic." Chapter XX should keep B's "It had. That was the first betrayal."
5. Use Draft A's Chapter XVIII and XIX moral sequence. "The note was still on the coverlet and the case still on the chair" is not expendable. It is central.
6. End Chapter XX closer to Draft A than Draft B. B is too tempted, again, to make history the abstract agent. A is colder where it counts.
7. Do one ruthless pass on interpretive after-sentences. The rule is simple: when an object, gesture, or room has already delivered the emotion, kill the next sentence unless it adds genuine complication. Most of the time it does not.
8. Sharpen dialogue register by speaker, not just by intelligence level. Maryam may think finely. Hanna may speak with procedural exactness. Aunt Widad may cut dryly. Amina should remain grounded in matter. Tariq should crack more under pressure.
9. Give Nawal one more earlier living edge. Not a sermon, not a set-piece, not a "make her lovable" scene. Just one more thing only she could have said or noticed.
10. Do not add more overt politics. The politics are already where they should be: in routes, delays, housing, schoolrooms, watched roads, municipal forms, radio reports, borrowed rooms, and who can cross where by dusk. More explanation would make the book thinner, not thicker.

The short version is this: Draft B often knows where to cut. Draft A more often knows where the book is truly cruel. The third draft should steal B's cuts and keep A's guilt. If you choose cleanliness over implication in the back third, you will make the book easier and worse. If

you keep the moral pressure and trim the prose that explains itself, you will have the strongest version of this novel.

REPLY VF CG II

I have read **Complete First Draft Polish** and **QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash** in full.

The blunt editorial answer is this:

Draft B is usually the cleaner, harder, better-edited manuscript. Draft A is sometimes the morally tougher one.
So the third draft should not be a winner-takes-all choice. It should use **Draft B as the base for much of the first two-thirds**, then become a **deliberate hybrid in the late book**, because Draft B solves pace there by removing too much of the characters' responsibility.

The biggest fact about the revision is structural, not decorative: Draft B is roughly **4,200 words shorter overall**, and most of that cutting lands in **Chapters XVIII and XIX**, with some weight added back in **XX**. That tells you exactly where the book itself knew it had a problem. The shortening is right. The exact solution is not yet right.

1. What the book really is, and where each draft understands it

This novel's true language is not abstract. It is **rooms, shutters, spoons, routes, keys, mugs, paper, lists, dust, bedsteads, registry copies**. When the book trusts that material vocabulary, it becomes first-rate. When it names theme too directly, it gets weaker.

Draft B understands that better.

That is why the renaming of **Chapter XIII** and **Chapter XIV** is not cosmetic. **"The Half-Emptied Flat"** and **"Less Room Than Before"** are better titles than **"The Price of Seeing"** and **"After."** The B titles belong to the actual imaginative system of the book: space narrowing, rooms changing use, domestic matter carrying moral pressure. The A titles tell the reader what to think. The B titles let the book do it in its own medium.

That same difference shows up sentence by sentence. Early on, Draft A gives you:
"*But hating herself had not altered the fall of the skirt. Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners.*"
Draft B turns that into:
"*The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely learned better manners.*"

That is a correct cut. Same idea, sharper delivery, less self-explanation.

Likewise with the flat. Draft A says:
"*The flat was exactly and not at all as she remembered it.*"
Draft B breaks the paradox into observable fact and consequence:
"*The flat was exactly as she remembered it … All of it had altered by being ownerless.*"
Again: better. Less writerly announcing, more dramatic seeing.

So at the level of basic prose discipline, Draft B is usually ahead.

2. Where Draft B is clearly stronger

The first twelve chapters are mostly a line-editing victory for B

Up to about **Chapter XII**, these are overwhelmingly the same novel with different levels of sentence control. B is usually doing one of three useful things:

It cuts the extra sentence after the image.
It removes the explanatory gloss after the judgement has already landed.
It replaces abstract paraphrase with the object or action that made the feeling.

You can see it in the affair scene too. Draft A writes, of the consummation:

"*What followed was tender because both of them were afraid, awkward because fear belongs to the body as much as desire does.*"

That is intelligent, but it is also the narrator stepping between the scene and the reader. Draft B gets out of the way and lets the room convict them:

"*The iron frame complained. The blanket smelled faintly of cedar and storage. Rain worked at the window. The dead man's flat remained the dead man's flat. Nothing in the room gave way before it.*"

That is much better. It does not ask to be admired. It simply refuses to sentimentalise the act. Use Draft B as the base here.

Draft B is better at stopping paragraphs where they should stop

A small example, but revealing: in Chapter XIV, A has
"*No one answered that. It was too near a true sentence for breakfast.*"
B cuts it to
"*No one answered.*"

That cut is right. The first sentence already carries the charge. The second is explanation out of habit.

Draft A repeatedly adds one sentence too many. Draft B often fixes that.

Draft B has a better instinct for chapter function

The late-middle titles I already mentioned. More broadly, B is trying to make chapters do one thing more decisively. That instinct is good, especially after the affair, where the novel cannot afford drift.

3. Where Draft A is stronger, and where B has cut the wrong thing

This matters more than the sentence-level gains.

The biggest wrong cut/change is the note

This is the central late-book issue.

In Draft A, Maryam **receives** the note too late. The missed encounter remains tragic, but it remains **morally entangling**. She has to carry the fact of it. The city interferes, yes, but the pain is still routed through her knowledge.

In Draft B, the note does **not reach her at all**. It comes back unopened. Tariq puts it under the mug. The reader knows; Maryam does not.

This is cleaner chapter architecture. It is also a weaker novel.

Why? Because it turns a hard moral failure into a logistical one. It shifts the pressure from character to arrangement. It produces pathos, but it lets both of them off at the precise moment the book most needs to keep them inside the field of compromised choice.

Draft B ends Chapter XIX with Maryam not knowing that "*a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened*..." That is elegant. Too elegant. It turns the tragedy into dramatic irony. The book is stronger when the tragedy remains **contaminated by knowledge**.

So: **the note must reach Maryam.**
Not early enough for a clean decision. Not in a way that lets her act nobly. But it must reach her. She must have to carry it.

That is the single biggest structural instruction I would give for the third draft.

Draft A keeps one crucial social observation that B should not have cut

In Chapter VI, Draft A has this excellent paragraph about Tariq's effect on the room:

"*Maryam had noticed by now that conversation sharpened when Tariq was present, not because he dazzled people into wit but because exactness invited its own sort of answer.*

Her mother became more aphoristic, Aunt Widad drier, Hanna more concise, even Leila more intolerably literal."

That is not filler. That is social intelligence. It locates Tariq not as private fantasy but as a pressure on the whole household register. It also prevents him from becoming a romantic abstraction. Draft B over-compresses here. **Restore this thought, perhaps slightly tightened, but restore it.**

Draft A is stronger at the very end

Draft B over-explains Maryam's late shameful relief. A handles it with much more authority.

Draft A gives you:
"*That was the indecency. If the flat was shut and the road already narrowing, then no one could ask her tonight to decide whether to try it. The choice had been lifted out of reach and the knowledge of that felt, for a moment, like rest. She knew what sort of feeling it was. It remained.*"

Draft B gives you:
"*She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all. Yet the necessity others had begun carrying for her left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded.*"

That is the weaker version. It says what the book has already dramatised. It is blunter, flatter, and less cruel. Draft A's "*That was the indecency*" is cleaner and more damaging. **End closer to A here.**

4. Where neither draft has found the best version yet

The book still over-explains after strong moments

This is the shared weakness. Draft B improves it, but the habit remains audible.

The recurring form is:

- image
- judgement
- restatement of the judgement in another key

Very often the third beat should go.

Examples:

- A's affair scene commentary is too interpretive.
- B's ending in Chapter XX becomes too essay-like.

- Both drafts sometimes compose object-endings a little too neatly.

A late example: A has "*On the coverlet lay the note. On the chair sat the case. One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early.*" B has "*The note was under the mug. The mug was on the sill. The room held the rest.*"

Both are good prose. Both are also a little self-conscious as arrangement. The objects are starting to behave like symbols before they have fully remained objects. The third draft should distrust that neatness.

The dialogue in The Demand is too evenly excellent

The confrontation between Maryam and Tariq is strong in both versions, but it is almost too perfectly articulated. Too many lines land cleanly. Too many wound elegantly.

"*You have not been an acceleration*" is superb. Keep it. But the surrounding exchange often sounds like two exceptionally lucid people delivering their best possible versions of pain in real time.

That is not how people speak when desire, duty, class, child, marriage, transport, and history are all choking the room at once.

The scene needs a little more waste in it. One or two failed sentences. One or two evasions that do not arrive polished. Let one of them repeat themselves stupidly once. Let one answer the wrong thing. The scene will get stronger, not weaker.

The voices are distinguished, but not yet enough

The book knows the differences between Maryam, Hanna, Tariq, Aunt Widad, Amina, and Leila. But at the level of memorable lines, too many of them can still sound like variations of the same governing intelligence.

Amina in particular must be watched. She is excellent because she speaks from labour, timing, class position, and practical contempt for nonsense. If every Amina line turns quotable, she stops being Amina and becomes a delivery system for the novel's intelligence.

Same with Aunt Widad. She can carry more shaped judgement than Amina. Keep that distinction hard.

Leila is often the cleanest calibration instrument in the book. Protect her. She says impossible things because children do; she should not start sounding like a miniature adult ironist.

5. Character truth: where the third draft must not flinch

Do not flatten Hanna into "the husband obstacle"

The book is much better than that, and whenever it drifts towards that simplification, it shrinks.

Hanna is one of the book's major achievements precisely because his love arrives as allocation, management, prevention, sequence, measurable mercy. That is why "*I have given you five more minutes*" hits so hard. It is not sentimental, but it is intimate in the only grammar he possesses.

Do **not** lose that.

What the book must preserve is the fact that Maryam's relation to Hanna is not false merely because it is unromantic on the page. It is dense with care, injury, habit, disappointment, reliance, and genuine knowledge. The Tariq plot only has force because Hanna is not easy to dismiss.

This is another reason the unread note in B is a mistake. It cleans up the field too much.

Maryam is strongest when the prose lets her notice rather than diagnose herself

Draft B is better at this overall. Keep following that instinct. Whenever the narration starts telling us what moral category her feeling belongs to, check whether the room, object, or action has already told us.

6. What I would actually do for the third draft

Very plainly:

Chapters I–XII

Use **Draft B as the copy-text**.

Then restore only what B has wrongly cut, which is not much. The main restoration I would insist on is the Chapter VI observation about conversation sharpening when Tariq is present. There may be one or two other small recoveries of that kind, but this section does **not** need wholesale rebuilding.

Chapters XIII–XIV

Use **Draft B's titles** and **Draft B's materially grounded handling** of the consummation and immediate aftermath.

But cut a few remaining explanatory after-sentences. The scene is strongest when the room, the bed, the weather, and the unchanged dead man's flat refuse romance for you.

Chapter XV

Keep the structure. Keep the best lines. Roughen the dialogue.

Chapters XVI–XVII

Do not waste your best energy here. These chapters are close to settled.

Chapters XVIII–XX

Rebuild as a hybrid.

Keep Draft B's instinct that:

- Chapter XVIII should really be **about the note**
- Chapter XIX should really be **about departure and "five more minutes"**
- Chapter XX should really be **about aftermath in the schoolroom**

But reject Draft B's unread-note solution.

Make the note reach Maryam too late. That preserves pace **and** preserves moral pressure.

Then end the novel closer to Draft A's restraint. Keep one or two of B's tactile additions if you want, but cut the blunt thesis lines. Do not end by explaining that she failed to choose. The novel already knows that. The reader already knows that. The point is that she feels the relief of being spared the choice and despises that relief. A already does this better.

7. The shortest possible version of the editorial instruction

Use Draft B wherever the revision is doing what revision should do: **cutting explanation, trusting objects, sharpening chapter function, and keeping the book in its own material lexicon**.

Use Draft A wherever the revision has tried to buy elegance by surrendering **moral difficulty**, especially in the note sequence and at the end.

And for the whole book: do one more ruthless pass against its favourite signatures — the "not X / not Y" turns, the extra sentence after the image, the polished aphorism after the scene has already landed. Draft B has begun that job. It has not finished it.

The third draft is there. It is not far. But it requires one hard refusal: **do not let late-book efficiency become late-book simplification.**

REPLY VF C I

What you have and what you don't yet have

These are not two different novels. They are one novel at two stages of the same revision, sharing roughly 90% of their text word for word. Draft B (the *QATAMON* manuscript) is a targeted polish of Draft A (the *Complete First Draft Polish*), not a reimagining. That means the question is not which draft to choose but where the polish worked, where it didn't go far enough, and where both drafts share problems neither has solved.

ARCHITECTURE

Both drafts have twenty chapters with nearly identical titles. The structural change that matters is in the final quarter:

Draft A's Chapter XIII is called "The Price of Seeing." Draft B renames it "The Half-Emptied Flat." Draft A's XIV is "After." Draft B renames it "Less Room Than Before." The Draft B titles are better. "The Price of Seeing" announces its own theme like a chapter heading in a moral novel; it tells the reader what to feel before the scene has earned it. "The Half-Emptied Flat" is concrete, material, and lets the scene's meaning arrive through the furniture — which is exactly what the prose itself does so well. Same logic with "After" vs "Less Room Than Before": the latter is spatial, domestic, earned. Keep the Draft B titles.

The more consequential structural difference is in Chapter XVIII, "The Note." Draft A runs roughly 3,800 words. Draft B runs roughly 2,000. The difference is not padding cut from Draft A; it is a wholesale redesign. In Draft A, we stay with Maryam: she receives Tariq's note late, reads it after the window for response has closed, and then we shift to Tariq at the flat, watching him wait and leave. In Draft B, the chapter opens with compressed domestic shorthand (the house shutting itself down), then cuts to Tariq's perspective — his sleepless night, the school ledger of crossed-out names, the act of writing the note, the waiting, and crucially, the boy returning with the envelope **unopened**.

Draft B's version is the stronger one, and it is not close. The returned envelope is the novel's most devastating single image. It does what the entire book has been preparing for: it makes the political and the personal land on the same object at the same moment. The note was not refused. It was not received. The city removed the question from the field before anyone could answer it. Draft A denies itself this image by having Maryam receive the note — which means the note functions only as private anguish, not as the collision between private desire and public collapse. Keep Draft B's Chapter XVIII. It is the best single chapter-level decision in either manuscript.

However, Draft B's Chapter XIX "Five More Minutes" then opens with packing the mother's case — functional, necessary, but slightly cold after the emotional devastation of XVIII. Draft A opens XIX with Maryam waking to find the note on the coverlet and the case on the chair. That image — the note arrived too late, the case arrived too early, one night's width between them — is one of the strongest in the book, and Draft B has sacrificed it. The third draft needs to find a way to preserve both: the unopened envelope AND the morning's paired objects. One possibility: Draft B's XVIII ends with Tariq leaving the note under the mug; XIX could then open with Maryam waking in a room where the case sits on the chair and the absence of the note (which she never received) is registered through its absence — the coat pocket where she keeps reaching for it and finding nothing.

Draft A's Chapter XIX is also monstrously long at 7,078 words — the longest chapter in a novel that otherwise runs 3,000–5,000 per chapter. Draft B breaks this more evenly between XIX and XX, which is correct. But it could break harder. The packing, the bed men, the truck, the schoolroom, Hanna's "five more minutes," and the final night — that is at least two chapters' worth of emotional material being forced through a single valve. Consider whether "Five More Minutes" itself — the moment Hanna stands in the doorway and says those words — wants to be the hinge between two chapters, not a scene buried inside one.

THE CONSUMMATION SCENE (Chapter XIII)

Both drafts handle this nearly identically and both handle it well. The sequence from the tea in the kitchen through to the bed is the best-controlled extended passage in the novel. The material details — hat pin, cuff catching in sleeve, the spring's indecorous noise, the glove under the bed — do the work that romantic language would have ruined. The line "She did not become another woman upon being wanted. She remained exactly herself: frightened, vain, hungry, ashamed, moved, half unwilling to see what she herself had authorised" is the novel's thesis stated as sensation, and it earns every word.

Draft B makes one small cut that slightly improves it: the phrase "The intensity lay not in revelation but in the complete collapse of postponement. A thing deferred through papers, errands, weather, child, church, death, road, and ordinary cowardice had become body. That was all. That was everything." In Draft A, this is preceded by an additional sentence: "Not intimacy. Not distance. A competence in not obliging one another falsely." That sentence describes an earlier dynamic but has no business appearing *during* the sex. Draft B cuts it. Correct.

Both drafts include: "He paused twice, once to say her name and once for nothing at all except to see whether she had changed her mind while there was still time to possess one." Draft B adds this; Draft A has instead "The shock of his care made the thing harder, not easier." Draft B's addition is better — it is specific, physical, and carries the weight of consent as ongoing negotiation without making it sound like a seminar. But Draft A's "the shock of his care" is also doing real work: it names the emotional paradox of tenderness making transgression *worse*, not better. The third draft might keep both.

AMINA'S PANTRY SCENE (Chapter XIII, both drafts)

This scene — Amina examining the coat, finding cedar dust, identifying inside-wall plaster, placing the loose button between soap and napkins — is the novel's finest piece of writing. It is identical in both drafts and should not be touched. The line "It came from the republic of matter, where ash, flour, chalk, and cedar all preserved their separate citizenship" is the single best sentence in the book. It does what no amount of moral commentary can: it places knowledge in the hands of a woman whose power operates entirely through material competence, and it refuses to sentimentalise either the knowing or the keeping-quiet. The whole novel's class architecture lives in this moment.

SENTENCE-LEVEL PATTERNS: WHERE BOTH DRAFTS SHARE A WEAKNESS

The prose is excellent. It is also, by Chapter XII, exhibiting a pattern fatigue that neither draft has solved. Specifically:

1. **The aphoristic close.** Too many paragraphs end with a sentence that turns an observation into an axiom. "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners." "Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention." "Respectability did not imprison by walls. It imprisoned by making every exit available only at the cost of becoming a type." Each of these is individually strong. Cumulatively, they begin to sound like a novelist who does not trust the reader to

extract the pattern without being told it exists. By the middle chapters, the reader is ahead of the prose. The third draft should cut roughly one in three of these summary epigrams. The ones that should stay are those that belong to the *characters* rather than to the narrator's commentary — "Bureaucracy does not object to death. It objects to incomplete death" works because it sounds like Tariq actually thinking. "That was Hanna entire. Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention" does not, because it is the novelist reaching over Maryam's shoulder.

2. **The "not X but Y" construction.** Both drafts are structurally addicted to this move: "Not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private." "Not fear. Something smaller and more social." "Not in any vulgar way. Merely as one became aware of..." "Not as insult but as enclosure." This is the prose's dominant rhetorical gesture: defining by negation, correcting a simpler reading before it can form. It is powerful when it reveals something the reader would not have thought of. It becomes tic when the negated term was never plausible in the first place. Nobody was going to think Maryam's awareness of Tariq was "vulgar," so negating it looks defensive. Audit every "not X but Y" in the manuscript. Keep the ones where the negated X is a real temptation for the reader. Cut the ones where it is a straw man the prose has erected so it can look precise while knocking it down.

3. **Leila's precocity.** Leila is a brilliant creation for the first six chapters. Her lines ("It seems the best day. He cannot interrupt"; "I dislike wise people"; "That seems unfair") work because they are genuinely childlike observations that happen to cut through adult evasion. By Chapter X, however, the novel has begun using her as a reliable delivery system for ironic commentary. "Can a country move?" "I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep the pencils." "Is delay dearer than bread?" The problem is not that children cannot say such things. It is that Leila never says anything *wrong*. Every one of her lines lands. No child is that consistently acute. The novel needs three or four moments where Leila is simply confused, or simply irritating, or says something that means nothing at all. Without those, she ceases to be a character and becomes a chorus.

4. **Amina's one-liners.** Same problem at lower intensity. Amina's lines are the novel's comic spine and they are very good. But by the later chapters she has become too reliably witty. "Because grown people discuss disaster best when it sounds like luncheon." "Everything matters once it is visible." "If ladies are making lists, add hooks." The servant-as-truth-teller tradition is ancient and honourable, but it works only if the servant is occasionally also just tired, or wrong, or merely practical without being aphoristic. Draft B has not addressed this.

THE ENDING

Draft B's final paragraphs are stronger than Draft A's. Both end with the key on the desk and Leila's ankle, but Draft B adds a passage that Draft A lacks:

She grieved him in uncertainty. She grieved also the house, the quarter, the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still survive them.

And beneath both griefs, because truth was meaner than dignity, ran the low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her.

This is the emotional truth the entire novel has been circling. Draft A reaches for it — "Relief came with the knowledge and at once made itself ugly" — but Draft B names it with more specificity and more shame. The phrase "the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still survive them" is extraordinary because it makes wasted time — the afternoons Maryam did not visit Nawal, the errands that covered for desire — into something the novel mourns rather than condemns. That is a mature moral intelligence. Keep it.

However, Draft B then slightly overextends: "She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all. Yet the necessity others had begun carrying for her left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded." That third sentence is the narrator again explaining what the previous two sentences already made clear. Cut it. Let the two short sentences stand alone.

The final image — the key laid on the desk beside the folded gloves, opening nothing in the room where it has come to rest — is identical in both drafts and is exactly right. Do not alter it.

WHAT THE NOVEL DOES NOT YET HAVE

Neither draft gives Tariq enough interiority before Chapter XVIII. We know his manner, his speech, his effect on Maryam. We do not know what the affair costs him in his own world until Draft B's Chapter XVIII, and by then it is almost too late. The scene with his mother's shopping list (soap, paraffin, lentils, one candle) is the only moment before XVIII where his domestic life has material weight. The school scenes — Khalil, the headmaster, the notices — show his professional world. But his private life, his mother's cough, his own room, his own version of being watched by a quarter — all of this is withheld too long. Draft B's XVIII gives us a paragraph about the school ledger of names (crossed out, gone to Jericho, gone to the aunt in Ramallah) that is doing vital work. Consider whether some version of this —

Tariq's own ledger of losses — might appear earlier, perhaps in Chapter XI ("Tariq's Mother"), so that when the consummation comes in XIII, we feel not only what Maryam risks but what he does.

Neither draft solves the problem of Hanna's knowledge. The novel is scrupulously ambiguous about whether Hanna knows about the affair, and mostly this ambiguity serves the book well. But there are moments where it strains. "Empty rooms become foolish if one leaves them half respectable" and "There is no point now in encouraging unnecessary lingerings around a room nearly finished" — these lines from Hanna could be innocent or devastating, and the novel wants them to be both. That is legitimate. But in the bedroom scene at the end of XIII, when Hanna says "And the bed?" and Maryam has a "sickening second" thinking he knows, the narrative itself seems uncertain whether it wants to resolve this question or keep deferring it. In the final chapters, Hanna's "I have given you five more minutes" carries the force it does partly *because* we don't know what he knows. If that is the intended effect, then the earlier flirtation with revelation (the "sickening second") should be cut. It cheapens the ambiguity by making it seem accidental rather than structural.

SUMMARY OF RECOMMENDATIONS

Keep Draft B as the base text. It is the better manuscript. Specifically:

Restore from Draft A: the image of the note on the coverlet and the case on the chair as paired objects for the opening of Chapter XIX. Find a way to have this without sacrificing the unopened envelope from Draft B's XVIII. Keep Draft B's chapter titles throughout. Keep Draft B's ending. Cut roughly a third of the narrator's summarising epigrams. Audit the "not X but Y" constructions. Give Leila two or three moments of being simply a child rather than an oracle. Give Tariq one more scene of interiority before Chapter XIII. Decide — and commit — whether Hanna's ambiguity is structural or accidental, and trim whichever moments pull against the decision. Consider splitting Chapter XIX at the "five more minutes" moment.

The novel is serious work. It knows what it is about. Its greatest strength is its refusal to separate the domestic from the political, the erotic from the bureaucratic, the personal from the material. Its greatest remaining weakness is a prose style that, at its less disciplined moments, admires its own precision loudly enough to make the reader aware of the novelist rather than the world. When it trusts the objects — the key, the mug, the cedar dust, the turned rug, the unopened envelope — it is as good as anything in contemporary fiction about displacement. When it tells you what the objects mean, it is merely very good. The gap between those two is the work of the third draft.

REPLY VF C II

I. THE CENTRAL STRUCTURAL DECISION: THE AFFAIR

The single largest difference between these drafts is what happens in Uncle Yusef's flat.

Draft A keeps the physical affair entirely implicit. The reader accumulates evidence — the mug, the private hours, Mrs Farah's remark, Amina's glances, the growing charge between Maryam and Tariq — but never witnesses consummation. The novel ends with the affair's status unresolved: desire acknowledged, the demand made and unanswered, the key carried into exile as an emblem of something that may never have become body.

Draft B breaks that surface open. Chapter XIII ("The Half-Emptied Flat") stages the consummation explicitly: the kiss, the back room, the iron bed, the glove under the bed, the hat pin that won't come loose. Chapter XIV ("Less Room Than Before") then gives us the morning after, the shawl hidden under cardigans, and Amina finding cedar dust and indoor plaster on the coat.

Which is stronger? Neither, yet. Each solves one problem and creates another.

Draft A's restraint is the more daring formal choice and, in many passages, the more powerful one. The novel's engine is *delay* — delay as social habit, as moral cowardice, as the city's narrowing of possibility. When the affair itself is delayed into permanent ambiguity, the form enacts the theme. The key at the end opens a room that may contain nothing more than what we've seen: papers, dust, a chipped mug. That hollowness is devastating. The novel becomes about what people do instead of the thing they cannot bring themselves to do, and the displacement of that unfulfilled desire onto every domestic object in the house is what gives Draft A its particular, suffocating beauty.

The problem with Draft A is that by the time we reach The Demand (Chapter XV) and the confrontation in the flat — "I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another" — the emotional pressure has accumulated to a degree the text cannot sustain in abstraction alone. Tariq says, "You become honest for half a second and then retreat into furniture." But the novel itself has been retreating into furniture for 250 pages, and at that moment the reader needs the confrontation to land on something harder than another beautifully displaced object. Draft A's Demand scene is superb in dialogue — "You have not been an acceleration" is one of the best lines in either draft — but it resolves into more avoidance, and the late chapters feel slightly repetitive: another room, another key, another displaced feeling rendered as household inventory. The pattern, perfect for twelve chapters, begins to show its seams.

Draft B's consummation solves that problem. It breaks the pattern at exactly the point where the pattern risks becoming a cage. And the scene itself is written with real skill. The detail of the iron bed complaining under their weight, the hat pin that won't come loose, the laugh that becomes tears — these are materially exact in the way the whole novel demands. The sentence "A thing deferred through papers, errands, weather, child, church, death, road, and ordinary cowardice had become body" earns itself by echoing the novel's accumulated vocabulary. And Amina's detection through fabric — "The dust is from an inside wall, not the road. And there is damp at the sleeve where it caught on plaster" — is one of the finest moments in either draft, because it grants Amina's material knowledge the authority the narrative has been building for her all along.

The problem with Draft B's choice is that it risks collapsing the novel's central ambiguity into a conventional adultery plot. Once the affair is consummated, the reader's question shifts from *Will she?* to *Will she be caught?*, and the latter is a smaller question. The key at the end, in Draft B, now opens a room where something definite happened, and the ending's power — "opening nothing in the room where it had come to rest" — is slightly diminished because the nothing is no longer genuinely uncertain. It's a nothing produced by events overtaking a choice already made, rather than a nothing that might be the whole of the story.

My recommendation for Draft Three: Stage the affair, but do not stage it where Draft B stages it. Move the consummation later — perhaps into the space now occupied by The Demand or immediately after — and compress it. The iron bed, the hat pin, the glove: keep those details. But cut the post-coital scene by half. The fifteen minutes of "pathetic postscript by which adults try to restore innocence to a room that has lost it" is over-narrated; the sentence describing it is better than the scene enacting it. Let the consummation be brief, materially awkward, and then let the novel *immediately* return to the household, as Draft B does so well with the supper scene. The Amina coat-brushing scene must survive into Draft Three. It is the novel's single best scene of class, knowledge, and power.

II. PROSE: SENTENCE-LEVEL COMPARISON

The two drafts share most of their best sentences and most of their worst habits.

Best shared work:

The opening paragraph is nearly identical in both drafts and is excellent. "The blue glass vase on the sideboard stood empty because Maryam's mother had said, from the sofa and without opening her eyes properly, that fresh flowers looked festive." That parenthetical

physical detail — *without opening her eyes properly* — is the novel in miniature: control performed through the body before the mind has fully committed.

"Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners" (Draft A) vs "The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely learned better manners" (Draft B). Draft A is tighter and more epigrammatic. Draft B is less polished but actually better, because the shorter clause — "The disgust changed nothing" — has more weight, and the semicolon in Draft A makes the observation sound too pleased with itself. **Use Draft B's version.**

"We are short four spoons" / "We are short an uncle as well" / "That cannot be entered as an expense" / "It will be anyway." Both drafts carry this exchange identically. It is perfect. Do not touch it.

Where Draft A is tighter:

Draft A consistently compresses where Draft B expands. Compare the passage about Maryam's discovery that Uncle Yusef died alone:

Draft A: "That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no."

Draft B: "What stayed with her was not the stroke or the doctor, only the fact that no one had been with him."

Draft A's version is better. The three-beat structure — "Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no." — performs rhythmic contraction, and *The no* as a noun is startling in a way that Draft B's explanatory clause ("only the fact that no one had been with him") is not. The explanation kills the music.

This pattern recurs throughout. Draft A is almost always the more disciplined stylist at sentence level. Draft B tends to add a clause that explains what Draft A trusts the reader to feel.

Where Draft B is more precise:

Draft B occasionally finds a better word or image. In the Semiramis chapter, Draft B's "a violent correction to sleep" is stronger than anything in Draft A's corresponding passage. Draft B also adds, in the Semiramis aftermath, "News began travelling by the slower, more contaminating routes of social interpretation" — a sentence Draft A lacks and should adopt.

In the final chapter, Draft B adds: "That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether one had the right to keep them." This earns its place. Draft A should take it.

Shared weaknesses:

Both drafts share a chronic habit of over-explaining emotional states through aphoristic commentary. The novel is at its best when it trusts objects, gestures, and silences to carry meaning. It is at its weakest when it glosses them with sentences like:

- "That was perhaps the truest thing about him: he did not rank claims by sentiment."
- "It annoyed her that such kindness was real. It annoyed her more that she relied on it."
- "One could live beside a man for years and still not know whether silence in him was absence or concealment."

None of these are bad sentences. They are all slightly too available. They arrive as if the narrator does not trust the reader to have felt what the scene already demonstrated. The novel needs perhaps twenty percent fewer of these. The rule should be: if the preceding paragraph has already shown us the quality being named, cut the commentary. If the commentary reveals something the scene has not yet made visible, keep it.

The worst recurring tic in both drafts is the construction "Not X. Not Y. Only Z" or "Not X exactly. Not Y. More like Z." It appears dozens of times. Examples:

- "Not hope. Hope was too theatrical..."
- "Not guilt exactly. Not fear exactly."
- "Not memory exactly. Not comfort. More binding than either."
- "Not warmth, not forgiveness, only the mutual admission..."

This structure is powerful in its first five appearances. By its twentieth it has become a mannerism. Draft Three should audit every instance and retain no more than ten across the whole novel.

III. CHARACTER

Hanna is the novel's greatest achievement. In both drafts he is the most fully realised character: a man whose emotional life is expressed entirely through procedural competence, whose love takes the form of sequence, whose mercy arrives as allocation. The line "I have given you five more minutes" is the best single line in either draft, and it works because nineteen chapters have taught us what time means in his hands. Both drafts serve him equally well.

Maryam is strong but occasionally risks becoming a vehicle for the narrator's intelligence rather than her own. The novel gives her excellent observation — "death did not merely close a life; it edited it" — but too many of her observations are too polished for the moment. A woman standing at a window watching a British lorry should not be thinking "Ordinary life had begun carrying precautions inside it like hidden seams" in that exact prose register. The thought is right. The phrasing is too composed for the experience it describes.

Tariq is the weakest major character, in both drafts. He exists primarily as the object of Maryam's attention and as a generator of exact sentences. He is not uninteresting — his mended cuffs, his mother's grocery list in his satchel, his patience with Khalil — but he lacks the contradictions the other characters possess. Hanna is competent and emotionally stunted. Maryam is intelligent and morally evasive. Amina is perceptive and trapped. Tariq is exact. That is not enough for the novel's second centre of gravity. Draft B helps slightly by giving him the afternoon of waiting for Maryam in the stripped flat — the scene from his POV where Elias comes up three times — but even there his interiority is mostly patience and controlled desire, which are the same two notes the novel has already played for him repeatedly. Draft Three needs to find something in Tariq that surprises Maryam — and the reader — beyond his precision.

Leila is beautifully drawn in both drafts. "I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep the pencils" is perfect. "Church is repetitive" / "That is one of its points" is perfect. The danger is that she is too consistently witty. Children this age are sometimes devastating and sometimes boring. Leila is never boring. One or two moments where she is simply petulant, or simply frightened without a clever line to carry the fear, would make the other moments sharper.

Amina is the novel's moral centre, and both drafts know this. "In houses, most things are" is the thematic keystone. Draft B's Amina — who detects the affair through fabric — is stronger than Draft A's, because the knowledge gives her power over Maryam rather than merely parallel insight, and the restraint with which she exercises that power ("Not me. I am only telling you that cedar dust shows on dark wool if one knows where to look") is the finest expression of her character in either draft.

Aunt Widad is excellent throughout. "Family is annexation conducted with soup." "Not yours. That is sometimes the most exact category available." Both drafts serve her identically.

IV. ARCHITECTURE

Both drafts are twenty chapters. The chapter titles are strong. The progression — from condolence through papers, the vote, Semiramis, thinning rooms, the demand, the note, departure — is the correct arc. Neither draft should add chapters. Both are already slightly too long.

The weakest section in both drafts is the stretch from Chapters V through VII ("Papers and Pretexts," "The Radio," "The Wrong Reasons"). The novel here does essential thematic work — establishing the affair's slow accretion, the UN vote, the neighbourhood's tightening — but it does so through scenes that repeat the same emotional pattern: Maryam notices Tariq, notices herself noticing, displaces the noticing into domestic obligation, and the narrator comments on the displacement. By Chapter VII, the reader has understood this mechanism and is waiting for it to change. Draft Three should compress these three chapters into two.

The strongest section in both drafts is Chapters IX through XII (Semiramis through Thinning Rooms). Here the novel's two pressures — the private affair and the public catastrophe — begin occupying the same sentences, and the prose responds with its best work. Neither draft should cut anything from this section.

V. SPECIFIC PASSAGES NEITHER DRAFT HAS SOLVED

1. **Nadia's letters.** Both drafts use the letters from Beirut as a structural device — papers first, silver second — and the letters are effective as punctuation. But Nadia herself remains thin. We know her by her tone ("Bring papers first and silver second. Leave sentimental objects to those with larger luggage and weaker sense"), which is brilliant, but she is essentially a voice in an envelope. Since her letters carry the novel's deepest political argument — *come before your reasons begin sounding respectable to you* — she deserves at least one memory of her as a body in space, not merely as prose style. Give Maryam one memory of Nadia laughing, or eating, or being wrong about something, so that when the letters arrive they carry weight beyond their sentences.

2. **Deir Yassin.** Both drafts handle this with admirable restraint — "The name Deir Yassin entered the house not through the radio first but through bread" — but the scene that follows does not quite earn its own brevity. The novel has been so patient and detailed about every other intrusion of history into the household that the rapid compression of Deir Yassin into a few paragraphs feels not like restraint but like avoidance. This is the hardest passage in the book to get right. It cannot be expanded into reportage. But it needs one more beat — one image from outside the house,

something Amina or Huda has seen, something that enters the room as material fact rather than as circulating rumour — to match the novel's own standard of physical specificity.

3. **The departure.** Both drafts handle the truck, the packing, and the locking of the house with great skill. But the transition from the house to the schoolroom is too fast in both. The truck ride itself is rendered in a single paragraph. This is the novel's hinge — the moment domestic life ceases to be possible — and it deserves the same slow, material attention the novel gives to every other threshold crossing. One page of the truck ride: what is seen, what is heard, what Leila says, what Hanna does not say.

VI. FINAL RECOMMENDATION

Draft Three should use Draft A as its base text for prose discipline, chapters I–VIII, and the final two chapters. It should import from Draft B: the consummation scene (compressed), the Amina coat-brushing scene, the expanded Semiramis chapter, and the additional interior lines in the ending about the key. It should cut the aphoristic commentary by twenty percent, compress Chapters V–VII, give Tariq one moment of genuine surprise, and add one page to the truck ride.

The novel is serious, original, and in places quite brilliant. Its central metaphor — that paperwork is the last form of agency in a collapsing world, and also the first form of self-deception — holds across twenty chapters without ever becoming schematic. It knows what it is about. Draft Three needs to trust that knowledge more often at sentence level and stop explaining itself at the moments where the objects are already doing the work.

THIS IS WHAT VF II ASKED

I am giving you two drafts of the same novel. Read both in full before responding. Then tell me what you find — what works, what doesn't, where one draft solves a problem the other hasn't, and where both still fall short. I am not asking you to choose a winner. I am asking you to read as an editor whose only loyalty is to the book these two drafts are trying to become. If that book is closer to one draft than the other, say so. If it lives in neither but somewhere between them, show me where. Go from the largest questions — does the story earn its ending, does the architecture hold, does the reader want to keep reading — down to the smallest — a sentence, a word, a comma that changes what a line does. Nothing is too small to mention if it matters to the reading experience, and nothing is too large to challenge if the novel hasn't earned it. Be specific. Use the text. Show me what you mean by pointing to it.

That's it. No categories, no rubric, no scaffolding. It asks for one thing — editorial truth — and gives permission to go anywhere the text leads. The MCCOC at the end will handle tone.

REPLY VF II CG I

I’ve read both in full: *Complete First Draft Polish* and *QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash* .

The good news is that this is a novel, not a promising exercise. The bad news is that it sometimes knows that too well. There is real authority here: social, emotional, historical, tonal. The book understands its own world at the level of cups, shutters, ledgers, coughs, stockings, missing spoons, wrong roads, and who gets to touch which drawer. That is not decorative intelligence. It is the book’s substance. The opening line about the room being “corrected for grief” is exactly right, because it announces the whole method at once: feeling entering through household protocol, politics entering through errands and altered habits, desire entering through usefulness before it ever becomes touch. Both drafts have that authority. Neither feels fake.

The book is closer to the Polish draft overall, and decisively closer in the last three chapters. But the best version is not simply the Polish draft untouched. It is mostly the Polish draft, with some hard steals from Draft B where B is cleaner, more concrete, and less tempted to pre-explain itself.

The largest issue is the ending, because that is where the two drafts finally reveal what sort of novel they think they are. Draft B gives you a cleaner mechanism: Tariq waits, the note comes back unopened, and the chapter lands on “The note was under the mug. The mug

was on the sill. The room held the rest." It is elegant. It is also slightly too elegant. It makes circumstance do too much of the tragic work for the novel. It leaves Maryam in ignorance and the reader in a superior position, which gives you pain, but a slightly schematic pain. The Polish draft is messier and better. It lets the note reach Maryam too late, lets it sit in her pocket through supper, then puts it beside Hanna's small case so that desire and evacuation occupy the same room at the same time: "On the coverlet lay the note. On the chair sat the case. One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early." That is the right contamination. It forces Maryam to know and still be unable to act. It also lets Hanna's practicality become part of the tragedy rather than merely its logistics. That is a major improvement. The same is true of the later beat when Hanna reports, flatly, that the flat door has not been disturbed and Maryam feels relief "and at once" knows it is ugly. That is adult, morally dirty, and earned. Draft B's ending is better outline-elegance. The Polish draft is better fiction.

That said, both endings still flirt with over-curation. By the time you reach the close, you have the note, the mug, the case, the key, the shutter, the pencils, the displaced room. Nearly all of them work. The danger is accumulation. The book is strong with charged objects; it is weaker when it starts arranging them for admiration. The line about the key "promis[ing] only access" is close to saying what the object has already said. I would trust the object more and the gloss less. The Polish draft is nearer the truth here, but I still think the final pages need one more ruthless cut against explanation.

Structurally, the novel largely holds. The opening third is excellent. The Semiramis section is the hinge, and it earns its place because Nawal is not just there to be killed for thematic depth. The whole earlier architecture of postponement makes that catastrophe bite twice: first as public event, then as private accusation. The book understands that what the hotel blast destroys is not only a building but a promise deferred once too often. That is strong. The reader does want to keep reading, and not out of dutiful respect. The world is too alive for that. But the propulsion is uneven because the middle is too often built in the same shape: breakfast or drawing room, paper or errand, exact conversation, closing paragraph of distilled intelligence. The pressure increases, yes, but the scene-rhythm does not vary enough. Chapters V–VIII and, later, XII–XV often arrive in the same tonal key even when the material is changing. The result is not sag exactly. It is over-evenness.

This is where Draft B sometimes solves a problem the Polish draft reintroduces. Draft B is better at starting inside the scene instead of clearing its throat before the scene begins. The clearest example is Chapter V. Draft B starts, "The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast." That is immediate, hard, and alive. The Polish draft inserts a competent but less necessary prefatory paragraph

before arriving at the better opening. Same problem in Chapter VI: Draft B begins with cold air, Leila saying the day “resembled a doctor,” and the reader is in motion at once; the Polish version begins with summary about Yusef’s papers ceasing to behave like grief and beginning to behave like work. That summary is true, but it is not the best entry point. In other words: the Polish pass improves the book’s emotional logic, but now and then it steps back from the scene at the exact moment it should step into it. Draft B is often cleaner in chapter ignition.

The characters are mostly excellent. Hanna is one of the book’s strongest achievements because he is never simplified into husband-as-obstacle. He is dry, exact, constricting, decent, often right, and emotionally costly. That is much more interesting than a bad husband. He is at his best when his care comes through bounded allocation rather than declaration: “I have given you five more minutes” is a superb Hanna line because it is merciful, controlling, loving, insufficient, and maddening all at once. Amina is even better, perhaps because the novel never sentimentalises her clarity. “People notice standing still more than walking” is exactly the sort of doubled line this book does best: social advice, moral warning, erotic diagnosis, survival instruction, all in one. Aunt Widad is vivid and distinct. The mother works too, though by the later chapters she risks becoming a little too reliably herself; she seldom surprises, only confirms.

Maryam is strong, but the book occasionally lets her interpret a scene a fraction too quickly and too well. She is an excellent reader of social pressure. The problem is that the novel sometimes borrows that intelligence before the scene has finished happening. The best Maryam moments are not her most polished ones. They are the compromised ones: the missed hotel visit; the late note; the ugly relief; the inability to answer Tariq cleanly because all the right reasons are also evasions. Keep driving her towards that kind of contamination. She gets more interesting the less fully she can narrate herself.

Tariq is where the novel still needs roughening. He is compelling. He is also over-protected by the prose. Too often he arrives as exactness made man: the right phrase, the right restraint, the right wounded plainness. The book knows this, and Chapter XI helps by giving him a mother, a school, a list that includes “soap, paraffin, lentils, one candle,” and later Chapter XV helps even more by finally letting him go sharp: “I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another,” then the harder wound, “It is the one that leaves you blameless.” That scene is the proof of what he can be when he stops being merely lucid and becomes inconvenient. The book needs a little more of that before and after. Not melodrama. Friction. More pride. More cost. More of the sense that his precision is not just attractive but damaging, limited, and sometimes unfair.

The affair itself is mostly earned. The book is smart enough not to make the erotic charge arise from glamour. It arises from use, repetition, work, shared exactness, the relief of being read without condescension. That is right. Chapter XIII earns the bed because the novel has already made repetition dangerous. But the book is at its very best not in the consummation itself, which is well done, but in the residue after it: the shawl hidden, the coat dust, Amina noticing too much, the changed social weather. That is where the novel stops being "forbidden love during catastrophe" and becomes itself. Keep leaning towards the residue, not the event.

At sentence level, the prose is powerful and dangerously mannered. I mean both words. When it is on, it is exact without prettiness and intelligent without softening. When it slips, it starts to sound like it knows it is exact. The repeated antithetical structure is the main problem: "Not this. Not that. Only…"; "It was not X. It was Y."; "That was the trouble…"; "The sentence…"; "exact," "practical," "indecent," "arrangement," "weather," "delay." Early on these are part of the book's nervous system. Later they become recognisable house style. Once the reader starts hearing the instrument more than the music, you are in trouble. The book does this often enough that it needs a line-by-line cull, especially in the later middle and ending. Not a flattening. A cull. Remove the visibly made lines. Keep the hard ones. Let the image stand where it has already done the work.

This is also why some of the title changes do not help. "The Price of Seeing" is arguable; it names the moral cost, but it is more literary in intention than the novel usually is at its best. "The Half-Emptied Flat" is blunter and more faithful to the book's method. "After," though, is simply weak. It is not a title; it is a placeholder. "Less Room Than Before" is much better. This novel is strongest when the abstract is forced through rooms, lists, objects, routes, and domestic humiliations. The more the titles remember that, the better.

So the blunt version is this. Draft B is often cleaner. The Polish draft is often truer. Draft B gives you harder chapter starts, some better concrete naming, and occasionally a more ruthless refusal to over-handle. The Polish draft gives you the better final architecture, the better moral contamination, and the better version of what this book actually is. The book those two drafts are trying to become is mostly the Polish draft from Semiramis onwards, but with Draft B's willingness to enter scenes later and exit them a touch sooner.

If I were editing towards the real book, I would keep the Polish structure of Chapters XVIII–XX, keep the demand scene as a central pillar, restore Draft B's Chapter V opening, strongly consider restoring Draft B's Chapter VI opening, replace "After" with something better, and do a merciless prose pass for the antithetical tic and any sentence that explains an object after the object has already landed.

The novel is not failing. It is, more dangerously, succeeding in a way that now demands harder self-denial. That is a better problem to have.

REPLY VF II CG II

I've read *Complete First Draft Polish* and *QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash* in full.

The book is closer to *Complete First Draft Polish*. Not because that draft wins every exchange. It does not. It is closer because it more clearly understands what the novel actually is. This is not, at heart, a historical panorama, and it is not chiefly an adulterous-love novel either. It is a novel about how public catastrophe enters private life through administration: papers, rooms, routes, spoons, ledgers, beds, cups, notices, errands, keys. When the book knows that, it is excellent. When it forgets and starts explaining its own intelligence back to itself, it slows down.

Its best early statement of itself is in the first chapter. In Polish, Maryam thinks that death 'did not merely close a life; it edited it'. That is the novel. Not death as sublime event, but death as revision, omission, paperwork, household traffic. Later the book says, even more nakedly, 'Death … had not created grandeur. It had created work.' That is the spine, and it is the right one. The book's real originality is that it makes history felt through domestic management rather than speeches. The line about the city entering houses 'not in speeches. In altered expectations' gets the method exactly right. When the novel works, it never has to announce politics because politics is already in the delayed servant, the watched road, the moved bed, the copied form, the wrong route home.

That is why the architecture mostly holds. Rooms narrow. Duties multiply. Objects recur with cumulative force: the blue vase, Yusef's spectacles, the mug on the sill, the key, the stockings, the map on the table. None of that is decorative. It is structural memory. The house and the flat are not settings; they are moral instruments. The book knows how to make a wardrobe removal or a missing spoon matter. Very few novels can do that without turning fussy. This one usually can.

But the middle does blur. Not because nothing happens. A great deal happens. The problem is that too many chapters arrive through the same choreography: breakfast, errand, papers, the flat, return, night, reflection. That sameness is partly the point — life narrowing into repeated forms — but narrative design cannot live on theme alone. Between *After Semiramis* and *The Demand*, especially, the novel begins proving the same truth in slightly altered household arrangements. I kept reading because the prose is intelligent and the pressure is

real, but a colder reader will start to feel the mechanism. The hinge chapters are clear: the funeral, the radio, Semiramis, the emptied flat/affair, the demand, the note, the removal. Everything between them has to sharpen, not just continue.

One place where Polish solves a real structural problem is Chapter VI. In *QATAMON*, Chapter VI opens with weather and the morning air: elegant, atmospheric, but a touch detached. In Polish, it opens with 'Uncle Yusef's papers had ceased to behave like grief and begun behaving like work.' That is a better bridge. It keeps the book on its true track and lets the radio/political turn grow out of the established machinery of paper, obligation and household sequence. That is a genuine fix. On the other hand, Chapter V in *QATAMON* has an opening line Polish should not have dropped: 'The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic.' That is first-rate. It is cleaner, harder, and more memorable than the replacement. So the answer there is not Draft A or Draft B. It is B's opening sentence with A's stronger continuation.

The biggest difference, and the one that matters most, is the ending. In *QATAMON*, Maryam never knows the note was written. The reader knows; she does not. That creates dramatic irony, but it also keeps the last movement one step too abstract for her. She ends in the schoolroom grieving an unanswered question she only half knows. In Polish, the note reaches her too late: 'Today. Four o'clock. The flat. If you can come, come. I will be there until dark.' That is far stronger. It gives the last act a concrete object, not just a conceptual loss. Then Polish makes the next essential move: it places the note and the packing case in the same room. 'One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early.' That is the novel's late pressure rendered physically, and it is much better than B's more withheld version. It makes the evacuation and the final key feel earned because the book has forced the missed chance into matter.

That said, *QATAMON* keeps one brutal clarity that Polish partly softens. In B's final chapter Maryam thinks, 'She had not chosen correctly. She had not chosen at all.' That is blunt, almost too blunt, but it names the moral centre. Polish trims towards greater subtlety: 'The choice had been lifted out of reach and the knowledge of that felt, for a moment, like rest.' That is finer writing, and because Polish has already made the note concrete it can afford more obliquity. Even so, I think something from B's harder admission should survive somewhere nearby. The ideal final movement is Polish's architecture with a trace of B's merciless plain-speaking still left in the bloodstream.

So: does the story earn its ending? Nearly. In Polish, nearly enough that I believe in the final image of the key. The key is earned. The narrowing is earned. The sense that history has stripped choice down to logistics is earned. What is not fully earned, still, is the last degree of Maryam's moral self-recognition. The novel knows her central tactic. Tariq names it in the

strongest confrontation in the book: ‘It is the one that leaves you blameless.’ That line is devastating because it is not only what he says to her; it is what the novel says to itself. Maryam’s difficulty is real. Her child, her mother, Huda, the house, the roads, Hanna — all of that is real. But the book also knows that real difficulty can become shelter. After Tariq says ‘I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another’, the novel is at its most dangerous and truthful. It needs to stay there. Too often afterwards, history begins doing some of Maryam’s moral work for her. That is where the ending still stops just shy of fully earned.

Hanna is one of the book’s great successes, and also one of its structural problems. He is not a cardboard husband. He is not there to be outgrown. He is exact, dry, competent, irritating, and often right. His love is procedural, which is why it is so moving when it shows. Lines like his insistence on choosing what one ‘would not wish to choose quickly’, or his way of turning every crisis into the next manageable interval, give him real gravity. The novel’s description of him — that for him love is often ‘indistinguishable from prevention’ — is dead right. The problem is that Hanna is so alive that Tariq has to do more than be Maryam’s intellectual echo. Sometimes he does. Chapter XI helps. The later note scene helps. The waiting scene helps. But not enough.

The hard truth is that Maryam and Tariq sometimes sound as though they were forged in the same verbal furnace. He gets excellent lines — ‘Bureaucracy does not object to death. It objects to incomplete death’ is very good — but his mind often moves in the same polished contraries and clipped exactitudes as Maryam’s narration. Hanna, by contrast, sounds like Hanna. Amina sounds like Amina. Aunt Widad sounds like Aunt Widad. Leila sounds like a child made slightly more dangerous by accuracy. Tariq is still, too often, a beautifully fitted pressure-point in Maryam’s consciousness rather than a fully separate human presence. The novel knows this and keeps trying to solve it with his burdens — mother, school, Khalil, notices, routes — but the stylistic separation is still not strong enough.

That is why the affair works intellectually before it works bodily. The book understands exactly what attracts Maryam: not romance in the cheap sense, but being met in her own exactness by someone who does not diminish it. Good. True. But the novel is sometimes stronger on the interpretation of the affair than on the lived event of it. In Chapter XIII, the line ‘The first dangerous thing in an affair was not touch. It was repetition’ is excellent. So is the description of the kiss as ‘a mistake recognised as itself while being committed’. But the scene occasionally hovers above itself, explaining its own danger while the bodies are still catching up. I would cut some of the interpretive sentences in that chapter and let the bed, cedar, cold, iron frame, stripped room and fear do more of the work. The material is already there. It does not need quite so much authorial escort.

Nawal is very well used. One scene, one invitation, one failure of attention, then Semiramis. That line of guilt is properly set up. When Maryam says 'I was going to go' after the explosion, the book cashes a cheque it prepared honestly. That is good architecture. Nadia, on the other hand, remains more functional than fully alive. Her letters do useful work — Beirut as possible exit, kinship as logistics, another life sounding from elsewhere — but Nawal, with far less page-space, feels more human. That is not fatal. It just means Nadia's thread is primarily instrumental. Either deepen her tonal presence or accept her as function and trim any places where the book is pretending she is more emotionally central than she currently is.

Amina and Leila are the book's great anti-ornamental forces. They save it repeatedly from becoming upholstered in its own intelligence. Amina's lies, covers, labour, and material reading of the world are indispensable. Leila's questions do real work too: not cute work, real work. When she says something like 'That seems rude' or interrogates adult euphemism, the book gets air. I do not think they are overused. I do think the novel sometimes knows, a little too well, that a Leila line will sharpen a dense page. That is a small issue, not a large one.

At the line level, Polish is usually stronger, but it also illustrates the book's main prose danger: over-finishing. When it is right, it is beautifully exact. 'Death did not merely close a life; it edited it' is better than B's 'death edited a life as much as it ended one'. 'The Price of Seeing' is a better chapter title than 'The Half-Emptied Flat' because it tells the truth about cost, not just scene furniture. But Polish also has a habit of adding one more sentence to tell you what the scene already told you. B is sometimes better at stopping. A small example: after a sharp exchange, B will simply give you 'The room went still.' Polish is likelier to add the interpretive gloss as well. That is not always wrong. Too often it is unnecessary.

Related to that: the book leans heavily on self-cancelling syntax. Not this. Not exactly that. Not because. Not with bitterness, not even quite with love. That is part of Maryam's mind, and part of the novel's moral atmosphere. But the habit has spread beyond where it is most useful. When every paragraph keeps correcting its own first statement, precision starts to feel like reluctance. The same applies to the beautifully turned chapter-end sentences. 'Tomorrow would belong to papers.' 'Nothing had happened except usefulness and paper.' 'The room held exactly the width of one night.' All good lines. Too many of them, too regularly placed, and the cadence becomes a mannerism. Save more plain endings. Let some chapters stop on the event rather than on the polished distillation of it.

A smaller but not trivial note: most of the title changes in Polish are improvements, but not all. 'The Price of Seeing' is better. 'After' is worse. It is too abstract for a novel whose power comes from exact spatial and domestic pressure. 'Less Room Than Before' may be less

elegant, but it belongs more natively to this book's system of meaning. If 'After' stays, it wants to earn that abstraction more forcefully inside the chapter than it currently does.

So the book these drafts are trying to become is not halfway between them in any equal sense. It is built on *Complete First Draft Polish*. That is the base text. But it still needs several things from *QATAMON*: B's cleaner Chapter V opening, B's occasional harder stop after a strong beat, and a little of B's willingness in the last pages to say, plainly, that Maryam has not merely been trapped by history but has also been protected by indecision until history makes indecision impossible.

The deepest truth is this: the novel already has a real subject and a real form. Its subject is not love under siege. It is the shrinking moral space in which love, duty, class, kinship, labour and catastrophe begin occupying the same room. Its form is not plot in the conventional sense. It is pressure translated into household sequence. That is why the book is worth taking seriously. What it still needs is not reinvention. It needs slightly more trust: more trust in silence after a hard line, more trust in the concrete object over the explanatory gloss, more trust that Maryam can survive being seen as less blameless than she would prefer, and more trust that Tariq can stand on the page as something other than the exact man for this exact woman.

REPLY VF II C I

The core finding: These are not two drafts. They are one draft at two stages of refinement. Roughly 85-90% of the prose is identical or nearly so, with Draft B (the al-Khashkhash title) being the later, tighter revision. The book lives closer to Draft B, but Draft B has introduced one structural choice — the Tariq POV in Chapter XVIII — that needs serious scrutiny.

Architecture and structure

Draft A runs 20 chapters but merges the final two into one bloated 7,000-word chapter ("Five More Minutes" absorbing "The Key"). Draft B correctly separates them. The separation works. "Five More Minutes" is about the evacuation — the domestic machinery of departure — and "The Key" is about what remains after arrival: the schoolroom, the blankets, the key held in the dark. They are different emotional registers. Cramming both into one chapter, as Draft A does, exhausts the reader before the final image can land. Draft B's two-chapter ending is the right call.

Draft B also renames Chapter XIII from "The Price of Seeing" to "The Half-Emptied Flat" and Chapter XIV from "After" to "Less Room Than Before." In both cases Draft B is better. "The

Price of Seeing" is too thematic, too knowing — it announces its own significance. "The Half-Emptied Flat" earns its metaphor by refusing to make one. "Less Room Than Before" does the same work as "After" but carries the novel's spatial logic (rooms shrinking, the quarter tightening) into the chapter title. "After" is empty.

The Tariq POV in Chapter XVIII — the novel's biggest open question

Draft A's Chapter XVIII stays with Maryam. She goes about her morning, collects Leila from school, returns home, and finds the note on the table. We never see Tariq write it, send the boy, or wait. The note arrives as an object among objects — beside the map, the sugar bowl, the parish slips. It enters her world the way the city's danger does: through paper, through domestic surfaces.

Draft B breaks the novel's POV discipline. For the first and only time, it enters Tariq's consciousness. We watch him write the note, fold it, hand it to the boy. We watch him wait in the empty flat. We watch the boy return with the note unopened. The back shutter rattles. The mug sits on the sill. He leaves.

This is the hardest editorial call in the book. Here's the case for and against:

For Draft B's choice: The scene is superb prose. The image of the unopened envelope placed under the mug on the sill is one of the novel's best. We need to feel the cost of the affair on Tariq's side, not just Maryam's. Without this scene, Tariq risks becoming merely an instrument of Maryam's moral crisis rather than a person with his own weight.

Against it: The novel has spent seventeen chapters building a very specific contract with the reader. We see through Maryam, through the house, through domestic surfaces. Even Hanna is known only as he appears to her — she reads his silence, his cuffs, his methods. Breaking that contract once, at the penultimate crisis, feels like a loss of nerve. It says the author didn't trust the reader to feel Tariq's absence through Maryam's experience of it. And in Draft B's own Chapter XX (the ending), the novel then tells us explicitly that Maryam "did not know that a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened" — which is powerful precisely because we *do* know, but only if we've been given it. This creates dramatic irony. But it also violates the novel's deepest formal principle.

My instinct: the Tariq scene should exist but should not sit where Draft B puts it. If you can find a way to fold its essential information into the ending — into that final paragraph of Chapter XX where Maryam lies awake not knowing — without giving Tariq his own POV chapter, the novel stays formally whole and the reader carries the weight of the unknowing. If you cannot do that without the scene becoming merely expository, then Draft B's gamble is justified and the formal break becomes the cost of truth. Either way, the current Draft B

structure where the reader gets the Tariq scene and then Maryam's ignorance of it is the stronger arrangement over Draft A, which simply omits Tariq's side entirely.

What both drafts do brilliantly

The domestic surface is extraordinary. I mean this without qualification. The opening chapter — the condolence house, the coffee, the spectacles, the turned rug — sets a standard of tactile domestic precision that both drafts sustain across 70,000+ words without the machinery becoming visible. Leila's dialogue is perfect throughout: "How much coffee does a soul need?" / "That seems unfair" / "I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep the pencils." The child never says anything cute. She says things exact enough to wound.

Hanna is one of the most complete portraits of a certain kind of decent, competent, emotionally unavailable man I've read in contemporary fiction. The line "Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention" is the character in a sentence. He is never made a villain, never turned into a straw man for Maryam's affair to burn against. The scene where Maryam overhears him telling Huda "Then we will know more in a month than we know now" is devastating because it shows tenderness arriving as administration — and forces the reader to ask whether that's a flaw or a form of love the novel's protagonist has spent years refusing to recognise.

Amina is the novel's conscience and its best-drawn secondary character. She operates entirely through matter — hems, cedar dust, buttons, tea cloths — and every physical observation she makes carries moral intelligence without ever converting it into speech. The pantry scene in Chapter XIII, where she finds the loose button and the cedar dust on the coat, is the novel's finest instance of a character knowing something and communicating that knowledge entirely through the vocabulary of her labour. "Cedar dust shows on dark wool if one knows where to look. Also the tea in the flat is stronger than ours. It stays in the cloth." That is a complete moral judgement rendered as laundry.

The Semiramis chapter works in both drafts. Nawal's death earns the weight it's given. The crooked hat, Amina's "I knew her hat," Leila's "Then you cannot visit tomorrow" — all of it lands.

Where both drafts still fall short

Tariq himself is underdeveloped. We know his cuffs are patched. We know his mother's shopping list. We know he reads well in French. We know he is exact. But we don't know enough about what he risks, what his world costs him, what the affair means inside his own life beyond the flat. The novel tells us he has a mother, pupils, a colleague in Khalil, a satchel. But it withholds from us anything that would make his desire as complex as Maryam's. He

functions too often as a screen onto which she projects the qualities Hanna lacks — wit, recognition, intellectual companionship — and not enough as a man with his own contradictions. This is the novel's weakest structural element. The affair cannot bear its full weight unless both participants are fully present.

The middle third (roughly Chapters V–VIII) sags. The rhythm of papers, errands, and escalating domestic friction is realistic but begins to feel repetitive. Several chapters end on the same note: Maryam lying awake thinking of the flat, the key, the work ahead. Both drafts need a harder editorial eye on chapter endings in this stretch. Each ending should alter the reader's understanding, not confirm it.

Nawal is introduced and killed with great skill, but she arrives too late in the novel's first half for her death to carry its maximum force. By Chapter IX we've had perhaps three scenes with her — the church courtyard, one brief conversation. She's vivid in those scenes, but her presence in Maryam's life hasn't been built with enough density for the guilt to feel fully earnt. One more Nawal scene in Chapters IV-VI would do it.

Line-level differences worth noting

Where Draft B trims, it usually trims well. Draft A's "Not a wound or a triumph. It was only an alteration" at the opening of Ch XIV becomes Draft B's cleaner "Altered, that was all." Same information, less performance. Similarly, Draft A's "the familiar mixture: gratitude, irritation, admiration, fatigue. No one of them ever arrived alone" is cut in Draft B — rightly, because the novel has already shown us this mixture many times and naming it is redundant.

Draft B adds one line to the key scene in Ch XX that Draft A lacks: "That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether one had the right to keep them." This is good and should stay. It earns the key as a symbol by refusing to make it one.

Draft B's Chapter XVIII opening — "The house had begun shutting itself without anyone quite admitting that this was what it was doing" — is sharper than Draft A's more elaborate version. The compression is right for where the novel is by this point. The reader doesn't need the extended breakfast choreography Draft A gives us; we've seen enough breakfasts to fill in the rest.

The ending

Both drafts end on the same image: the key laid on the desk, "opening nothing in the room where it had come to rest." It works. It earns its quiet. Draft B gets there more cleanly because the two-chapter structure gives the ending room to breathe after the evacuation. Draft A rushes it.

But Draft B's ending carries additional freight because of the Tariq POV scene. The reader knows what Maryam doesn't — that the note was sent, carried, returned, placed under the mug. So when Maryam lies in the dark holding the key to the flat, the reader holds two kinds of ignorance: hers (she doesn't know about the note) and history's (neither of them knows what comes next). That double weight is what makes the ending feel like it belongs to a novel about 1948 rather than merely a novel set in 1948.

The verdict

The book lives closer to Draft B. It's tighter, better titled, better structured at the end. The one major question — the Tariq POV — is a genuine editorial gamble, not a mistake. The novel needs more Tariq, not less; the question is only whether it needs him through his own eyes or through the negative space of his absence. Draft B chooses the former and the ending is stronger for it, even if the formal purist in me resists.

What neither draft has yet solved: making Tariq a full person rather than a function, thickening Nawal's presence before Semiramis, and tightening the middle third. These are solvable problems. The novel's foundation — its ear for domestic detail, its refusal to let politics overwhelm the human, its treatment of Hanna, Amina, and Leila — is exceptional in both drafts.

The Demand (Chapter XV) — where both drafts are at their strongest

This is the novel's real climax, not the consummation scene in Chapter XIII. The sex scene is well-handled — awkward, material, unglamorous — but it's Chapter XV where the emotional architecture bears its full load. Tariq's line "I need to know whether I am arranging one life or another" is the cleanest sentence in the book. It doesn't ask for love. It asks for information. And that's what makes it devastating — because it puts Maryam's indecision in the vocabulary of the very bureaucratic exactness the novel has spent fourteen chapters building. He's asking her to file him correctly. Family, archive, or neglect.

The exchange that follows — "It is the one that leaves you blameless" — is the scene the whole novel has been building towards, because it strips away every shelter Maryam has constructed. The child, the house, the city, Huda, the roads. All true. All, as Tariq says, furniture. Both drafts handle this identically, which tells me you knew this was the load-bearing wall.

But there's a problem in the aftermath, and both drafts share it. After this confrontation, the bed men arrive and Hanna appears. The scene becomes practical again. The demand is shelved. And it never fully returns in either draft. Chapters XVI and XVII move into the tightening city — narrowing streets, the third letter from Nadia — and the personal question gets absorbed into the historical one. This is thematically right (the city forecloses the

private dilemma) but dramatically incomplete. The reader doesn't know what Maryam would have done had history not intervened. That ambiguity is deliberate, but at present it risks reading as evasion rather than tragic irresolution. You need one more beat — even half a paragraph — in which Maryam confronts what she would have chosen had the choice remained hers. Not answers it. Confronts it. The ending gestures at this ("the low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her") but it arrives too late and too abstractly. The novel earns that line only if an earlier scene has shown us Maryam reaching for a decision and failing, not because circumstances prevented her but because she herself could not.

Amina — the novel's structural miracle

I said earlier she's the best-drawn secondary character. That understates it. Amina is the novel's formal conscience. Every time the prose risks becoming too interior, too Maryam-centred, Amina arrives with a material fact — cedar dust, a loose button, a hem that "shows everything" — and grounds the narrative in the physical world. She is the novel's answer to its own potential weakness: the danger that domestic interiority becomes airless.

But she's more than that. She's the class counterweight. The novel is about a bourgeois Christian Arab family in 1948 Jerusalem. It knows this. The risk of such a setting is that the reader's sympathy flows entirely to people whose losses, however real, are losses of comfort, position, property. Amina — Muslim, working-class, navigating the same city with fewer protections and no room of her own — refracts every one of the family's dramas through a harsher lens. When she says "In houses, most things are" (a matter of cleaning), she's saying something the novel itself needs to hear: that the moral drama Maryam is conducting with such exquisite self-scrutiny is, from another angle, a problem of laundry.

Both drafts handle her equally well. The one place I'd push: we never learn what happens to Amina after the family moves to the schoolrooms. Draft A has her appearing in the schoolroom scenes. Draft B is less clear. Her fate matters — not because the novel owes every character resolution, but because Amina's presence or absence in those final rooms tells us something about what survives displacement and what doesn't. The family keeps its silver, its icons, its cases. Does it keep her?

Leila — where the novel earns its lightness

Every line of Leila's dialogue works. Not one fails. This is rare. Child characters in literary fiction are usually either unbearably precious or weirdly adult. Leila is neither. She is exactly as intelligent as a bright six-year-old is: she asks the right questions for the wrong reasons, makes logical deductions from insufficient data, and treats adult behaviour as a species of institutional incompetence she has not yet been taught to tolerate.

"One is short and the other is unjust" (about slate pencils). "I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep the pencils." "Church is repetitive." "That seems like a poor arrangement." These are not cute. They are structurally necessary. They puncture the adult register of management, grief, and self-deception with a clarity the narrative cannot provide from within Maryam's consciousness without becoming editorial. Leila is the book's pressure valve.

The one risk: she's so consistently good that by Chapter XII or so the reader begins to expect her to be good, and expectation is the enemy of surprise. Consider one scene where Leila is simply petulant, ordinary, charmless. One scene where a child is just a child and not an oracle. It would make the rest of her sharper.

The middle sag (Chapters V–VIII) — specifics

The problem isn't that these chapters are bad. They're not. The problem is one of diminishing returns on a pattern. Each chapter follows roughly the same structure: breakfast scene → errand or visit → encounter with Tariq or city tension → domestic aftermath → Maryam alone at night. The pattern is deliberate — it mirrors the routine the family is trying to maintain as the city worsens — but by Chapter VII ("The Wrong Reasons") the reader has internalised the rhythm too fully. The surprise of the domestic surface has become its own convention.

Chapter V ("Papers and Pretexts") is essential: it's the first time Maryam goes into the city alone, encounters Tariq outside the flat, and begins constructing alibis. Chapter VI ("The Radio") introduces the wider political reality through the family's response to news. Chapter VII ("The Wrong Reasons") and Chapter VIII ("Amina Covers") both develop the surveillance theme — Mrs Farah, the neighbourhood's watching eyes, Amina's silent knowledge. All necessary. But VII and VIII could be compressed. What's in VIII that VII hasn't already done? Amina's awareness of the affair is established in VIII, but the pantry scene in XIII does it far better. Consider whether VIII is earning its own existence or merely preparing for XIII.

Draft B trims the openings of several of these chapters, which helps. But the real solution isn't cutting — it's variation. One of these chapters needs to break the domestic pattern entirely. A chapter that follows Maryam outside the house for a sustained stretch, not on an errand but on something that forces her into a different register. The Nawal visit that never happens is the obvious candidate — but it can't happen because Nawal dies. What if one of these chapters gave us Maryam at the Khoury house *before* Semiramis? One afternoon with Nawal in which Nawal sees something in Maryam and says something Maryam doesn't want to hear? It would solve two problems at once: thickening Nawal before her death, and breaking the chapter rhythm in the novel's soft middle.

Hanna — the novel's ethical centre

Here is the uncomfortable truth about this novel: Hanna is a better person than either Maryam or Tariq, and the book knows it. He is decent, competent, kind in ways too structural to be recognised as kindness, and faithful in the sense that faithfulness, for him, is indistinguishable from being awake. He pays Ibrahim's school fees and leaves the receipt under the sugar bowl. He moves Huda's bed from the wall. He lists the women and children who might need transport south and folds the list into his pocket.

The novel never sentimentalises him and never softens him enough to make the affair seem justified. That's right. But there's a related risk: that Hanna becomes so irreproachably decent that Maryam's attraction to Tariq starts to look merely like a taste for wit, for intellectual companionship, for being "used accurately." This is a legitimate human motive, but it's not a sufficient one for the weight the novel places on it. The affair needs to carry the full force of a woman choosing something she knows will damage her — not because her husband is cruel, but because her husband's form of love has left her some essential part of herself unseen.

Both drafts gesture at this. The key lines: "She had never loved this quality in him. She had relied on it more times than she could remember." And: "Some men made themselves indispensable in order not to have to say who they were when they sat still." These are good. But the novel needs one scene — even a short one — in which Hanna fails Maryam not practically but humanly. Not a scene of cruelty. A scene of oblivion. A moment where she offers him something that isn't a task and he doesn't know how to receive it. Without that scene, the marriage feels like a climate Maryam endures rather than a relationship in which both people have contributed to the distance between them.

The title question

Draft A is titled "QATAMON First Draft." Draft B is titled "QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash." The title is right. It's the name of the neighbourhood, the name of what's lost, the name of what the key opens. It does what the best titles do: it names the thing that will be gone by the end.

Final word on the POV break in Draft B

Having now read the Tariq POV scene more carefully against the full novel, I'll sharpen my earlier position. The scene is necessary. Not the POV — the information. The reader needs to know that Tariq wrote the note, that the boy carried it, that the house was shut, that the note came back unopened, that he placed it under the mug and left. This information is what makes the ending work. Without it, the key in Maryam's hand is merely personal — a relic of her own guilt and desire. With it, the key becomes paired with the note: two objects of failed connection, one held by each person, neither knowing the other's exists in the same form.

The question is only delivery. Draft B gives it to us through Tariq's eyes. Draft A withholds it entirely. Neither is perfect. A third option: keep the scene but deliver it not through Tariq's direct consciousness but through reported action — the boy's account, perhaps, overheard or reported by Elias. This would preserve the novel's Maryam-centred POV while still giving us the essential facts. The reader would learn what happened to the note, but through the same secondhand channels by which all news arrives in this novel — parish boys, priests, folded slips. It would be formally consistent and emotionally complete.

But if the choice is binary — Draft A's omission or Draft B's POV break — Draft B is right.

REPLY VF II C II

The book lives closer to Draft B, but Draft B has not yet finished earning what it knows.

The two drafts are not two different novels. They are two phases of the same novel, and the vast majority of their prose is shared. What differs is mostly expansion, rebalancing, and a handful of passages where Draft B has done further work. The question is not which draft to choose. It is whether Draft B's additions and revisions consistently improve the book — and where they don't, what the book still needs.

I. Architecture: Does the structure hold?

Both drafts run twenty chapters across roughly five months of 1947–48 Jerusalem. The architecture is the same: death, papers, the slow entrance of Tariq, the social constriction around Maryam, Semiramis as rupture, the affair, the Nakba narrowing the world until the family is sleeping in a schoolroom and the key to Yusef's flat is the novel's final image.

The architecture holds. It is the novel's greatest achievement. The escalation from domestic grief to historical catastrophe is managed almost entirely through domestic objects — cups, spectacles, string, keys, maps folded under salt cellars — and the reader never feels the mechanism because it is disguised as life. The structure earns its ending because the ending is not an event but a subtraction: the key opens nothing, the room is gone, the choice has been removed before it was made. That is what the book is about — how history removes the space in which personal decisions could still be made — and the structure delivers it.

Where the architecture wobbles: both drafts suffer from a flattening in the middle chapters (roughly VII–VIII, "The Wrong Reasons" and "Amina Covers") where the postponement of the Nawal visit and the second Beirut letter cover similar emotional territory without sufficient escalation between them. The reader feels the mechanism of delay being demonstrated a

second and third time when they have already understood it. Draft B expands these chapters, which makes the problem more visible rather than less.

II. What Draft B solves

Draft B's chapter titles for XIII and XIV — "The Half-Emptied Flat" and "Less Room Than Before" — are better than Draft A's "The Price of Seeing" and "After." "The Price of Seeing" declares its theme aloud; "The Half-Emptied Flat" *is* the theme. The room's physical emptying doing the metaphorical work is exactly how this novel operates everywhere else, and the chapter title should follow that principle.

Draft B's opening of Chapter I is slightly better handled. Where Draft A gives us "Maryam stood in the doorway for a moment before going in, not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private," Draft B trims to "Maryam stood in the doorway a moment before going in. The house had already ceased to be private." The cut of "not because she was overcome" is correct. The novel should not explain what Maryam is *not* feeling. The reader doesn't need the disclaimer.

Draft B adds material to the Semiramis chapter (IX) that strengthens it — the detail about the telephone startling them more than the explosion "because telephones carried intention" is first-rate. So is the expanded moment of Hanna shaving as proof that sequence still holds. These are additions that pay their way.

Draft B's ending is also superior in a few precise ways. The addition of "That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether one had the right to keep them" after Maryam closes her hand around the key gives the key image a physical intelligence it needs. And the final paragraph's "Ordinary indignities persisted. So did ordinary mercies" before Leila's ankle is better than Draft A, which moves too quickly to the key on the desk. The rhythm needs that pause, that last breath of the communal before the private.

III. Where Draft A was better, or where Draft B overreaches

Draft B's Chapter XIV, "Less Room Than Before," opens with Maryam waking the morning after the affair. Draft A handles this more sparingly. Draft B adds the shawl from the flat draped over the chair and Maryam's impulse to hide it, plus Amina's line: "I took the brush to your coat again. The damp brought the cedar up." The Amina line is superb — Amina repairing the evidence *in the night* and returning it as clothing is one of the most devastating things in the book. Keep it. But the shawl business is one beat too many. The glove under the bed in the scene itself already does the work of the incriminating object. Adding the shawl dilutes by doubling.

In Draft A, the intimate scene at Yusef's flat has a line: "The first kiss was not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable. It was a mistake recognised as itself while being committed." Draft B trims this to "The kiss, when it came, was recognised as a mistake even as it continued." Draft B is tighter and worse. The word "theatrically" is doing something the replacement loses — it pushes back against the reader's potential expectation of romantic climax. The sentence needs to *deny* the reader the category of eruption. "Recognised as a mistake" is merely honest; "anything so theatrically solvable" tells the reader that the novel knows what it is refusing to be.

IV. The prose — what works

This prose is, at its best, extraordinary. The novel's great formal achievement is that its aphorisms emerge from character and never float free as authorial commentary. "Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention" — that is Maryam seeing Hanna, not the author seeing Hanna. "Bureaucracy does not object to death. It objects to incomplete death" — that is Tariq's voice, not an essayist's. "Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners" — that is the narrator's voice, but it has been earned by the preceding paragraphs of Maryam's self-examination.

The dialogue is uniformly excellent. Leila alone would justify the novel. "I do not like wise people." "Church is repetitive." "That seems arrogant." These are not cute child-lines; they are precision instruments. The child says true things without the apparatus of adult concealment, and the adults' silence after her statements is where the novel's deepest commentary lives.

Aunt Widad and Amina are the novel's two choral voices, and they function differently: Widad converts grief into management and calls it duty; Amina converts it into labour and calls it nothing. The line "She never wasted an answer when work could be used as an answer instead" defines Amina but also defines the novel's own aesthetic: it uses objects and actions where lesser novels would use statements.

V. The prose — what doesn't

The novel's besetting sin is the reflexive aphorism. When they land, they are devastating. When they don't, they sound like a narrator too pleased with their own intelligence. A few examples:

"One could live beside a man for years and still not know whether silence in him was absence or concealment." This is the sort of sentence that makes a reader nod but doesn't actually move anything forward. It tells us what we already know about Maryam and Hanna. Cut it or make it do work — attach it to a specific silence, a specific moment where she cannot read him.

"The world did not halt. It only incorporated the loss into a series of tasks." This appears after the burial. It's true. It's also the kind of statement that lets the reader feel wise without having had to do any work. The preceding detail — the spectacles on the sideboard, the cardamom — already *is* the observation. The abstract restatement weakens what the concrete details achieved.

There are also moments of slight over-explanation. When Hanna picks up and puts down Yusef's spectacles in Chapter I, the gesture is perfect. But then: "That small unfinished motion struck Maryam more sharply than any open show of grief would have done." The sentence explains the effect of the gesture, which the gesture has already had on the reader. Trust the gesture.

VI. Characters — what the book still hasn't solved

Tariq is the weakest of the principals. He is too perfectly calibrated. He never says the wrong thing, never overreaches, never fails at the exactness the novel attributes to him. "Men's motives are always smaller than women permit them to be" — that's a good line, but it's the same kind of good line he always delivers. He is defined by his absence of excess, which means the reader can admire him but never quite fear for him. In the Tariq's Mother chapter (XI), the novel gets closer to making him human — the chipped mug, his anger about the deed, his mother's cruelties — but even there he remains composed. The one moment where he becomes truly dangerous to the reader is "Not only because of the radio." That half-confession works because it is the only time his control visibly cracks. The novel needs two or three more such moments.

Hanna, by contrast, is the book's most complete creation. He is never once described as loving, yet by the end the reader loves him more than any character in the novel, including Maryam. The school fees under the sugar bowl. The spectacles he picks up and cannot clean. The hat he leaves unbrushed the morning of Deir Yassin. The list where he writes "Carried" instead of "Saved." Every one of these is a faultless piece of characterisation. Hanna *is* the novel's moral centre, and the fact that the novel never says so is what makes it true.

The mother is brilliantly done. "Let Leila cough piously" is one of the funniest and most heartbreaking lines in the book. She is never merely comic. Her vanity and her rigidity are forms of survival, and the novel knows it.

Amina is the character the novel relies on most and understands least. She is labour, observation, and conscience, but we never learn what she risks by crossing the quarter to reach this house, or what her own household looks like, or what it costs her to repair Maryam's coat in the night without comment. The novel uses her constantly as moral

instrument without ever quite granting her interiority. I am not asking for a chapter from her point of view — the novel's close third through Maryam is correct — but I am asking for one moment where Maryam sees *Amina's* cost rather than merely benefiting from her discretion.

VII. Does the reader want to keep reading?

Yes. From the first paragraph. The opening is one of the best I have read in a manuscript. "The drawing room had already been corrected for grief" — "corrected" is the novel in one word. The whole book is about the corrections people make to rooms, faces, sentences, and lives under pressure.

The only places where momentum slows are the middle chapters of postponement (VII–VIII) and certain passages where the aphoristic narrator gets between the reader and the scene. The novel's pace is otherwise managed with great skill — it never rushes, but it also never wastes a scene. Every chapter has a task, and the tasks build.

VIII. The ending

Both drafts end the same way. Draft B's version is slightly better for the reasons noted above. But both earn the ending. The key on the desk is the right final image because it contains everything the novel has been about — access denied, love unresolved, domesticity displaced, objects outlasting the arrangements that gave them meaning. The key opens nothing. That is the sentence the entire novel has been building towards.

IX. Final assessment

Draft B is the draft to work from. Its additions mostly improve the book. Its chapter titles are better. Its ending is slightly superior. But it needs to be cut back in specific places — the shawl in XIV, some of the reflexive aphorisms, the slight overexpansion in VII–VIII — and it needs to address the Tariq and Amina problems noted above.

This is a very good novel. It is not yet a great one, but the distance between those two things is shorter than the distance most manuscripts have to travel. The prose is controlled, the structure is earned, the ending is true, and the domestic detail is so precisely observed that the political catastrophe arrives without ever having to announce itself. That is a rare achievement.